

Polarizing Effects of Political Attacks on the Press: Evidence from Israel*

Alexandra A. Siegel[†] Chagai M. Weiss[‡]

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Abstract

Political attacks on the press are common in polarized societies, yet their effects remain underexplored. We conceptualize such attacks as rhetorical efforts to delegitimize and constrain journalists, and theorize that they polarize politics by shaping journalists' reporting and citizens' media consumption and attitudes. We estimate the effects of political targeting of radio hosts in Israel using an event-study design, finding suggestive evidence of an immediate but short-lived increase in anti-government content among targeted hosts. We then implement survey-based selection and evaluation tasks, revealing how political attacks on the press polarize the consumption and evaluation targeted journalists' content. Finally, through an information experiment we show that learning about attacks does not affect government supporters, but increases opposition supporters' preferences for social distance from outpartisans and concerns about democratic backsliding. Our findings highlight how attacks on the press may shift media production, consumption, and political attitudes, creating a reinforcing cycle of polarization.

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[†] Associate Professor, University of Colorado Boulder.

[‡] Assistant Professor, and Andrea and Charles Bronfman Chair in Israel Studies, University of Toronto.

Introduction

On December 1, 2024, a social media channel closely affiliated with the Likud—Israel’s ruling party—published a list ranking national public radio hosts by their loyalty to the governing coalition. Most hosts were labeled as anti-government, and the ranking coincided with legislation to privatize parts of the public broadcaster. Golan Yochpaz, CEO of Kan—the Israel Public Broadcasting Corporation—condemned the labeling of journalists as a “McCarthyist” threat to the freedom of press and democracy. More generally, this behavior was widely viewed by the traditional media establishment as a deliberate attack attempting to undermine the legitimacy of targeted journalists.¹

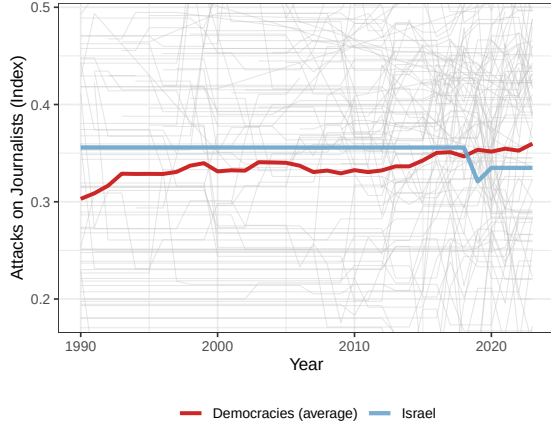
Political attacks on the press, which we conceptualize as *public rhetorical efforts by political actors to delegitimize and constrain journalists in an attempt to influence the production, circulation, or reception of political information*, unfold across a diverse set of contexts, often implemented by a range of political actors, taking various forms. These attacks undermine principles of mutual respect and independence crucial for the circulation of credible information in democratic societies (Cook, 2012; Sparrow, 1999). They are therefore understood to be a salient violation of democratic norms (Van Dalen, 2021), with a potential to undermine core foundations of liberal democratic societies (Rogenhofer and Panievsky, 2020).

As demonstrated in Figure 1a, the targeting of Israeli journalists is part of a global pattern of political assaults on the media. Increasingly, across regime types, journalists and media outlets have been subject to various attacks ranging from public vilification and legal pressure to economic manipulation and, in some contexts, violence against journalists (Relly and González de Bustamante, 2015; Reporters Without Borders, 2024; Howard and Hussain, 2010; Stoycheff and Nisbet, 2020; Benkler, Faris and Roberts, 2018; Bonello-Ghio and Nasreddin, 2022). Indeed, from Europe and the United States to Latin America and the Middle East, populist elites increasingly denounce the press, portraying mainstream journalism as biased or corrupt, and employing labels like “fake news” to cast reporters as “enemies of the people” (Davis and Sinnreich, 2018; Krämer, 2018; Vallone, Ross and Lepper, 1985; Panievsky, 2022). Coinciding with the rise of attacks on the press, Figure 1b reports heightened levels of polarization across the globe, and Figure 1c suggests that these two patterns may be interrelated.²

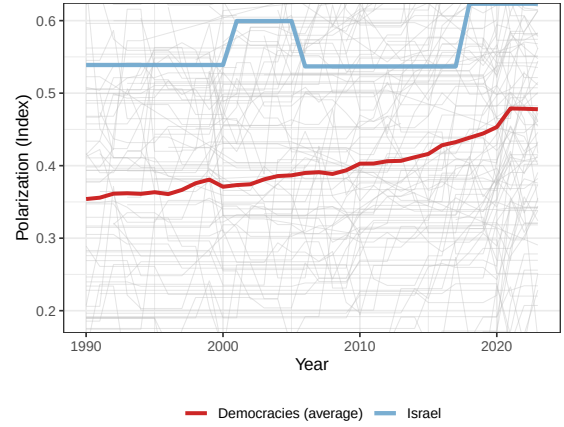
Motivated by these descriptive patterns, we ask: what are the consequences of political attacks on the press? Despite the growing prevalence of such attacks, and increasing academic attention to their consequences, whether and how political attacks on the press polarize politics remains unclear for conceptual, theoretical, and empirical reasons. Conceptually, most existing studies focus

¹For more information, see: https://www.calcalist.co.il/local_news/article/hjbmdcymjl. (Last accessed October 14, 2025.)

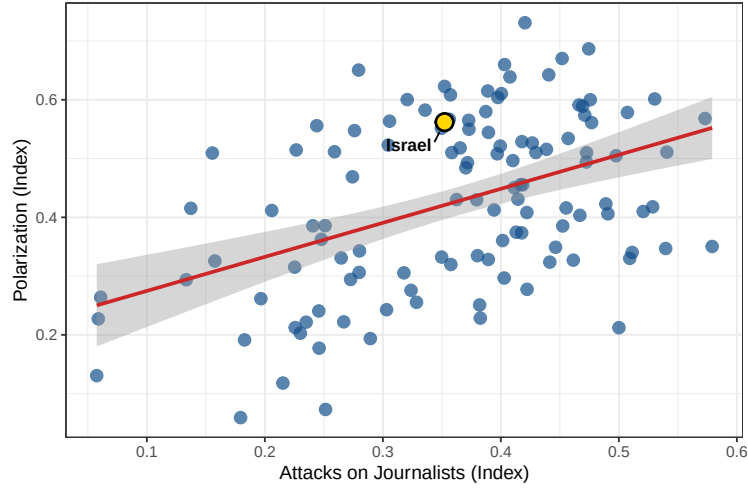
²The blue lines in panels a) and b) show Israel’s trajectory relative to aggregate cross-national patterns, indicating that Israel is a highly polarized country where attacks on the press are, for the most part, above the democratic average. Panel c) highlights Israel’s position within the cross-national distribution of both variables.



(a) Attacks on Journalists Over Time



(b) Polarization Over Time



(c) Attacks on Journalists and Polarization

Figure 1: Attacks on Journalists and Polarization in Democracies Around the World. This Figure reports data from V-Dem (Coppedge et al., 2025). Panel (a) reports the global average score of V-Dem’s journalist harassment index over time (`v2mehar_jrn`), reverse-coded). Panel (b) reports the global average score of V-Dem’s political polarization index over time (`v2cacamps`). Panel (c) reports the bi-variate correlation of both variables ($\rho = 0.617$, $p < 0.001$). We focus on electoral and liberal democracies as coded by the `v2x_regime` variable in the V-Dem data.

on specific types of attacks that vary substantially in their core attributes. For example, [Stanig \(2015\)](#) examines media freedom restrictions, while [Archer and Peterson \(2025\)](#) study partisan accusations of outlets as biased ([Archer and Peterson, 2025](#)). However, we lack both a clear definition of political attacks on the press and an account of the core dimensions on which they vary, rendering knowledge accumulation across studies challenging. Theoretically, existing studies focus on the consequences of attacks for specific actors and outcomes. For example, [Panievsky \(2022\)](#) considers journalists’ self-censorship in response to political targeting, whereas [Archer and Peterson \(2025\)](#) examine audiences declining trust in media in response to partisan attacks on specific outlets. While informative, these studies rarely connect the numerous consequences of political attacks, and we lack a unified framework to consider the multiple, potentially reinforcing, consequences of political attacks on the press. Empirically, though studies on the consequences of violent targeting and institutional restrictions on media freedom draw on design-based approaches to provide causal evidence under well-defined assumptions ([Jurado and Morales, 2026](#); [Stanig, 2015](#)), most studies on more discursive and less violent political attacks—which are increasingly common across democracies ([Rogenhofer and Panievsky, 2020](#))—rely on descriptive evidence ([Panievsky, 2022](#); [Van Dalen, 2021](#); [Krämer, 2018](#)), or focused survey experiments with few outcomes ([Archer and Peterson, 2025](#)). Thus, the overall effects of political attacks require further empirical attention.

In this paper, we attempt to address these conceptual, theoretical, and empirical issues, and extend our understanding on the polarizing consequences of attacks on the press. We begin by developing a broad conceptual definition of political attacks on the press, and clarifying key dimensions along which such attacks vary across contexts. We then theorize how political attacks on the press may polarize politics. Specifically, we highlight three interrelated mechanisms. First, attacks may shape the news content that journalists supply, either by discouraging engagement with sensitive political topics—resulting in a silencing effect—or by prompting more critical coverage of the government—resulting in a backlash effect. Second, attacks may shape media consumption and content evaluation patterns, encouraging selective exposure and biased interpretations of journalistic content, motivated by citizens’ ex-ante political preferences. Finally, political attacks on the press can directly affect citizens’ attitudes towards counter-partisans and shape their broader institutional trust and perceptions of democratic health.

To test the observable implications of our theoretical framework, we focus on the Israeli case, and report three complementary studies including an event-study identifying the effects of political attacks on the content produced by targeted (and non-targeted) radio hosts, survey-embedded selection and evaluation tasks through which we document how political attacks on journalists shape consumption and evaluation of media content, and an information experiment through which we identify the direct effects of information regarding a political attack on public attitudes and preferences.

These analyses yield three primary findings. First, we find no evidence that political attacks on the press have a chilling effect on journalists in our context. Instead, we observe suggestive evidence of an immediate, short-lived increase in anti-government speech among targeted journalists, suggesting that political attacks on the press may lead to a modest, short-lived backlash effect. Second, political attacks on journalists polarize media consumption and evaluation. Government supporters reduce their selection of targeted journalists' content by 34% of a control-group standard deviation, while opposition supporters increase theirs by 10%. Attacks also polarize broader evaluations of targeted journalists' credibility and content quality. Through two extension experiments, we demonstrate that these effects are mostly consistent across actor types, and that both government and opposition attacks on the press shape audiences selection and evaluation of media content in polarizing ways. Notably, these initial effects are likely mutually reinforcing—modestly and temporarily expanding the overall supply of anti-government media content (in the short term) while simultaneously polarizing its consumption and evaluation along partisan lines. Third, our final result suggests that beyond shifting media supply and demand, political attacks on the press also have a direct effect on political attitudes. We find that exposure to depictions of political attacks on the press heighten opposition supporters' preferences for social distance from outpartisans and concerns about democratic backsliding by 14% and 10% of the control group standard deviation respectively, and reduces their trust in government by 9% of the control group standard deviation. Government supporters' attitudes remain unchanged after exposure to depictions of attacks on the press, suggesting that such attacks may fail to strengthen support within a politician's base and may even prove counterproductive—intensifying partisan animosity, reducing trust in government, and heightening perceptions of democratic backsliding among opposition supporters.

By conceptualizing political attacks on the press, theorizing their multiple consequences, and empirically examining their capacity to polarize politics in Israel, we contribute to three lines of research. First, we contribute to work on the political causes and effects of attacks on the press (Van Dalen, 2021; Panievsky, 2022; Archer and Peterson, 2025). Recent accounts of this phenomena mostly focus on journalists' behaviors as an outcome, paying less attention to downstream effects on citizens' media consumption and evaluations or their broader political attitudes. Moreover, existing findings are mixed, with some studies pointing towards a silencing effect that minimize the prevalence of critical reporting (Holland and Rios, 2017; Bonello-Ghio and Nasreddin, 2022; Panievsky, 2022), while others suggesting that attacks on the press motivate backlash resulting in more critical content (Ozawa et al., 2024). Our conceptualization of political attacks highlights the importance of distinguishing the form an attack takes and of tracing its consequences for different actors, and our theoretical framework allows for a more comprehensive consideration of the multiple, potentially reinforcing consequences of attacks on the press. In this sense, our study is not the final word on the political consequences of attacks on the press, but rather a template that future

research should extend to compare how distinct forms of attack, from different actors, in different contexts, might shape political behavior, attitudes, and patterns of polarization in divided societies.

Second, we contribute to the literature on selective exposure to partisan media (Stroud, 2011a; Prior, 2013; Levendusky, 2013b,c; Broockman and Kalla, 2025b; Peterson, Goel and Iyengar, 2021). Past studies mostly focus on documenting patterns of selective exposure (Peterson, Goel and Iyengar, 2021; Broockman and Kalla, 2025b; Weiss, Siegel and Scacco, 2025), and identifying their downstream political effects (Levendusky, 2013c,a; Broockman and Kalla, 2025a). Other work focuses on the causes of selective exposure to partisan media, highlighting how structural changes in the media landscape (Levendusky, 2013b; Hmielowski, Beam and Hutchens, 2016; Grossman, Margalit and Mitts, 2022), alongside individual-level factors including consumers' ideology and psychological predispositions (Peterson and Kagalwala, 2021; Stroud, 2008; Iyengar and Hahn, 2009), contribute to rising patterns of selective exposure to partisan news. Complementing these accounts, we propose that political elites—and specifically their attacks on the press, which can affect both the supply of and demand for political news—may be an underappreciated cause of selective media exposure.

Finally, we contribute to the literature on partisan polarization and declining support for democratic norms and institutions (Iyengar et al., 2019; Gidron, Adams and Horne, 2020; Voelkel et al., 2024; Norris, van Es and Grömping, 2021; Lührmann and Lindberg, 2019; Graham and Svobik, 2022). Complementing recent studies demonstrating how elite rhetoric and behaviors may intensify partisan divides (Kim, 2025), or alternatively, depolarize the electorate (Weiss, Green and Willer, 2025; Bassan-Nygate and Weiss, 2022; Huddy and Yair, 2021), our findings suggest that elite's attacks on the press are an underappreciated cause of polarization. As we show through our studies, such attacks not only affect partisan preferences directly—by increasing preferences for social distance and concerns about democratic health among opposition voters—but also shift patterns of media consumption, and to a lesser extent production. As we describe towards the end of this paper, these latter effects may very well reinforce one another—increasing consumption of critical media among opposition supporters, while decreasing it among government supporters—further exacerbating existing patterns of polarization in divided societies.

Conceptualizing Political Attacks on the Press

We define political attacks on the press as rhetorical public efforts by political actors to delegitimize or constrain journalists, with the aim of influencing the production, circulation, or reception of political information. What distinguishes an attack from ordinary media criticism is its generalized delegitimizing and coercive form. Rather than contesting a specific report on its evidentiary merits, political attacks on the press target the credibility of the media, focusing on the messenger instead of their message.

Specifically, these attacks often employ generalized accusations that draw exaggerated, and often misleading distinctions between "good" and "bad" reporters, "fake" and "real" news, or "honest" and "corrupt" outlets. These attacks may also have an explicitly coercive dimension, threatening journalists or news organizations with limitations in access, as well as reputational or legal consequences as a means of inducing self-censorship or editorial compliance. Political attacks on the press are thus best understood not as contributions to public debate about political information, but as efforts to erode the legitimacy of the press as an institution.

Four Dimensions of Political Attacks on the Press

Our broad definition encompasses a wide range of political attacks on the press. To provide further clarity, and situate our theory and evidence within this growing research agenda, we outline four dimensions along which these attacks vary. These dimensions, summarized in Table 1, relate to the perpetrator's identity, the instrument they employ, their targets, and the context in which attacks unfold.

First, political attacks on the press can be carried out by different actors, ranging from country leaders (e.g., Prime Minister Netanyahu's accusations that mainstream Israeli television channels brainwash viewers in an attempt to assist Israel's enemies ([Kraft, 2025](#))), government spokesmen (e.g., White House Press Secretary Karolin Leavitt's repeated labeling of mainstream reporters as "left-wing hacks" and "fake journalists" ([Rahman, 2026](#))), party networks and affiliated institutions (e.g., Hungary's Fidesz party, whose party-aligned Sovereignty Protection Office systematically characterized independent outlets as "foreign agents" ([European Centre for Press and Media Freedom, 2025](#))), or independent political influencers (e.g., Elon Musk's sustained campaign on X against legacy media in the run-up to the 2024 U.S. presidential election ([Zard, 2025](#))). Second, as the examples above suggest, political attacks on the press often vary in their content. Different actors, employ different instruments and behaviors to constrain and delegitimize journalists. Common instruments include unfounded accusations relating to journalistic integrity, allegations of subversive intentions, charges of alignment with enemies, and threats to reform the media, constrain journalists' freedom of press, and retaliate against critical reporting. Third, political attacks on the press vary in the target on which they focus. In an attempt to constrain and delegitimize the press, politicians can target the press as a whole ([Stanig, 2015](#)), specific outlets ([Archer and Peterson, 2025](#)), or individual journalists ([Panievsky, 2022](#)). Finally, political attacks on the press vary in terms of the context in which they unfold. Different attacks unfold in authoritarian, hybrid, and democratic regimes. Notably, the structure of political institutions may influence what attacks actors decide to deploy, as well as their potential to impact journalists and audiences.

Considering our broad definition, and these four dimensions, we develop a theoretical framework to explain how political attacks on the press influence journalists and audiences, and in turn

Table 1: Four Dimensions of Political Attacks on the Press

Dimension	Description	Key Variations	Our Focus
Actor	Who carries out the attack	• Country leaders • Government spokesmen • Opposition politicians • Party networks • Independent influencers	<i>Government politicians and affiliated partisan networks</i>
Instrument	Type of attack	• Accusations of bias • Allegations of subversive motives • Charges of alignment with enemies • Credible threats	<i>Rhetorical accusations and implied threats</i>
Target	Who or what is attacked	• The press as an institution • Specific outlets • Individual journalists	<i>Individual journalists</i>
Context	Institutional environment	• Authoritarian • Hybrid • Democratic	<i>Democratic, backsliding contexts</i>

This table summarizes the four dimensions of political attacks on the press. The rightmost column indicates the scope of attacks examined in this paper.

fuel polarization. We focus on attacks carried out by government politicians and their affiliated partisan networks, directed at specific journalists, and characterized by sweeping accusations of biased coverage—all within democratic, albeit backsliding, contexts. In a series of extension studies, we further consider the effects of attacks by opposition politicians, and in the Discussion and Conclusion, we elaborate on how theoretical expectations might diverge across other actor types, targets, forms, and political contexts.

How Attacks on the Press Polarize Politics

A rich conceptual and mostly descriptive literature considers how attacks on the press shape journalists’ reporting behavior. Some studies clarify the nature and dynamics of such attacks (Krämer, 2018), while other work considers how targeted journalists shift their reporting patterns (Panievsky, 2022; Ozawa et al., 2024). Other studies examine how political attacks on the press may reduce media trust, lower accuracy judgments, or diminish self-reported intentions to use targeted outlets (Van Duyn and Collier, 2019; Archer and Peterson, 2025; Pingree et al., 2018; Smith, 2010; Watts et al., 1999).

Importantly, however, the consequences of political attacks on the press for both media producers and consumers are rarely examined together, despite their close relationship and potentially reinforcing consequences. This limitation hinders our understanding of the broader political conse-

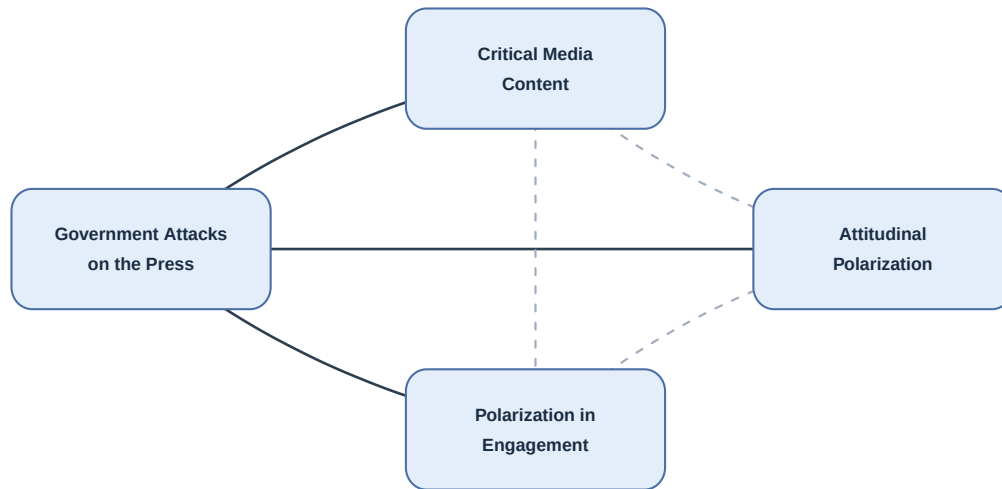


Figure 2: Theoretical framework linking government attacks on the press to political polarization. Solid lines denote relationships examined in this paper; dashed lines denote theoretically plausible relationships not directly tested.

quences of attacks on the press. If elite attacks on the press jointly affect the production of content by targeted journalists, as well as partisans’ political beliefs, and their willingness to consume media produced by specific journalists, then such attacks may be especially polarizing. However, theoretical frameworks and empirical investigations that focus on journalists or media consumers in isolation, may underemphasize such dynamics, and, in turn, underplay the political consequences of political attacks on the press. To address this and develop a more comprehensive theoretical framework, we examine how political attacks on the press influence journalists content production (media supply), as well as the public’s consumption and evaluation of political news (media demand), and their broader political attitudes and perceptions of democratic norms. We provide a visual depiction of our theoretical framework in Figure 2.

Media Supply

Political attacks on the press can shape the production of news—and specifically journalistic content—in diverging ways. On the one hand, such attacks can serve to silence criticism, reducing the volume of coverage that is critical of political elites. Indeed, in the shadow of attacks journalists and editors may avoid engaging with reporting on topics that will provoke attention, or official retaliation from the government or affiliated political elites (UNESCO, 2021; Bonello-Ghio and Nasreddin, 2022). Even without influencing formal editorial decisions, political attacks on the press may in-

duce self-censorship, altering the framing, tone, and sourcing of coverage in an attempt to reduce perceived risk (Besley and Prat, 2006; Pring and Canan, 1996). In some instances, these dynamics of re-framing and censorship can also lead journalists to “perform balance,” which can ultimately bias coverage in favor of parties that levy attacks on the press (Krämer, 2018; Panievsky, 2022).

Alternatively, political attacks on the press can spark backlash. Existing research emphasizes how “watchdog reporting,” which focuses on scrutinizing powerful elites is a central component of journalists’ professional identities (Mellado, 2015; Hanitzsch, 2011). The ability and social legitimacy to pursue such critical reporting is often theorized as a right that journalists continuously sustain by protecting their autonomy (Carlson and Lewis, 2015; Carlson, 2016). In turn, political attacks which pose a threat to journalists’ scope of practice may be met with resistance. Indeed, research from the Philippines suggests that in response to political attacks journalists increase their advocacy to preserve the freedom of press (Macaraig and Hameleers, 2022), while other work focused on Brazil suggests that targeted journalists double down on watchdog reporting, leading to increased prevalence of journalistic coverage which is critical of the political elites (Ozawa et al., 2024).

Taken together, we theorize that attacks on the press may either silence journalists or mobilize their critical reporting. Though we do not empirically test the conditions under which attacks generate silencing or backlash, drawing on our conceptual framework, we suggest that silencing is more likely when powerful state actors deploy coercive instruments or issue rhetorical attacks carrying credible implied threats against individual journalists, particularly in non-democratic contexts where such threats are backed by the real prospect of repression. Backlash, by contrast, is more likely in democratic contexts where institutional protections remain more intact, and where attacks from actors with limited coercive capacity focus on delegitimizing rather than threatening the press.

Moreover, expectations over audience preferences and reactions may also condition journalists’ responses to political attacks. In contexts where journalists anticipate that opposition audiences will reward critical coverage—through increased consumption, social media engagement, or expressions of solidarity—backlash may be more likely. Conversely, in contexts where journalists expect that critical coverage will primarily alienate government-supporting audiences without compensating gains, silencing may prevail. In this sense, the demand-side context may itself shape supply-side incentives, creating the potential for reinforcing dynamics between journalist behavior and audience responses.

These contextual possibilities, and the limited direct evidence identifying the effects of attacks on the press on targeted journalists’ reporting patterns motivate the first component of our empirical analyses. However, as noted above, attacks on the press may affect not only the supply of, but also the demand for, critical journalism. We thus turn to theorize how attacks on the press shape media

consumers' engagement with content produced by targeted journalists.

Media Demand and Evaluation

Turning to media demand and evaluation, we theorize that attacks on the press will shape which outlets and narratives citizens seek out and how they interpret coverage presented by targeted journalists. Our expectation draws on the literature on elite cues, which shows that politicians' rhetoric and behavior can shape partisan judgments and preferences (Lenz, 2009; Nicholson, 2012). Building on these findings, we anticipate that elite attacks on the press will serve as salient partisan and ideological signals, reinforcing and intensifying patterns of selective exposure.

In turn, supporters of the attacking actor may come to view targeted outlets as further biased or illegitimate, leading them to turn toward explicitly partisan-aligned information sources (Stroud, 2011b; Levendusky, 2013b). Supporting this expectation, Archer and Peterson (2025) find that exposure to a Republican politician's attack on a local newspaper dramatically reduces the public's trust in and intent to consume local news, particularly among Republican respondents. Conversely, opponents of the political actor may increasingly rely on attacked outlets as trusted watchdogs, reinforcing media diets concentrated on critical perspectives. Indeed, past research suggests that attacks on the press may increase loyalty, donations, or subscriptions among government opponents who seek to defend journalists under attack (Lichterman, 2016; Thompson, 2017; Fischer, 2017).

Importantly, such polarized responses to political attacks on the press may extend beyond outlet choice to the interpretation of content produced by various news organizations and media personalities. Past work suggests that exposure to attacks on journalists can activate hostile media perceptions, wherein audiences see neutral or balanced reporting as biased against their side (Vallone, Ross and Lepper, 1985; Gunther, 1992). Such polarization in engagement with, and interpretation of, journalistic content, can undermine the possibility of shared factual baselines, even when audiences consume the same information. Drawing on these insights, our primary theoretical expectation is that political attacks on the press will increase politically motivated media selection and evaluations of journalistic content. These combined consequences, may lead partisan and counter-partisans to inhabit increasingly distinct information ecosystems, and interpret similar information in diverging ways.

Notably, however, these effects may depend on the identities of attackers and audiences. A substantial body of evidence, primarily from the US context, documents that conservative voters express lower baseline trust in mainstream media than liberal voters (Ladd, 2012; Grossmann and Hopkins, 2016), and that right-wing populists have been particularly associated with anti-press rhetoric (Krämer, 2018). As described below, such patterns mirror the politics of media and information in the Israeli context. This may imply that attacks originating from right-wing political actors may be especially effective at polarizing media consumption and evaluation, because they

resonate with pre-existing skepticism toward the mainstream press among their supporters. We consider this possibility in our empirical analyses, and discuss the scope of our evidence and broader implications in our concluding remarks. However, before testing how attacks on the press shape patterns of media consumption and evaluation, we turn to lay out the final component of our theoretical framework considering the direct effects of such attacks on citizens' political attitudes and beliefs.

Political Attitudes and Beliefs

As noted above, attacks on the press may indirectly exacerbate polarization by altering patterns of journalistic reporting and shaping how consumers engage with and evaluate the content produced by targeted journalists. However, we theorize that beyond these indirect consequences driven by mechanisms of media supply and demand, attacks on the press can have a direct effect on mass attitudes, further exacerbating political polarization and shaping citizens' perceptions of democratic norms. We expect attacks on the press to directly polarize mass political attitudes for two primary reasons.

First, elite de-legitimization of the press can serve as a signal of weakened democratic norms (Van Dalen, 2021), especially when combined with other forms of institutional erosion (Levitsky and Ziblatt, 2018; Benkler, Faris and Roberts, 2018). For pro-government audiences, such signals may normalize past or future restrictions on media freedom and other behaviors that violate liberal democratic principles. For opposition audiences, attacks on the press may be perceived as clear indicators of democratic backsliding, heightening concerns about authoritarian drift and potentially mobilizing both concern and resistance (Norris, van Es and Grömping, 2021; Waisbord, 2020).

Second, elite attacks on the press can undermine both trust in the media and beliefs about its legitimacy. The polarization of media trust and perceptions of press freedom can contribute to a broader cycle of democratic fragility. Citizens who view media freedom as under threat may interpret other government actions—such as changes to electoral laws, judicial appointments, or restrictions on civil society—through a backsliding lens, even when these actions have ambiguous democratic implications. Over time, this can widen the gap between partisan assessments of whether democracy is functioning, fostering parallel political realities and undermining the legitimacy of democratic institutions (Lührmann and Lindberg, 2019).

Observable Implications

In light of the theoretical framework above, we expect political attacks on the press to shape journalists' reporting behavior, audiences' consumption and evaluation of news, and the public's broader political preferences and democratic attitudes. To evaluate these expectations, we present a series of complementary empirical studies that examine the multiple, and potentially reinforcing, effects

of government attacks on the press. Table 2 summarizes our theoretical expectations alongside the empirical strategies we use to test their observable implications.

Table 2: Theoretical Expectations and Study Descriptions

Study	Estimand	Expectation	Research Design
Study 1	Effects of attacks on media supply	Attacks on journalists may either silence or motivate journalists’ criticism of government.	Event-study analysis identifying effects of government attacks on Israeli radio hosts’ production of ant-government content.
Study 2	Effects of attacks on media demand and evaluation	Attacks on journalists will polarize the consumption and evaluation of media content.	Survey-based media selection and evaluation tasks considering how government and opposition attacks affect media consumption and evaluation of journalistic content.
Study 3	Effects of attacks on attitudes	Attacks on journalists will polarize mass political attitudes.	Information-based survey experiment identifying how information about a government attack on the press shapes political attitudes.

The Israeli Context

To test the observable implications of our theoretical framework turn to Israel. Our focus on the political consequences of Israeli elites’ attacks on the press is motivated by three factors: 1) the increasingly politicized nature of Israeli media, 2) persistent political attacks on journalists, and 3) heightened levels of polarization in recent years. Notably, as depicted in Table 1, by focusing on the Israeli case—a paradigmatic context of democratic backsliding—we empirically focus on attacks carried out by government politicians and their affiliated partisan networks, directed at specific journalists, and characterized by sweeping accusations of biased coverage and implicit threat. When extending our empirical analyses of how attacks shape media demand and evaluation, we demonstrate that opposition attacks on the press mostly generate symmetrical polarized effects.

Israel’s contemporary media landscape features a mix of public and private platforms. Until the 1990s, however, television and radio services were provided exclusively by a centralized public broadcaster (Schejter, 2022). A series of reforms and legislative changes in the 1990s opened these markets to private enterprise, producing a more populous and somewhat diverse media environment (Peri, 2004). Nonetheless, emerging channels continue to depend heavily on government

regulators (Panievsky, 2022). This ongoing reliance has led some scholars to argue that “a major characteristic of both media regulatory actions and the actors in the media environment is the existence of purportedly commercial government mouthpieces” (Schejter, 2022, p. 152). In that sense, while freedom of press is legally protected in Israel (Schejter, 2022), direct and indirect forms of political influence on journalistic slant and content are by no means marginal (Grossman, Margalit and Mitts, 2022; Schejter, 2022).

Politicians’ attempts to influence media reporting in Israel have taken different forms, ranging from alleged propositions to provide regulatory benefits in exchange for positive coverage (Schejter, 2022), through formal interference in headline selection in pro-government media outlets (Grossman, Margalit and Mitts, 2022), to outright attacks on critical journalists (Panievsky, 2022). Indeed, a central feature of Netanyahu’s cumulative eighteen years as Prime Minister—spanning multiple non-consecutive terms from 1996 to the present—has been the persistent framing of mainstream private and public media outlets as politically biased, unrepresentative, and motivated by personal vendettas against him (Peri, 2004; Panievsky, 2022). This populist sentiment, manifesting in countless explicit attacks on the press, has motivated the introduction of pro-government and right-wing outlets into the Israeli media ecosystem (Peri, 2004; Grossman, Margalit and Mitts, 2022). As outlets such as Israel Hayom (a free daily newspaper closely associated with Netanyahu) and Channel 14 (a right-leaning television network that has become a platform for governing coalition politicians) have gained increasing popularity, the Israeli media landscape has become increasingly partisan.

Alongside rising politicization in the Israeli media landscape, mass polarization has intensified among the Israeli public in recent years (Bassan-Nygate and Weiss, 2022, 2020; Gidron, Sheffer and Mor, 2022). Such polarization, which has been extensively documented using longitudinal survey data (Amitai, Gidron and Yair, 2023), has gained especially high-salience in light of recent democratic backsliding reforms led by Netanyahu’s 36th government (Gidron, 2023), and its contentious management of the Israel-Gaza war (Elran and Shapira, 2024). Whether or not rising polarization in Israeli society may be a consequence, at least in part, of political attacks on the press, is a topic we now turn to empirically investigate.

Study 1: How Political Attacks Shape Media Supply

Building on the framework above, we posit that political attacks can alter journalistic content. On one hand, such attacks may heighten the perceived costs of critical reporting and induce silencing or self-censorship—reducing general output rates or softening critical coverage. On the other, political targeting may provoke backlash, prompting journalists to double down and increase their critical content (UNESCO, 2021; Pring and Canan, 1996; Besley and Prat, 2006).

To adjudicate between these diverging expectations, we leverage a difference-in-differences

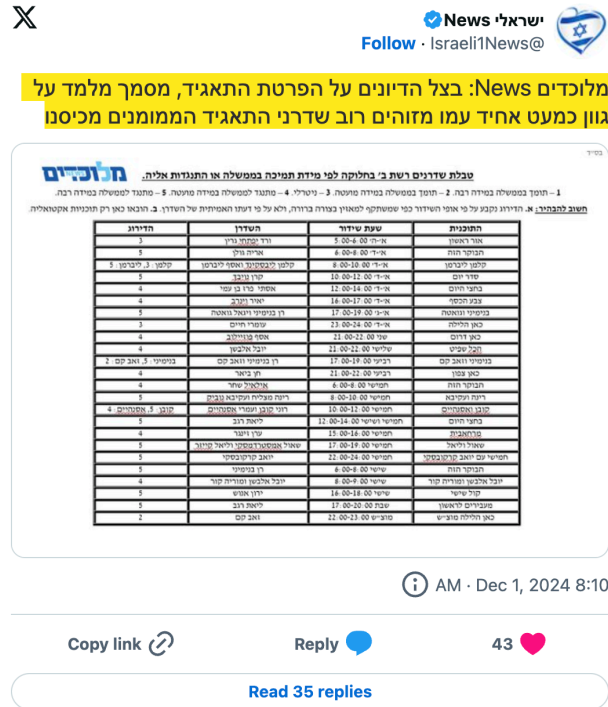


Figure 3: **Israeli radio host rankings published by Melukdaim News on December 1, 2024.** The list rates hosts on a 1-5 scale, where 1 denotes “especially pro-government” and 5 denotes “especially anti-government.” Most hosts received a score of 5; no host received a score of 1.

event-study design centered on the publication of a Likud-affiliated list ranking journalists according to their level of government support. As noted in the Introduction, on December 1, 2024, *Melukdim News*—a Likud-affiliated multi-media outlet managed by Avi Ravina, which delivers political content via a monthly journal, an online newsletter, 72 WhatsApp groups, Facebook, TikTok and Telegram—published a list of Israeli radio hosts from the Kan network (Israel’s main public network) ranked from 1-5 according to their level of support for Netanyahu’s ruling government. As shown in Figure 3, the ranking focused on the majority of radio hosts in the Kan network. Most radio hosts were outed as “especially anti-government” (i.e., a rating of 5/5), while a few hosts were identified as neutral or modestly pro-government (i.e., a rating of 2-3/5), and not a single host was described as “especially pro-government” (i.e., a rating of 1/5).

Beyond its circulation in numerous Likud party and pro-government media channels, the list attracted a great deal of attention from the Israeli media establishment and was covered by most mainstream outlets as a serious assault on freedom of the press (Guetta, 2024; Cohen, 2024). We leverage the timing in which this list was distributed, as well as its differential implications for various radio hosts in Israel, to examine how attacks on the press affect radio content among targeted hosts. Notably, the nature of the event on which we focus allows us to examine the effects of an attack by a political organization closely affiliated with the Likud, an increasingly populist-right

wing governing party in Israel. Specifically, in our main analysis we compare targeted radio hosts (who received a 3-5 score on the list depicted in Figure 3)³, with a sample of non-targeted radio hosts in the Kan network as well as other popular networks, and track the count of paragraphs containing polarized anti-government content (negative references to coalition actors or positive references to opposition actors). Under the parallel trends assumption, this design allows us to test whether attacks on the press primarily chill critical speech (silencing and self-censorship) or instead trigger a short-run increase in critical output (backlash).

Data and Measurement

The data for this study include the content of radio shows produced by targeted and non-targeted radio hosts between November 14 and December 14, 2024. Our unit of analysis is the radio show, and our data includes a total of 22 Kan radio shows hosted by journalists who were included on the publicly distributed list and were not labeled by the Likud as pro-government. Our control group includes 38 shows: one Kan show whose host received a positive rating from the Likud, as well as shows hosted by radio journalists from two non-targeted stations—103FM (18 shows) and Galatz (19 shows)—that are similar in format and audience reach.

To compile this data, we built web scrapers to download MP3 audio files for all episodes produced by treated and control hosts between November 14 and December 14, 2024, covering the two weeks before and after the list was leaked. This yielded 184 treated episodes from 22 Kan shows, 5 control episodes from Kan shows, 134 control episodes from 19 Galatz shows, and 1,693 (shorter and more frequent) control episodes from 18 103FM shows. We transcribed all audio into Hebrew using Amazon Web Transcribe, producing 25,251 paragraphs (three-sentence chunks) from treated hosts and 44,777 from control hosts. This enables us to measure the total volume of content produced by targeted and non-targeted radio hosts over time.

Our primary outcome of interest is the prevalence of anti-government content produced by targeted and non-targeted radio hosts before and after the attack. To measure this, we first constructed Hebrew-language dictionaries to detect content relevant to the coalition government (keywords related to Prime Minister Netanyahu, his family, Likud ministers, and the Likud party).⁴ Paragraphs containing at least one dictionary term were flagged as potentially relevant to our outcome of interest. We then applied the `openai` R package with the “gpt-4-turbo” model to classify each relevant paragraph’s *topic polarity* (positive, negative, neutral) and *framing* toward the coalition government.⁵ To measure anti-government content we count the number of paragraphs (3 sentence

³In Appendix D.4, we show that results are robust to alternative treatment definitions: a stricter cutoff restricting the treated group to scores of 4-5, a broader definition treating all Kan hosts as targeted, and a continuous specification using the Likud score as a treatment-intensity variable.

⁴See Appendix A.1 for dictionary terms.

⁵See Appendix A.2 for prompt text.

chunks) in each radio show containing negative references to government/coalition actors. Table 3 provides examples of paragraphs classified as anti-government, comprising our primary outcome of interest. We validate our LLM classification by training two native-Hebrew speaking RAs to manually code random samples of our data. We find that our RAs had on average 88% intercoder agreement with one another, compared to an average of 83% agreement between the RAs and the GPT codings. The high rate of agreement we observe between our RAs and the LLM coding, just 5% lower than the agreement we observe between trained graduate student RAs, increases our confidence in this measurement approach.⁶

Table 3: Examples of anti-government content with English translations (from randomly selected sentence ids).

Category	Sentence ID	English translation
Anti-government	38827	We are witnessing attempts to undermine the strength of the judiciary and to weaken it. Some of these attempts have been explicitly declared by various figures in the Knesset [Israeli parliament] and in the government.
Anti-government	23766	I work on this all the time. I think we have a government that is not okay... and I think this is truly the first time a government in Israel is abandoning hostages.
Anti-government	5299	I think this is a very bad law; anyone who grew up in the system understands that it... opens the door to interference by the political echelon, fundamentally changing the principles of the work that are tied to the job.

Empirical Strategy

Since most radio shows in our sample do not broadcast on a daily basis, in our main analyses we aggregate shows into five-day periods. Thus our primary outcome of interest is Y_{it} : the total amount of polarized anti-government content aired in show i at time period t . Our aggregation of data to five-day time periods balances two objectives: minimizing time periods where specific shows do not air (by increasing the temporal scope of each observation), while maximizing granularity in our data (by ensuring that temporal scope is not too coarse), allowing us to estimate the immediate effects of the Likud attack on radio content. As we show in Appendix D, our main results are robust to alternative time aggregations and treatment measures.

Using this data, and under the parallel trends assumption, we employ a standard event-study

⁶To see agreement metrics broken down by each RA compared to one another and GPT, see Table A2 in the Appendix.

design. Our primary specification is:

$$Y_{it} = \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k \mathbf{1}\{t - t_0 = k\} \times \text{Treat}_i + \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \eta X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where Y_{it} is the amount of polarized anti-government content produced by radio show i during period t . $\mathbf{1}\{t - t_0 = k\}$ are event-time dummies which we interact with Treat_i , a treatment indicator, yielding our primary parameters of interest: β_k , the time-specific effects of treatment. Our main specification also includes show fixed effects (α_i) and time fixed effects (γ_t), as well as a control for the number of radio shows aggregated in each time period (ηX_{it}). Standard errors are clustered by radio show, the level at which treatment was assigned (Abadie et al., 2023). Our estimation strategy compares changes in treated shows’ outcomes before and after the attack to changes over the same period for control shows, allowing the dynamic β_k coefficients to trace treatment effects over time. The reference period is $k = -1$.

As a robustness check, we also estimate dynamic treatment effects using the Callaway and Sant’Anna difference-in-differences estimator (Callaway and Sant’Anna, 2021). This approach is less sensitive than two-way fixed effects event studies to bias from treatment effect heterogeneity and negative weighting, and is well suited to settings with treated and never-treated units and potentially unbalanced panels. We implement the estimator using never-treated shows as the control group. This provides an alternative estimate of the post-attack trajectory of anti-government content under the same core identifying assumption of parallel trends between treated shows and control shows.

In Appendix D, we additionally assess the sensitivity of our conclusions to plausible violations of parallel trends using the “Honest DiD” framework proposed by Rambachan and Roth (2023). This procedure evaluates how large post-treatment deviations from parallel trends would need to be—relative to the magnitude of observed pre-trend differences—to overturn inference about the early post-attack effect. Together, the Callaway and Sant’Anna estimates and the Honest DiD sensitivity analysis help clarify how much our conclusions depend on the two-way fixed effects functional form and on the strength of the parallel trends assumption. More generally, they provide a conservative check on our interpretation of the primary estimates reported below.

Results

Across specifications, our results provide no evidence of a chilling effect on anti-government content among targeted radio hosts. Instead, we find suggestive evidence of an immediate, short-lived increase in anti-government rhetoric following the December 1 attack, displayed in Figure 4. In the first post-treatment period, the estimated effect of the attack is positive and statistically significant across all three aggregation schemes (3-day, 4-day, and 5-day specifications). Substantively,

using treated shows' pre-treatment means as baselines, we observe an increase of 30.8% in anti-government content in our main specification ($\beta_0 \approx 8.33$; pre-treatment mean ≈ 27.0).⁷ Later post-treatment point estimates remain generally positive but are smaller and imprecisely estimated, suggesting that any backlash effect is concentrated in the immediate aftermath of the attack rather than sustained over time.

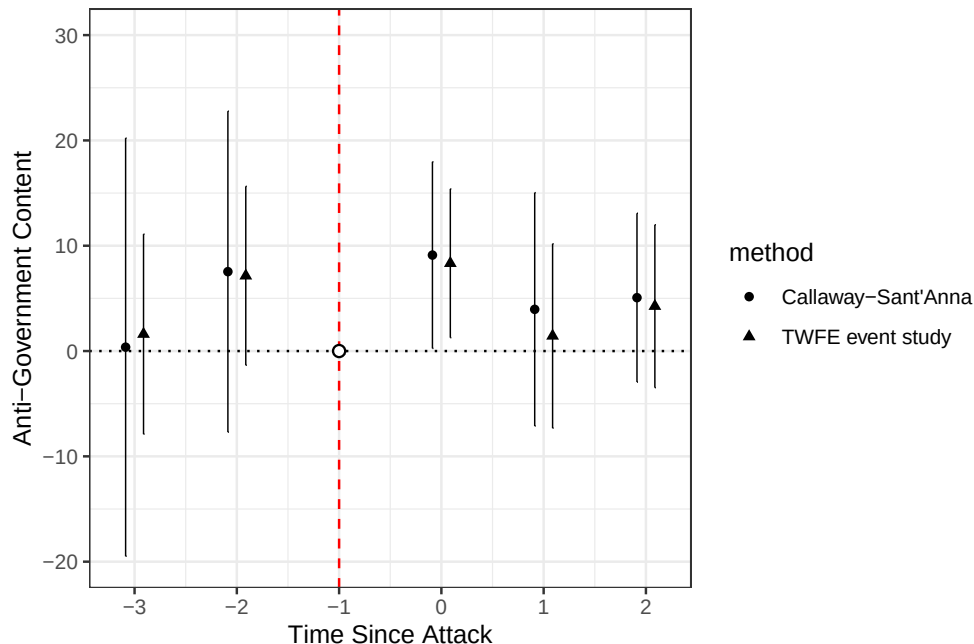


Figure 4: Effect of the Likud attack on radio hosts' production of anti-government content. This coefficient plot overlays dynamic estimates from two approaches using five-day aggregated data: 1) a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) difference-in-differences event-study specification with show and period fixed effects and a control for the number of shows included in each time period, and 2) the Callaway and Sant'Anna (CSA) DiD estimator. Standard errors are clustered at the show level. For the TWFE event study, estimates are shown relative to the reference period ($t = -1$). The CSA dynamic estimates do not rely on a single omitted reference period in the same way; however, we display them on the same event-time scale (including the visual marker at $t = -1$) to facilitate comparison across methods. The corresponding regression tables, along with results for alternative time aggregations and treatment measures are reported in Appendix D.

We complement our TWFE estimates with additional estimates using the Callaway and Sant'Anna framework, which is less sensitive than TWFE event studies to certain forms of specification bias and provides a useful robustness check even in a non-staggered setting. The Callaway-Sant'Anna estimates generally align with the TWFE results. The 5-day aggregation yields the clearest evidence of an immediate positive statistically significant post-attack response, while the 3- and 4-day

⁷In appendix D, we show that the immediate effects in response to treatment amount to 41.2% in the 3-day specification ($\beta_0 \approx 11.0$; pre-treatment mean ≈ 26.7), 33.8% in the 4-day specification ($\beta_0 \approx 9.16$; pre-treatment mean ≈ 27.1)

versions point in the same direction but are estimated less precisely. Because the magnitude of several pre-treatment coefficients is nontrivial relative to the immediate post-treatment estimate in some specifications, we evaluate the sensitivity of our primary analysis to potential violations of parallel trends using the Rambachan and Roth HonestDiD “relative magnitudes” approach. This exercise asks how large post-treatment trend deviations would have to be—relative to observed pre-treatment deviations—to overturn inference about the immediate post-attack effect. The results, displayed in Appendix D, show that our 5-day aggregation primary analysis remains significant up to deviations of $M < 0.3$ of the magnitude of the pre-treatment violations.

Together, these results provide suggestive evidence of backlash dynamics in response to politicized attacks on the press. These findings contrast with Panievsky (2022), who documents—based on semi-structured interviews with targeted Israeli journalists—that reporters adopt strategic bias in response to political pressure, adjusting their framing to mitigate conflict with political elites in ways that can produce a silencing effect. Three factors may help reconcile these diverging results. First, the two designs capture different quantities. Our event-study design measures *revealed* content choices rather than self-reported intentions, and focuses on the immediate aftermath of a specific, publicly visible attack rather than on journalists’ responses to sustained, diffuse political pressure. Second, the designs differ in their basis for comparison. Panievsky’s interview-based approach examines journalists who experienced political pressure without a counterfactual group of non-pressured journalists, making it difficult to distinguish accommodation from baseline editorial choices. Our design provides such a comparison, contrasting content produced by targeted and non-targeted journalists before and after the attack. Third, the two settings may elicit different responses. The acute, public nature of the Melukdim list may have triggered a boundary-maintenance response—an immediate assertion of professional independence—that differs from the gradual accommodation Panievsky describes under chronic political pressure.

Taking advantage of the richness of our observational data, we conduct several additional analyses to further characterize this backlash effect and explore alternative mechanisms. First, we decompose the aggregate anti-government content measure into its constituent entity-specific components—anti-government, anti-Netanyahu, and anti-Likud content—and re-estimate the event-study specifications for each (Appendix D.5). We also estimate separate event studies for pro-opposition and pro-protest content to test whether the backlash manifests not only through criticism of the government but also through increased positive coverage of opposition actors. The results show that the backlash effect is driven primarily by anti-government content broadly, rather than by criticism directed at any specific political figure or party, and we find no significant effects on pro-opposition or pro-protest content. An unsupervised topic model (BERTopic) applied to the anti-government sentences confirms that the thematic composition of government criticism shifts in parallel across targeted and non-targeted shows, tracking the evolving news cycle rather than

reflecting differential changes in the type of content aired (Appendix D.6). We also descriptively test for indirect chilling effects among non-targeted journalists and find no evidence that the attack altered anti-government content on shows whose hosts were not included on the Melukdim list (Appendix D.7). Finally, we examine whether journalists discussed the attack itself both on air and on personal social media. While both targeted and non-targeted shows increase their coverage of press-freedom themes after the attack, non-targeted shows do so at a notably higher rate (Appendix D.8). Moreover, of the 26 journalists on the Melukdim list, only one directly referenced the attack on personal social media during the month that followed (Appendix D.8). Together, these patterns suggest that targeted journalists channeled their response through substantive government criticism in their professional coverage rather than through meta-commentary about the attack itself.

While our event-study design identifies changes in the content that targeted journalists produce, it cannot establish how audiences respond—whether they seek out or avoid content by targeted journalists, and whether they evaluate it differently. Moreover, to the extent that attacks reshape audience composition, this may itself feed back into journalists’ incentives and reinforce the supply-side dynamics documented above—underscoring the importance of examining audiences’ responses alongside those of journalists. We therefore turn to a complementary study of audience behavior, examining whether, beyond their immediate suggestive effects on journalists, government attacks on the press shape consumers’ demand for and evaluation of political media.

Study 2: How Political Attacks Shape Media Consumption

As we describe in our theoretical framework, attacks on the press may operate as salient cues that influence which media content audiences select to read, how they engage with it, assess its quality, and evaluate its tone. To test these propositions, and further evaluate the consequences of attacks on journalists we designed two complementary experiments. Study 2a focused on evaluating how government attacks on journalists affect consumers’ *selection* of media content, whereas Study 2b focused on how attacks on journalists affect consumers’ *engagement* with media content.⁸ To further examine the extent to which attacks serve as cues, and consider the role of the actor who carries them out, we also conduct extension studies, which examine the effects of both government-led and opposition-led attacks on the same outcomes of interest.

⁸Both studies, as well as Study 3, were implemented in the same survey. We randomized the order of Studies 2a-2b, which were followed by Study 3. This design choice was taken in order to avoid order effects among the two complementary studies, and avoid priming respondents with the information treatment in study 3.

Study 2a: Attacks on Journalist and Patterns Media Selection

Research Design

As part of Study 2a, respondents were invited to participate in an incentivized knowledge task. In this task, respondents were informed that they will be asked two questions about contemporary events relating to either the Israeli Judicial System or Biotech Sector,⁹ and that if they correctly answer all questions, they will enter a 100 NIS lottery. Respondents were further informed that the questions they will answer are relatively specific, and therefore, they can select to read recent news articles on the topic from a variety of journalists.

After receiving information about the knowledge task, respondents were presented with a list of four (fictitious) Israeli journalists named Oren Faran, Tamar Aharon, Sharon Yashar, and Adam Levi. This list included a brief description of journalists' professional histories. In order to measure respondents' media consumption patterns and selection behavior directly, we informed respondents that as part of the knowledge task, they may select up to three journalists whose content they may read, to increase their likelihood of correctly answering the knowledge questions that follow. We combined a choice constraint—requiring participants to select three out of four journalists—with a meaningful financial incentive—amounting to 100 NIS lottery—in order to induce costly selection as part of our task.

To implement our primary treatment, we randomized whether Oren Faran's biographical information included a mention of him being attacked by various Likud officials, including prime-minister Netanyahu. Our primary outcome of interest records whether a respondent chooses to read content created by Oren Faran as part of the knowledge task. For ease of interpretation, we standardize this outcome so that the control group has a mean of 0 and a standard deviation of 1.

To estimate the effects of information regarding Likud attacks on respondents' selection of Oren Faran's journalistic content, we employ a pre-registered OLS regression, with HC2 robust standard errors. Specifically, we regress our primary outcome of interest (selection of Faran's media content as part of the knowledge task) over a binary treatment indicator (taking a value of 1 for respondents receiving information about the targeting of Oren Faran, 0 otherwise), which is further interacted with demeaned covariates (ideology, age-category, religiosity, gender, locality) and secondary treatments (to which respondents is assigned at the start of the survey) to increase precision (Lin, 2013). Following our pre-registration plan, we report the ATE for the full sample, as well as CATEs for government and opposition supporters.

⁹We randomized the topic of the task to focus on either political or non-political domains, and report CATEs by domain in Appendix E.4.

Results

In Figure 5, we report our main estimates for the effects political attacks on respondents’ choices in the knowledge task. The top panel of Figure 5 shows that respondents who received information about Likud attacks against Oren Faran were less likely to consume his content. However, this relatively modest effect, amounting to 7.6% of the control group standard deviation, masks significant heterogeneity in responses to treatment.

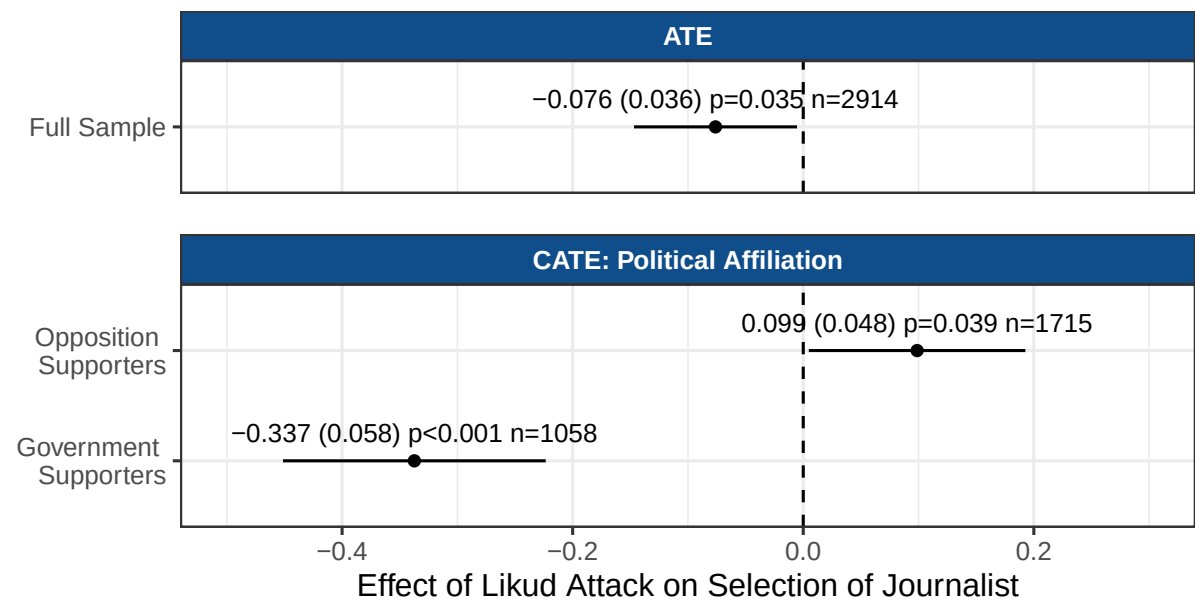


Figure 5: **Media attacks reduce overall consumption of articles written by targeted journalists, and polarize voters in their media selection.** This Figure reports point estimate and corresponding 95% confidence intervals representing the effects of the political attack treatment on the probability that respondents’ select to read articles written by the targeted journalist. Table format results reported in Table A15.

Considering CATEs among government and opposition supporters reveals stark polarization in responses to treatment. These additional analyses suggest that our main negative estimate is driven by government supporters who, in response to treatment, reduce their selection of articles written by Oren Faran by over a third of the control group standard deviation. In contrast, effects on supporters of the opposition are positive, albeit more modest, increasing selection of articles written by Oren Faran by 9.9% of the control group standard deviation. Importantly, the estimated difference in CATEs across subgroups is not only substantively significant—amounting to 44% of the control group standard deviation—but also estimated with high levels of precision ($p<0.01$). We therefore interpret this evidence to suggest that attacks on journalists can polarize patterns of media consumption, reducing consumption of content among government supporters and increasing it among opposition supporters.

Extension: Beyond Government Attacks on the Press

The results reported in Figure 5 emphasize the polarizing effects of *government* attacks on journalists. However, one might wonder whether attacks by other political actors have similar effects. Specifically, do attacks on journalists polarize consumption when they are carried out by politicians from opposition parties? We examine this question empirically through an extension study,¹⁰ implemented among 3,377 government and opposition supporters in Israel, in which we adopt a similar design, introducing a second treatment: an identical attack carried out by opposition politicians.¹¹ We provide further information on the design of the study, as well as sample descriptive statistics, balance tests, and diagnostics in Appendix E.5.

Introducing this second treatment allows us to replicate the three quantities of interest reported in Figure 5, alongside five new quantities of interest: 1) the overall effects of opposition attacks, 2-3) the overall effects of in-party and out-party attacks, and 4-5) the conditional effects of opposition attacks on government and opposition supporters. In our main analyses, we employ a similar estimation approach to the one adopted above,¹² and report our extension results in Figure 6.

Three main insights emerge from the results reported in Figure 6. First, in our full sample, attacks by both government and the opposition actors have similar effects, reducing consumption of content produced by the targeted journalist by 14-15% of the control-group standard deviation. Second, these aggregate estimates mask meaningful partisan variation, reported in the middle panel of Figure 6. Defining the treatment by the congruence between the attacker and the respondent, we find meaningful variation across treatment-types. Specifically, in-party attacks reduce consumption of content produced by targeted journalists by 35% of the control-group standard deviation, whereas out-party attacks do not shift overall selection patterns in aggregate.

Finally, turning to subgroup effects, we find that government supporters reduce their consumption of content by journalists targeted by the government by 48% of the control-group standard deviation, while opposition supporters reduce theirs by 24% when the attacker is an opposition figure. The larger effect among government supporters likely reflects both the authority of a sitting government official and the lower baseline media trust among this group.¹³ Moreover, consistent

¹⁰Using a different survey firm in Israel, named “Midgam”.

¹¹In this study, respondents assigned to government (opposition) attacks, are told that “several members of Likud (opposition block) have attacked his journalistic work, claiming that his reporting is politically motivated and characterized by a pronounced bias against the government (opposition). In addition, his name has appeared in publications by Likud (opposition) figures identifying him as a journalist who takes a particularly critical line toward the government.”

¹²Though, in analyses of the full sample, we include political block fixed-effects, since we block-randomized treatment within blocks of government and opposition supporters.

¹³Indeed, control-group estimates from our original study suggest that trust in traditional media outlets varies dramatically between government and opposition supporters. When asked how much they trust Kan 11 on a 0-100 scale, government supporters report a 35.3 average level of trust (95 CI: 32.7, 37.9), whereas opposition supporters report an average of 64.4 level of trust (95 CI: 62.4, 66.4). Differences across political blocks are substantive in magnitude and

with the evidence in Figure 5, government attacks have a small positive effect among opposition supporters, increasing their selection of content produced by targeted journalists. However, this pattern is not symmetric. The effects of opposition attacks on government supporters' selection behavior are small and imprecisely estimated. Taken together, the results in Figure 6 underscore how political attacks by both government and opposition actors can polarize the consumption of political information.

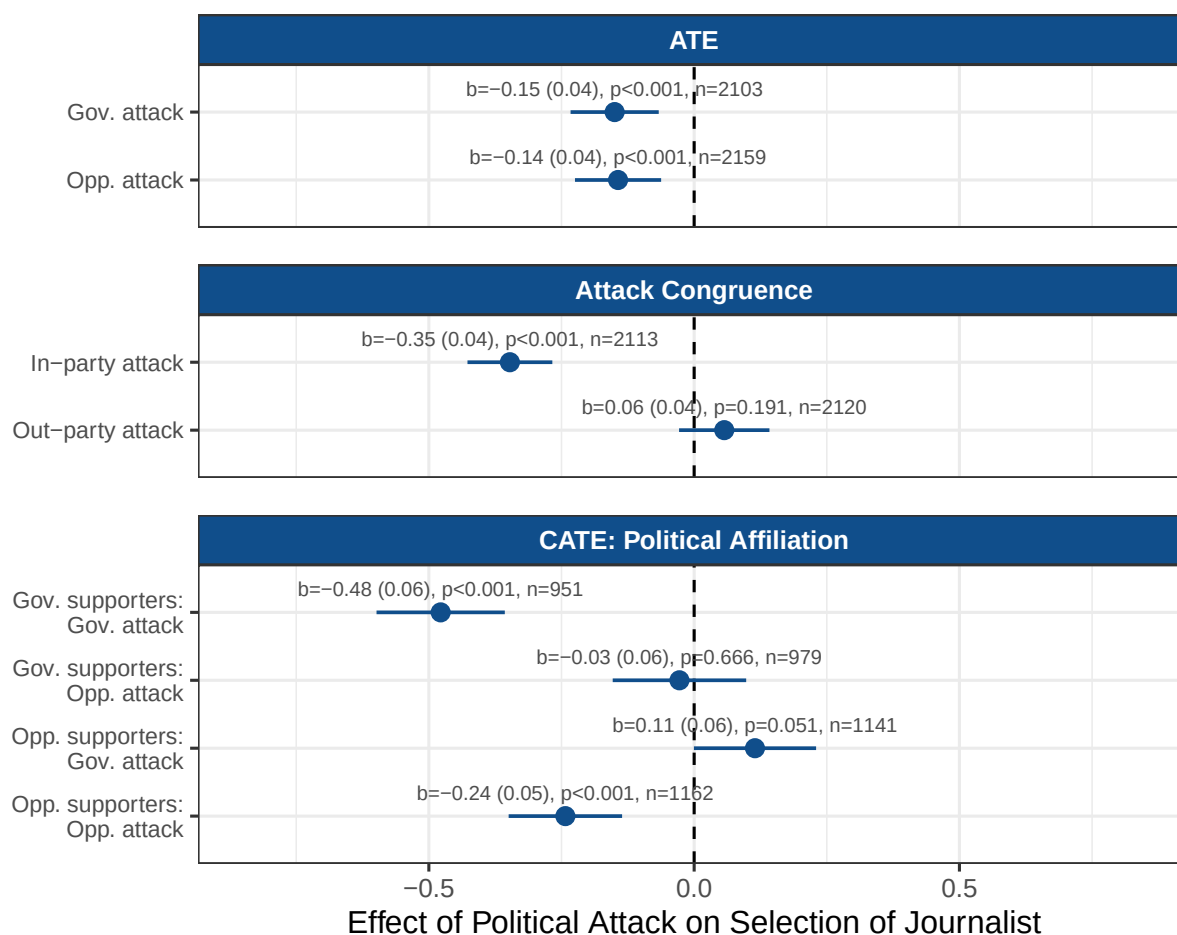


Figure 6: Media attacks by government and opposition actors reduce overall consumption of articles written by targeted journalists, and polarize voters in their media selection. This Figure reports point estimate and corresponding 95% confidence intervals representing the effects of government and opposition political attack treatments on the probability that respondents' select to read articles written by the targeted journalist. The top two panels compare a single treatment group against the control group, whereas the bottom panel focuses on subgroup effects of government and opposition supporters. Full regression results reported in Table A16.

precisely estimated ($p < 0.05$).

Study 2b: Attacks on Journalists and Evaluation of Media Content

Research Design

In Study 2b, we consider how attacks on journalists affect respondents' engagement with, and evaluation of their journalistic content. To do so, we designed an evaluation experiment where we asked respondents to read a brief news article regarding either the labor market impacts of AI or recent legal developments relating to Israel's contested conscription law.¹⁴ Respondents were informed that the article they will read was written by a (fictitious) Israeli journalist named Yariv Levi. All respondents received basic information describing Levi's professional background, and treated respondents were further informed that Levi has been the subject of political attacks by government officials, including a senior minister.

After receiving information about the task, respondents were directed to read a brief article, and then report primary outcomes of interest, including: i) three reading comprehension questions (which we combine into an additive knowledge retention index ranging from 0-3), ii) four evaluative measures eliciting respondents' willingness to share the article, as well as their perceptions of article objectivity, journalistic standards, and informative value (which we average into an index ranging from 0-100), iii) a measure of perceived pro-government slant (single 0-100 item), and iv) a measure of perceived pro-opposition slant (single 0-100 item). We standardize all outcomes, so that the control group has a mean of 0 and a standard deviation of 1, and employ the same specification used in Study 2a to estimate our primary treatment effects, as well as CATEs by governments and opposition support.

Results

In Figure 7 we report our primary estimates demonstrating how political attacks on journalists affect respondent's engagement with and evaluation of their journalistic content. We find that treated respondents who receive information about political attacks, are modestly less likely to retain the knowledge included in the article they read. On average control group respondents correctly answer 2.3 questions, compared with 2.2 correct answers among the treated. In Appendix E.4, we provide suggestive evidence that these effects may be driven by treated respondents spending less time reading the article to which they are exposed. Considering CATEs by political support, we find that exposure to treatment has a negative, albeit imprecisely estimated effect for both government and opposition supporters ($p > 0.1$), likely as a result of reduced power in our subgroup analyses, alongside generally small but homogeneous effects across subgroups.

¹⁴Like in Study 2a, we randomized the topic of the article to focus on either political or non-political domains, and report CATEs by domain in Appendix E.4.

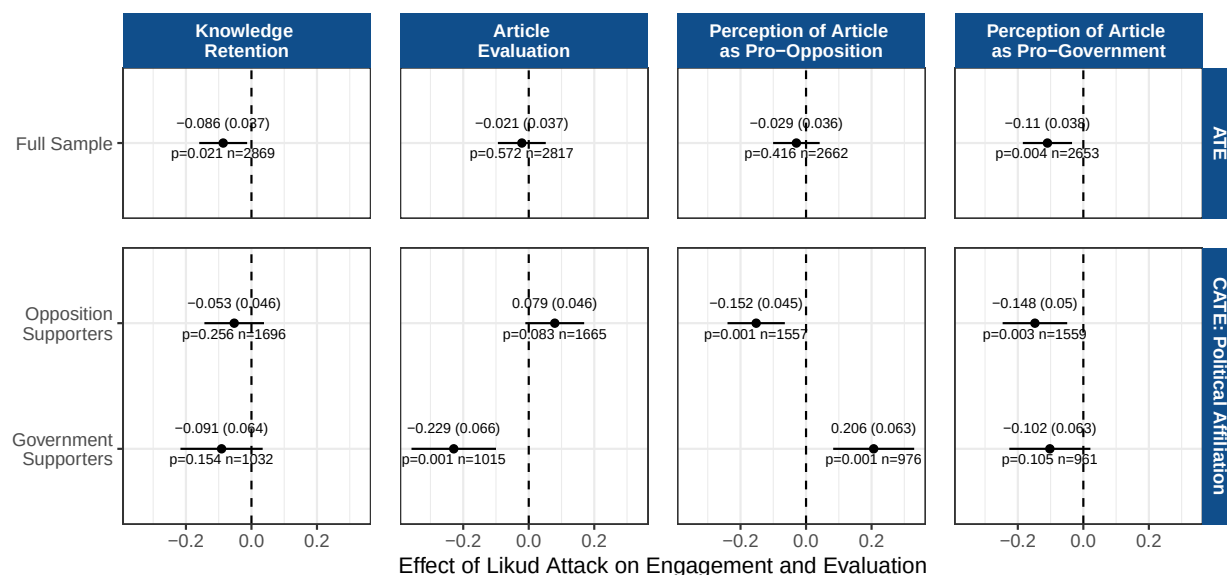


Figure 7: Media attacks shape respondents' evaluations of journalistic content. This Figure reports point estimate and corresponding 95% confidence intervals representing the effects of the political attacks treatment on respondents' evaluation of journalistic content. Table format results reported in Table A23.

Turning to subjective evaluations, ATE estimates in the second panel of Figure 7 suggest an overall null effect of Likud attacks on respondents' evaluation of journalistic content. However, in line with the polarized pattern of results reported in Figure 5, we find that this null effect is driven by diverging responses to treatment among government and opposition supporters. Indeed, in response to treatment government supporters report less favorable evaluations of the article to which they were exposed. This effect is equivalent to a decrease on the overall evaluative index which amounts to 22.9% of the control group standard deviation. In contrast, opposition supporters report a modest increase in positive evaluations of the article, equivalent to 7.9% of the control group standard deviation.

Considering respondents evaluation of the article's pro-opposition slant, we find a similar pattern of polarization. The overall effects of the Likud attack treatment on perceptions of pro-opposition slant are null, but this null is driven by diverging responses among government and opposition supporters. Whereas the former evaluate the article as substantially more pro opposition under treatment—amounting to a change equivalent of 20% of the control group standard deviation—the latter view the article as less pro opposition under treatment—amounting to a change that is equivalent to 15% of the control group standard deviation. Finally, we find that treatment modestly reduced perceptions of the article's pro-government slant by 11% of the control group standard deviation. Importantly, this effect is relatively homogeneous among government and opposition supporters.

Overall, these results suggest that—irrespective of the content that journalists produce—political attacks on the press may reduce consumers’ in depth engagement with journalistic content (as measured through our knowledge retention index, as well as additional analysis of respondents’ reading time reported in Appendix E.4), and lead them to evaluate the slant of the content as less favorable towards the government. Importantly however, political attacks on the press have additional polarizing consequences, leading government and opposition supporters to evaluate the quality of journalistic content and its political slant in diverging directions. Alongside the evidence from Study 2a, the findings reported in Figure 7 emphasize that political attacks on the press have the potential not only to shift patterns of media selection, but also change how consumers evaluate the actual content produced by journalists.

Extension: Beyond Government Attacks on the Press

In Appendix E.5, we report on a second extension study in which we benchmark the effects of government and opposition attacks on evaluation of media content produced by targeted journalists. Like in our first extension study, we employ a similar design, introducing a second treatment invoking political attacks from the opposition on the journalist who wrote the article that respondents evaluate.¹⁵ Several insights emerge.

First, we find clear evidence that attacks shape respondents assessments of article quality and slant. In particular, our estimates suggest a clear positive “out-party” effect, wherein exposure to attacks from one’s political opponents leads respondents to ascribe higher quality scores to the article they read. Interestingly however, and in contrast to our main results reported in Figure 7, we find no meaningful “in-party” negative effects for government or opposition supporters. Second, we find that attacks meaningfully shape perceptions of article slant. Most notably, opposition attacks lead government supporters to evaluate an article as less pro-opposition, whereas government attacks lead opposition supporters to view articles as less pro-government. Finally, diverging from the results in our main analyses, in the extension we do not find evidence that attacks shape factual knowledge retention. Overall, however, these results emphasize how political attacks on the press may polarize not only the selection, but also the evaluation of journalistic content.

Additional Analyses

In addition to the extension studies described above, in Appendices E.3 and E.5 we report several diagnostics and additional analyses for our main experiments. First, we provide descriptive

¹⁵In this study, respondents assigned to government (opposition) attacks, were told that “*Recently, several members of the Likud (opposition parties) have claimed that Yariv Levy’s journalistic coverage is politically biased. A senior minister in the Israeli government (leader of an opposition party) even questioned Levy’s journalistic work, alleging that he distorts facts in order to portray the current government and right-wing (opposition) politicians in a negative light.*”

statistics of our sample, and report balance on covariates for all treatments included in our survey. Second, we report minimal patterns of attrition throughout our survey, and rule out concerns about differential attrition by treatment. Third, for our main analyses, we extend our findings from Figures 5-7, and report pre-registered analyses considering subgroup effects among respondents assigned to politicized and non-political journalistic content. Estimates from these analyses are measured with higher degree of uncertainty due to reduction in statistical power when considering subgroup effects. However, for the most part, results appear to be homogeneous across topics. These additional analyses, strengthen our confidence in the overall evidence reported in Figures 5-7.

Together, the results reported above demonstrate that political attacks on the press polarize both the selection and evaluation of media content. However, these experiments focus on how attacks shape citizens' engagement with journalism specifically—they do not address whether political attacks on the press have broader consequences for citizens' political attitudes, their perceptions of democratic health, or their willingness to engage with political out-groups. Study 3 examines these broader attitudinal consequences directly.

Study 3: How Political Attacks Directly Shape Attitudes

Thus far, we have provided empirical evidence suggesting that political attacks on the press increase radio hosts' production of anti-government content and polarize patterns of media consumption and evaluation among the general public. However, we argue that government attacks on the press may have broader consequences that extend beyond shaping the supply and demand for political news. Indeed, such attacks may directly affect, and potentially polarize, citizens' political attitudes.

Research Design

To test this expectation, we report a final information experiment, in which we exposed a subset of respondents to an article describing the December 1, 2024 Likud attack on Israeli journalists.¹⁶ After reading the treatment or a placebo article, respondents reported primary outcomes, including: i) three items eliciting respondents' perceptions of democratic backsliding in Israel averaged into a perceived democratic backsliding index ranging from 0-100, ii) five items measuring re-

¹⁶Respondents in the control group read an article about future NASA expeditions to the moon. It is important to emphasize that our survey was implemented eight months following the initial government attack reported in the treatment news story. Considering this, we measured respondents' awareness to, and recall of the attack, at the end of our survey. Specifically, we asked all respondents whether they recall the December 1 attack on Kan 11 Journalists. As we show in Appendix E.4, among control group respondents (who did not read about the attack), 7.3% of respondents recalled this event, and another 14.4% of respondents were unsure whether they recall the event. We further show demographic correlates of recall, suggesting higher rates of recall among opposition supporters and older respondents. This supplementary evidence suggests that our primary treatment was relatively novel for most respondents, but also underscores that the potential impact of public attacks on the press may be temporally concentrated, since, in the long run most respondents' do not recall the occurrence of specific events.

spondents' preferences to maintain various relationships with out-partisans averaged into a social distance index ranging from 0-100, and single measures of iii) trust in the Israeli government, and iv) opposition ranging from 0-100. All outcomes are standardized so that the control group mean is 0 and standard deviation is 1.¹⁷ We use the same specification employed in study 2 to estimate the effects of exposure to the article depicting the Likud attack on Kan 11 journalists.

Results

In line with the evidence from studies 2a-b, the results reported in Figure 8, suggest that receiving information about political attacks on the press—and specifically reading an article depicting the Likud attack on Kan radio hosts—generated mostly polarized responses. As shown in the top-left panel of Figure 8, the effects of attacks on perceptions of democratic backsliding among our full sample are small and imprecisely estimated. However, this small positive estimate masks meaningful heterogeneity across government and opposition supporters. Specifically, exposure to treatment increases opposition supporters' perceptions of, and concerns about, democratic backsliding by 9.6% of the control group standard deviation. In contrast, the effects of attacks among government supporters are especially small and imprecisely estimated, amounting to less than 10% of the effect reported among opposition supporters.

Turning to consider the consequences of political attacks on citizens' preferences for relationships across the political divide, a somewhat similar pattern emerges. In general, we find that exposure to treatment reduced preferences for interpersonal relationships with outparty members by 10.3% of the control group standard deviation. However, this effect is mostly driven by opposition supporters who become substantially less open to relationships across party lines by over 14% of the control group standard deviation. While our CATE estimates for government supporters are also negative, they are imprecisely estimated, amounting to less than a third of the magnitude of effects among opposition supporters.

In the third and fourth panels of Figure 8 we examine treatment effects on trust in the Israeli government and opposition. Our ATE estimates suggest small and imprecisely estimated responses to treatment. However, in line with the broader pattern of results reported thus far, these small ATE estimates mask meaningful heterogeneity. Whereas exposure to treatment does not shape government supporters' levels of trust in a substantial manner, effects among opposition supporters are relatively meaningful. Among opposition supporters, exposure to treatment reduces trust in the Israeli government by 8.8% of the control-group standard deviation and increases trust in the opposition by 9.6%.

Taken together, the evidence reported in Figure 8 emphasizes the broader polarizing effects of

¹⁷We also collected measures of trust in various media channels and report treatment effects on these outcomes in Appendix E.4.3.

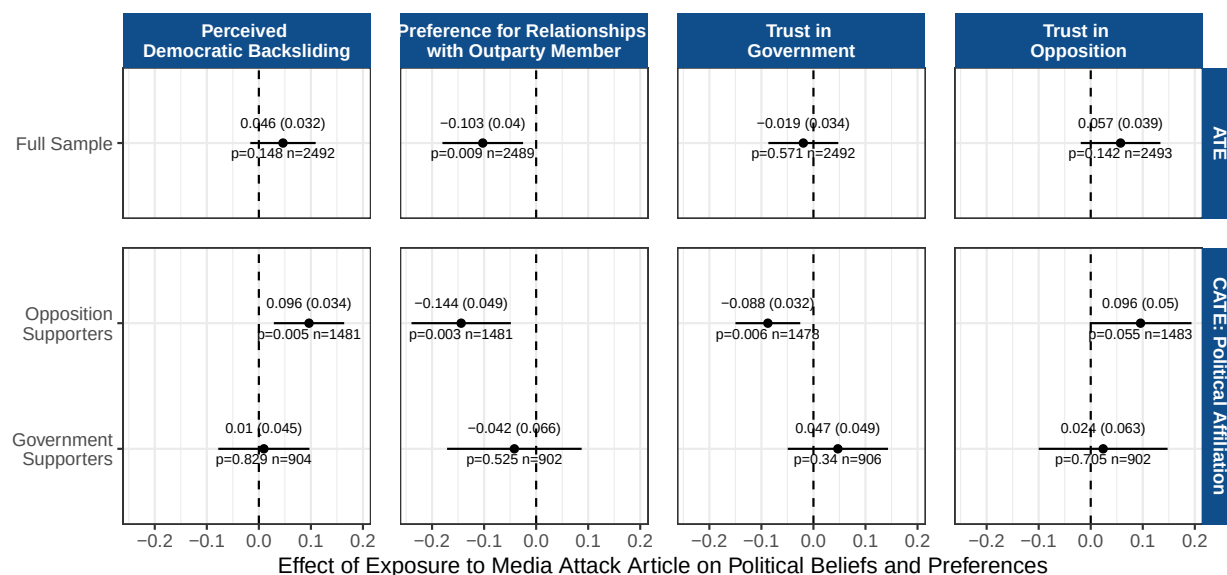


Figure 8: **Learning about the Likud Attacks on Kan 11 Radio Hosts Polarizes Citizens.** This Figure reports point estimate and corresponding 95% confidence intervals representing the effects of reading an article depicting the Likud’s ranking of radio hosts by their level of government support. Table format results reported in Table A24.

attacks on the press. Beyond their short-term effects that compel targeted journalists to produce more anti-government content, and their impact on patterns of selective and polarized engagement among the general public, such attacks have meaningful effects on the public’s broader political beliefs and preferences. Though in aggregate our evidence points to limited effects, our analyses of CATEs show that attacks on the press increase opposition supporters concerns over democratic backsliding and trust in institutions, and reduce their trust in the government as well as their preferences for social engagement with government supporters. At the same time, these attacks have little effect on shifting government supporters’ beliefs or preferences in any direction.

Discussion

Our empirical analyses yield three primary findings. First, government attacks on the press do not exert a chilling effect and may instead increase the short-run prevalence of anti-government content produced by journalists. Second, political attacks, whether from government or opposition actors, polarize media consumption and evaluation, dissuading partisans from consuming content produced by targeted journalists, while encouraging both groups to evaluate the credibility of media content in line with their ex-ante political preferences. Third, government attacks can shape political beliefs and policy preferences, particularly among opposition supporters. These results emphasize the importance of examining the broad consequences of political attacks on the press for multiple actors, including journalists and citizens. Importantly, however, these findings mostly

speak to one specific configuration of political attacks within the broader typology we outline in Table 1: rhetorical attacks by governing actors, directed at individual journalists, in a democratic, backsliding context. With that in mind, our combined results offer several nuanced theoretical insights and implications on the polarizing potential of political attacks on the press.

First, our findings from Studies 1 and 2 suggest that political attacks on the press—which simultaneously influence targeted journalists’ reporting and the public’s media consumption patterns—may generate reinforcing effects. By modestly altering both the content of journalists’ coverage and the composition of their audience, such attacks may foster the emergence of echo chambers. In practice, our findings suggest that targeted journalists may respond to political attacks by intensifying their criticism of the ruling party and government. Our additional observational analyses further clarify the nature of this supply-side response. The backlash manifests through broad anti-government content rather than criticism of specific political figures, the thematic composition of government criticism tracks the news cycle in parallel across targeted and non-targeted shows, we find no evidence of indirect chilling among non-targeted journalists, and both targeted and to a greater extent non-targeted journalists increased explicit discussion of press freedom and media independence in the post-attack period (Appendix D). These patterns are consistent with the boundary-maintenance mechanism theorized in our discussion of media supply: targeted journalists defend their professional autonomy through substantive coverage choices rather than through personal or partisan counter-attacks.

Yet, because attacks also reshape patterns of media selection among the general public, exposure to this additional critical media content is unevenly distributed. Specifically, government opponents, whose *ex-ante* evaluations of the government are already more negative, are disproportionately likely to consume it, while government supporters increasingly disengage from targeted journalists reducing their exposure to criticism of the attacking government. These reinforcing dynamics are consistent with the demand-to-supply channel theorized in our discussion of media supply. Journalists may be more willing to assert editorial independence when they anticipate that opposition audiences will reward critical coverage, while the resulting audience sorting further concentrates critical consumers around targeted outlets. While Studies 1 and 2 do not allow us to speak directly to how this reinforcement process might polarize the electorate, empirically established insights from the literature on selective exposure to partisan news ([Levendusky, 2013a](#); [Broockman and Kalla, 2025b,a](#)), emphasizes the potentially meaningful consequences of this process for broader patterns of societal polarization.

Second, beyond the supply-demand reinforcement documented through Studies 1 and 2, the evidence from Study 3 reveals that attacks on the press also have direct consequences for political attitudes. Indeed, our results indicate that attacks on the press do not mobilize government supporters, but instead provoke backlash among opponents. Specifically, exposure to information regarding

the Likud-affiliated attack on Kan 11 had no discernible effect on government supporters' perceptions of democratic backsliding, their preferences for social relations with political opponents, or their trust in the coalition and opposition. In contrast, the same information significantly shaped opposition supporters' beliefs and preferences. Exposure to attacks reduced willingness for cross-party engagement, a pattern with direct implications for societal polarization. It also heightened concerns about the health of democracy and lowered trust in government—thereby broadening the partisan gap on these salient political issues.

Taken together, our findings underscore the thus far under-examined polarizing consequences of government attacks on the press, complementing recent studies that emphasize elite behavior as a central cause of polarization (Bassan-Nygate and Weiss, 2022; Nicholson, 2012; Bäck et al., 2023). Moreover, these findings emphasize politicians' central role in (unintentionally) encouraging partisan slant in political news, as well as selective exposure to news sources by citizens. This suggests that elites likely play a central role in the emergence of well-documented patterns of selective exposure to increasingly partisan news (Levendusky, 2013a; Broockman and Kalla, 2025b,a), and political polarization more broadly.

Conclusions

This paper advances theory, measurement, and empirical evidence on the political consequences of elite attacks on the press. Theoretically, we introduce a conceptualization of political attacks on the press along four dimensions—actor, instrument, target, and context (Table 1)—and specify a multi-actor framework (Figure 2) linking targeted political attacks to shifts in media supply (what journalists produce), demand (who selects to consume different news sources, and how audiences evaluate their content), and attitudes (how citizens perceive out-partisans, their elected officials and broader democratic health). Empirically, we pair an event-study of a salient attack on the press leveraging a novel corpus of Israeli radio broadcasts with five preregistered survey experiments to explore how such attacks shape media supply, media demand, and general attitudes. Substantively, we show that political attacks on the press can increase anti-government coverage, polarize the consumption and evaluation of content produced by targeted journalists, and trigger opposition backlash in terms of heightened concerns over democratic backsliding and rising preferences for social distance—widening the partisan gaps in selective exposure to news and broader political attitudes. Notably, our results stem from a context of rhetorical attacks with limited coercive credibility, directed at individual journalists in a democratic, albeit backsliding context, where institutional protections remain intact. As we explain in our theoretical framework, these factors warrant backlash and polarization, rather than silencing and compliance, especially likely.

Despite these contributions, this work is not without limitations. First, our supply-side estimates are identified around a single episode in a short time-frame. While the event-study plots

do not show strong systematic pre-trends, and are robust to multiple specifications, the Honest-DiD sensitivity analysis indicates that some specifications are more vulnerable to modest deviations from parallel trends. Accordingly, we interpret these results cautiously as consistent with a short-lived backlash effect, and we also view the patterns as descriptively informative evidence of how anti-government content increased in the days immediately surrounding the attack, even if contemporaneous shocks or spillovers to comparison outlets cannot be fully ruled out. Relatedly, while our event-study estimates show no evidence that the initial backlash reverses into chilling within our two-week post-treatment window, we cannot rule out longer-term silencing effects that emerge as the salience of the attack fades or as journalists face repeated targeting. Indeed, the recall data from our survey—showing that only 7.3% of control respondents recalled the specific attack eight months later—suggests that the impact of individual attacks may be temporally concentrated, raising important questions about whether sustained campaigns of media targeting, such as those examined by [Panievsky \(2022\)](#), produce qualitatively different dynamics than isolated episodes.

Second, our survey tasks rely on concise vignettes and fictitious bylines to isolate mechanisms. Real-world reactions shaped by reputation, repeated exposure, and social signaling may differ in magnitude. Similarly, our behavioral and attitudinal outcomes are self-reported immediately post-treatment, raising questions about the longer-term effects of attacks beyond highly controlled survey environments. Thus, we encourage scholars to build on our theory and evidence to identify the effects of media attacks on news consumption, evaluation and attitudinal change using complementary, more naturalistic research designs (like the design employed in Study 1).

Our evidence stems from the Israeli context: a theory-relevant case characterized by high polarization, robust public broadcasting, plural private media, and recurring rhetorical attacks by governing elites directed at individual journalists. Thus, we expect these findings to generalize to other polarized democracies with similar configurations. Specifically, in contexts where attacks are public and credible, targeted outlets are salient, substitution toward partisan media alternatives is easy, and press trust is already sorted by partisanship, we expect that political attacks on the press will have similar effects as those detailed above. That said, drawing on our classification of political attacks described in Table 1, one may expect that the consequences of such attacks may be weaker (or potentially manifest in a chilling response) in closed autocracies, and more contingent where media salience and substitution are limited. Thus, we encourage researchers to employ suitable research designs (e.g., case selection via purposive sampling ([Egami and Lee, 2024](#); [Bassan-Nygate et al., 2025](#))), to interrogate questions of external validity.

An important scope condition for our findings concerns the identity of the actors committing political attacks on the press. Our event study, and most of our experiments, involve attacks originating from a right-wing governing coalition. A substantial literature documents that conservative voters express lower baseline trust in the mainstream media than liberal voters ([Ladd, 2012](#); [Gross-](#)

mann and Hopkins, 2016), and that right-wing populist movements are especially associated with anti-press rhetoric (Krämer, 2018). As noted above, this is especially true in the Israeli context. This raises the question of whether attacks originating from other political actors—with different ideological backgrounds or institutional standing—would generate similar or diverging effects. We begin to address this question with our extension experiments, which benchmark government against opposition attacks and establish that attacks originating from *both* government and opposition actors polarize the consumption and evaluation of media. Notably, for media selection among partisans, government attacks are double in magnitude when benchmarked against opposition attacks. Because ideology and governing status are aligned in the Israeli context, however, this design provides leverage on both dimensions at once but cannot fully disentangle whether difference in effect magnitude is driven by the attacker’s institutional role or ideological position of the attacker and their constituency. Future work in contexts where left-wing parties hold power would help isolate the relative contributions of governing status and ideological standings, and we encourage scholars to build on our analyses to address this point, and further extend our analyses to additional contexts.

These limitations notwithstanding, our results suggest that government attacks on the press shift media supply in the short run, and influence audiences consumption and evaluation patterns in ways that can entrench partisan information ecosystems. Building on these findings, future work should explore the durability of the effects we identify under repeated attacks, systematically vary the dimensions identified in our typology—comparing effects across actor types (governing vs. opposition, state vs. non-state), instruments (rhetorical, legal, regulatory, economic, harassment/violence), targets (individual journalists vs. outlets vs. the press as an institution), and contexts (consolidated democracies, hybrid regimes, autocracies)—map cross-platform spillovers and audience flows with behavioral data, and test newsroom, civil-society, and platform responses that might mitigate polarization without hindering watchdog journalism.

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The Polarizing Effects of Political Attacks on the Press:

Evidence from Israel

Supplementary Information

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A Text Analysis

A.1 Dictionaries

Table A1: Hebrew keywords for dictionary-based analyses.

Category	Hebrew Keywords	English Translations
Government	רוהמ, ראש הממשלה, ביבי, בנימין, נתניהו, אשת ראש, יאיר נתניהו, שרה נתניהו, משפחת נתניהו, אבנר נתניהו, הממשלה, שר, שרים, קואליציה, ליכוד, ממשלה, ממשלת.	Netanyahu, Benjamin, Bibi, Prime Minister, PM (abbreviation), Sara Netanyahu, Yair Netanyahu, Prime Minister's wife, Avner Netanyahu, Netanyahu family, government, Likud, coalition, ministers, minister, government of (construct form).

A.2 GPT Prompts

"You are labeling paragraphs from Israeli radio hosts that reference the government. For each paragraph, assess two dimensions:", "1) Topic Polarity: What is the nature of the content being discussed about the government or its members? Is it inherently positive, negative, or neutral? For example, neutrally mentioning a successful policy is a positive topic; neutrally mentioning policy failures or mentioning corruption is a negative topic; describing an event or decision that is neither positive nor negative is neutral. If the content is not relevant to the government/coalition actors, it should be classified as irrelevant. Be sure that the topic polarity is assessed only in reference to the government or particular government/coalition figures, not other actors or topics that might be discussed in the paragraph.", "2) Framing: How does the speaker frame the government or its actions? Is the speaker's tone or attitude positive, negative, or neutral? Positive framing includes praise or support; negative framing includes criticism or disapproval; neutral framing is descriptive or balanced. If the content is not relevant to the government/coalition actors, it should be classified as irrelevant. Be sure that the framing is assessed only in reference to the government or particular government figures, not other actors or topics that might be discussed in the paragraph." "Given

these instructions, how would you label the following paragraph: "Use only one of: positive, negative, neutral, or irrelevant for each score. Then explain your reasoning by referring to specific words or tone from the paragraph."

B Validation

Table A2: Percent agreement across coder pairs for topic framing vs. topic polarity.

Coder pair	Variable	Percent agreement
GPT vs RA1	Framing	0.844
GPT vs RA1	Polarity	0.788
GPT vs RA2	Framing	0.851
GPT vs RA2	Polarity	0.818
RA1 vs RA2	Framing	0.909
RA1 vs RA2	Polarity	0.860

C Descriptive Analyses of Radio Data

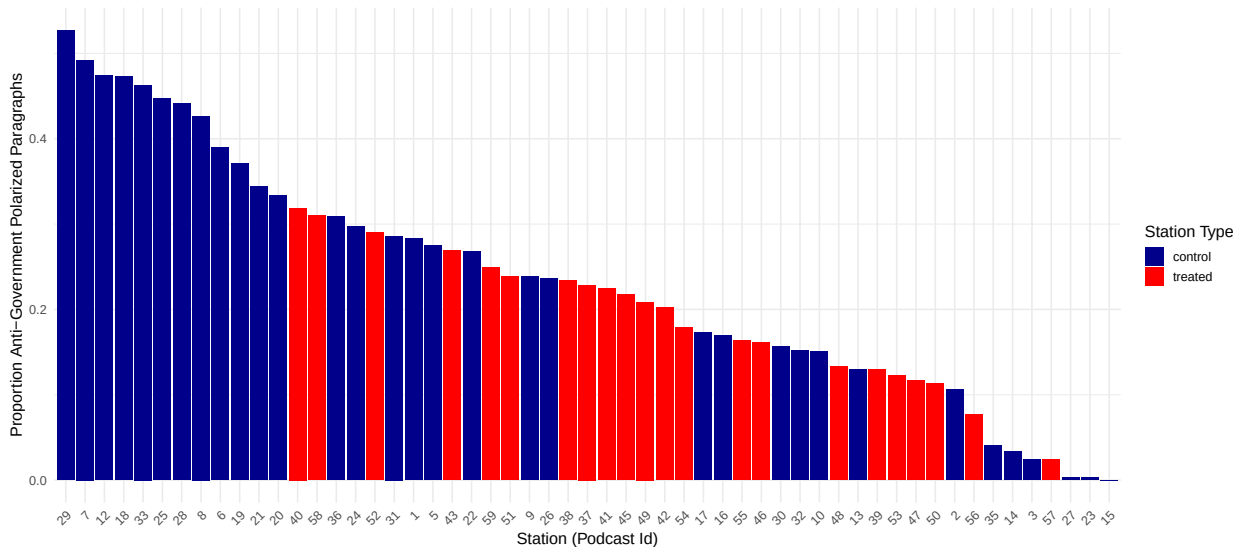


Figure A1: **Proportion of Anti-Government Content in the Pre-Treatment Period.** Anti-government content is measured as the sum of negative references to coalition actors. The proportion is calculated as anti-government paragraphs / total paragraphs.

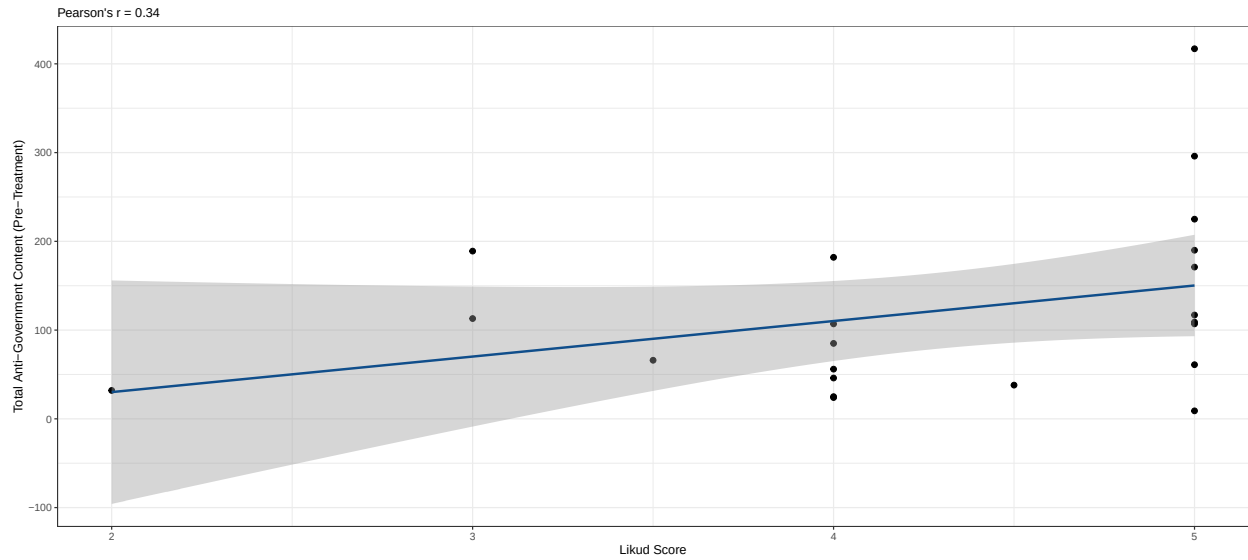


Figure A2: Correlation between Anti-Government Content and Likud Score for Treated Podcasters in the Pre-Treatment Period. Anti-government content is measured as negative references to coalition actors. Likud Scores were listed on leaked government list attacking podcasters.

D Event Study

D.1 Treatment Assignment Over Time

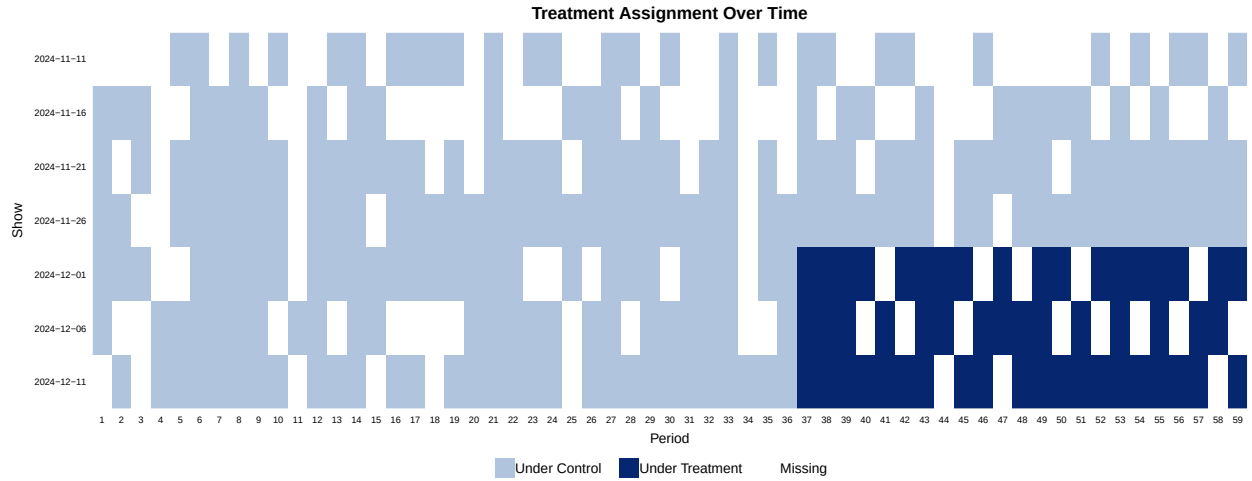


Figure A3: **Treatment assignment over time (five-day aggregation).** This panel-view figure visualizes treatment status across radio shows and time using our five-day period definition, which is the main aggregation used in the analysis. Each row corresponds to a show and each column to a five-day period. The figure illustrates the shift into treatment for targeted shows beginning with the period anchored on December 1, 2024, while comparison shows remain under control; blank cells indicate periods with missing observations.

D.2 Honest DiD Sensitivity Analysis

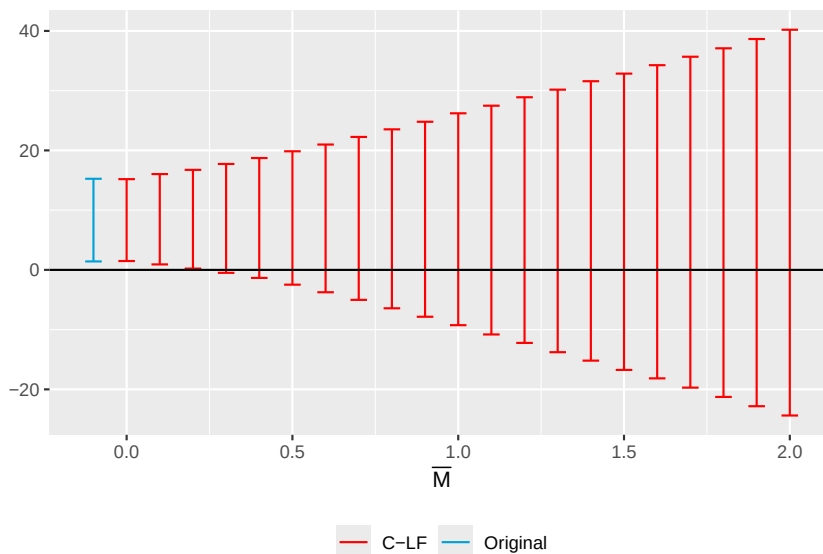


Figure A4: **Honest DiD Sensitivity Analysis for 5-Day Aggregation.** This figure reports the Rambachan and Roth (2023) relative-magnitude sensitivity analysis for the dynamic DiD estimate at $t = 0$, using the five-day aggregation that underpins our main specification. The horizontal axis, $\bar{M}$, indexes the size of post-treatment violations of parallel trends relative to the largest violation observed in the pre-treatment periods, while the vertical axis shows the corresponding confidence intervals for the estimated effect. The blue interval at $\bar{M} = 0$ corresponds to the conventional event-study confidence interval under parallel trends; the red intervals show how the confidence set widens as we allow for larger deviations from parallel trends. For violations $\bar{M} < 0.3$, the confidence interval remains above zero, indicating that the estimated increase in anti-government content is robust to small departures from the parallel trends assumption.

D.3 Robustness to Different Event-Time Windows

Table A3: **Effect of attack on radio host production of polarized anti-government content across different event-time windows.** This table reports event-study estimates of the December 1 attack's effect on the share of polarized anti-government content in radio broadcasts, using 3-day, 4-day, and 5-day period definitions. Polarization is measured as the sum of positive references to opposition actors and negative references to coalition actors. All specifications include podcast, period, and show fixed effects, with standard errors clustered at the podcast level. Coefficients are reported relative to the reference period ($t = -1$).

Dependent Variable:	Anti-Government Polarized Content		
Model:	4-day window	3-day window	5-day window
<i>Variables</i>			
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -6		7.524 (5.728)	
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -5	7.117 (5.969)	1.614 (6.296)	
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -4	-1.779 (4.493)	9.829 (6.034)	7.706 (5.368)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -3	8.004 (4.572)	5.409 (6.428)	1.606 (4.744)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -2	2.304 (4.537)	5.504 (5.836)	7.145 (4.243)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 0	9.165* (4.483)	10.97* (5.048)	8.333* (3.529)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 1	4.138 (5.055)	6.550 (5.320)	1.435 (4.373)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 2	2.573 (4.396)	3.061 (6.680)	4.259 (3.864)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 3	3.582 (5.495)	7.848 (6.192)	
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 4		5.319 (6.194)	
<i>Fixed-effects</i>			
podcast_id	Yes	Yes	Yes
period	Yes	Yes	Yes
shows	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	314	337	290
R ²	0.85361	0.85755	0.86699
Adjusted R ²	0.80418	0.81082	0.81953
Within R ²	0.03362	0.02586	0.03125

Clustered (podcast_id) standard errors in parentheses.

Signif. Codes: ***, 0.001, **, 0.01, *, 0.05

Table A4: **Callaway-Sant’Anna dynamic effects around the intervention (anti-government content).** This table reports dynamic treatment effect estimates from the Callaway and Sant’Anna estimator for the effect of the December 1, 2024 Likud attack on radio hosts’ production of anti-government content. We implement the estimator using 3-, 4-, and 5-day aggregations to accommodate irregular broadcast schedules and allow for an unbalanced panel. Standard errors are clustered at the show level. Unlike the TWFE event-study specification, the Callaway-Sant’Anna approach does not rely on a single omitted reference period; estimates are reported by event time for ease of comparison with the TWFE results.

spec	week	estimate	se	conf.low	conf.high
3 day window	-3	-2.932	8.416	-19.426	13.563
3 day window	-2	-1.320	7.900	-16.804	14.163
3 day window	-1	-3.241	9.346	-21.559	15.077
3 day window	0	6.843	8.044	-8.923	22.609
3 day window	1	2.815	5.716	-8.388	14.018
3 day window	2	5.033	8.404	-11.439	21.505
3 day window	3	7.131	8.042	-8.631	22.893
3 day window	4	12.414	9.677	-6.552	31.381
4 day window	-3	10.195	6.563	-2.668	23.058
4 day window	-2	-1.582	7.619	-16.516	13.352
4 day window	-1	-6.529	6.839	-19.933	6.875
4 day window	0	7.959	6.345	-4.477	20.395
4 day window	1	6.400	5.177	-3.746	16.547
4 day window	2	5.375	4.681	-3.799	14.549
4 day window	3	11.893	9.873	-7.459	31.244
5 day window	-3	0.368	10.218	-19.660	20.396
5 day window	-2	7.539	7.818	-7.785	22.863
5 day window	-1	-9.912	4.543	-18.816	-1.007
5 day window	0	9.111	4.659	-0.021	18.243
5 day window	1	3.959	5.556	-6.931	14.849
5 day window	2	5.068	3.391	-1.578	11.715

D.4 Robustness to Alternative Treatment Definitions

Our main specification classifies radio hosts as “targeted” if they received a score of 3-5 on the Likud-affiliated list (Figure 3), excluding one Kan host who received a score of 2. Here we assess sensitivity to this classification by re-estimating the main event-study and difference-in-differences models under three alternative treatment definitions: 1) a *strict* cutoff that restricts the treated group to hosts with scores of 4-5 only, dropping those at the boundary; 2) an *all-Kan* specification that treats every Kan network host as targeted regardless of their score; and 3) a *continuous* specification that uses the Likud score itself as a treatment-intensity variable, estimating a dose-response relationship.

Table A5 reports results. Panel A shows TWFE event-study coefficients. The immediate post-attack estimate (event time = 0) is positive across all four specifications. The main specification (scores 3-5) yields a coefficient of 8.33 ($p = 0.022$). The all-Kan specification produces a similar estimate of 7.69 ($p = 0.033$). The strict cutoff (scores 4-5) yields a smaller and marginally significant estimate of 6.55 ($p = 0.084$), likely reflecting reduced statistical power from dropping three treated podcasts rather than a substantively different effect. The continuous specification confirms a significant positive dose-response relationship: each unit increase in the Likud score is associated with 1.83 additional anti-government sentences in the first post-attack period ($p = 0.018$). Across all specifications, the effect dissipates by the second post-attack period, consistent with the short-lived backlash pattern documented in the main text.

Panel B presents Callaway-Sant’Anna dynamic ATT estimates for the three binary treatment definitions (the continuous specification is not compatible with the C&S estimator). The C&S results confirm the same pattern: positive first-period effects for the main (9.11), strict (7.44), and all-Kan (10.19, $p < 0.05$) specifications, with no sustained effects in subsequent periods.

Table A5: Robustness to Alternative Treatment Definitions (5-Day Bins)

	Treatment Definition			
	Scores 3–5 (Main)	Scores 4–5 (Strict)	All Kan Hosts	Continuous Score
<i>Panel A: TWFE Event-Study</i>				
Event Time = −4	7.706 (5.368)	7.339 (5.316)	7.141 (5.427)	1.729 (1.191)
Event Time = −3	1.606 (4.744)	4.598 (4.490)	0.533 (4.908)	0.517 (1.134)
Event Time = −2	7.145 (4.243)	7.926 (4.152)	6.201 (4.222)	1.810 (0.924)
Event Time = −1	(Reference Period)			
Event Time = 0	8.333* (3.529)	6.555 (3.725)	7.686* (3.516)	1.830* (0.753)
Event Time = 1	1.435 (4.373)	1.498 (4.519)	0.247 (4.372)	0.313 (1.027)
Event Time = 2	4.259 (3.864)	3.275 (3.584)	3.848 (3.880)	0.959 (0.841)
<i>Panel B: Callaway-Sant’Anna (Dynamic ATT)</i>				
Event Time = 0	9.111* (4.515)	7.437 (4.671)	10.189* (4.470)	—
Event Time = 1	3.959 (5.795)	5.524 (6.127)	2.670 (5.868)	—
Event Time = 2	5.068 (3.695)	3.703 (3.689)	4.606 (3.894)	—
<i>N</i> treated podcasts	22	19	23	22
Observations	290	290	290	290
Podcast, period, shows FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Clustered (podcast-level) standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$. Reference period is event time = −1.

“Continuous Score” uses the Likud score (0–5) as a treatment-intensity variable rather than a binary indicator.

Callaway-Sant’Anna estimates are not available for the continuous specification.

D.5 Disaggregated Content Analysis

To better understand the nature of the backlash effect documented in our main analysis, we decompose the content produced by targeted and comparison hosts into entity-level components. Our primary outcome in the main text flags a sentence as anti-government if it contains a negative reference (by topic polarity or framing) to *any* coalition entity—the government, Netanyahu, the Likud party, or the Netanyahu family. This aggregate measure captures the overall volume of critical coverage directed at the ruling coalition, but does not reveal *which* actors are the target of increased criticism or whether journalists also shift their coverage of non-coalition actors. To address this, we estimate separate event studies for five entity-specific content categories: 1) anti-government content (negative references to the government), 2) anti-Netanyahu content (negative references to the prime minister), 3) anti-Likud content (negative references to the Likud party), 4) pro-opposition content (positive references to opposition actors), and 5) pro-protest content (positive references to protest movements). For each outcome, we employ the same TWFE specification, Callaway and Sant’Anna estimator, and HonestDiD sensitivity analysis used in the main text.

Figure A5 presents the results. The top-left panel reproduces the aggregate anti-government result from the main analysis. The remaining panels report entity-specific effects. In each panel, we overlay dynamic estimates from the TWFE event study and the Callaway and Sant’Anna estimator, following the same approach used in Figure 4. The corresponding regression tables are reported in Tables A6 and A7.

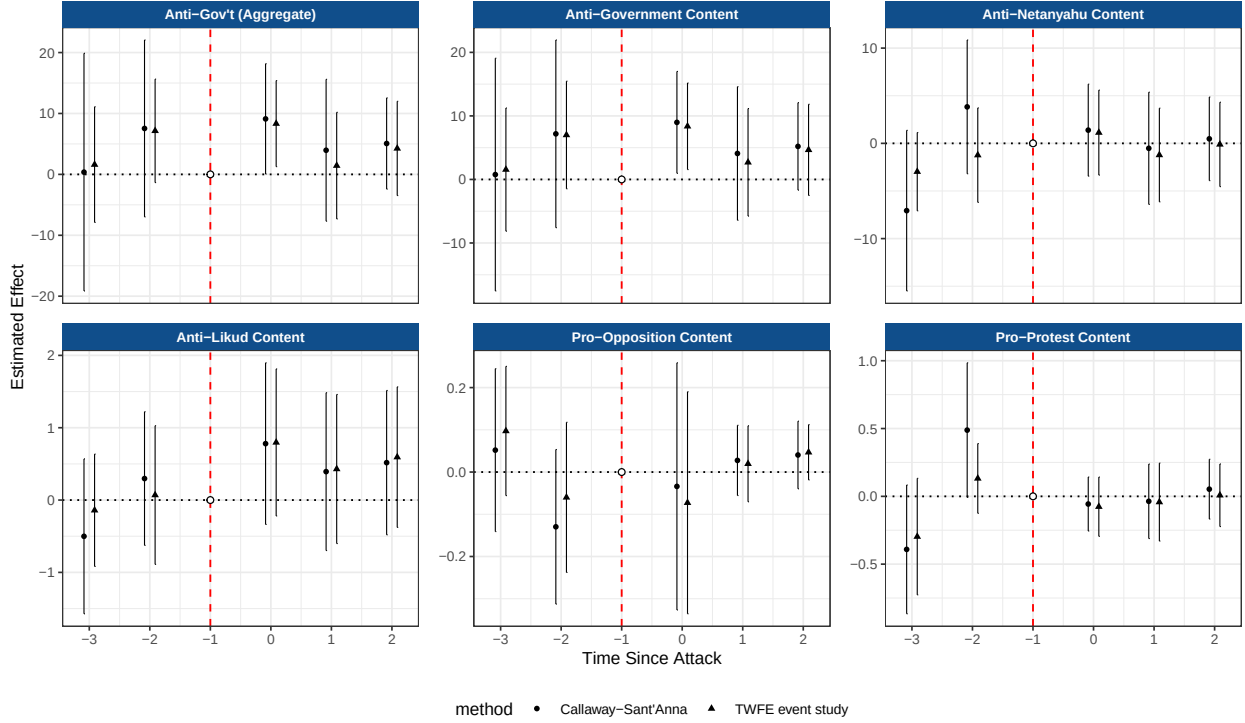


Figure A5: **Decomposition of anti-government content by entity.** Each panel overlays dynamic estimates from the TWFE event study and the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator for a specific content category, using five-day aggregated data with show and period fixed effects and a control for the number of shows in each period. Standard errors are clustered at the show level. The top-left panel reproduces the aggregate anti-government measure from the main analysis (Figure 4). The remaining panels decompose this measure into entity-specific components.

The decomposition reveals that the aggregate backlash effect is primarily driven by an increase in general anti-government content. Specifically, the government-specific component shows a significant positive effect at $t = 0$ ($\hat{\beta} = 8.37$, $p = 0.017$), closely matching the aggregate estimate ($\hat{\beta} = 8.33$, $p = 0.022$). This is consistent with the fact that general government references account for the vast majority of anti-government sentences in our corpus (a daily average of 24.4 sentences per show, compared with 7.9 for Netanyahu, 0.6 for Likud, and fewer than 0.1 for the Netanyahu family).

In contrast, we find no significant post-treatment effects for anti-Netanyahu or anti-Likud content, indicating that the backlash does not manifest as increased personal criticism of specific coalition politicians or the attacking party itself. Turning to the opposition side, we also find no signif-

icant effects on pro-opposition or pro-protest content. Targeted journalists do not respond to the attack by increasing positive coverage of opposition actors or protest movements.

Taken together, this pattern is substantively informative. The backlash operates through an increase in general criticism of the government and its policies—the core function of watchdog journalism—rather than through personal attacks on specific political figures or through partisan advocacy for the opposition. This is consistent with targeted journalists asserting editorial independence through their coverage choices rather than adopting an overtly partisan posture in response to political pressure.

Figure A6 reports the HonestDiD relative-magnitude sensitivity analysis for each entity-specific outcome, following the same approach used in Figure A4.

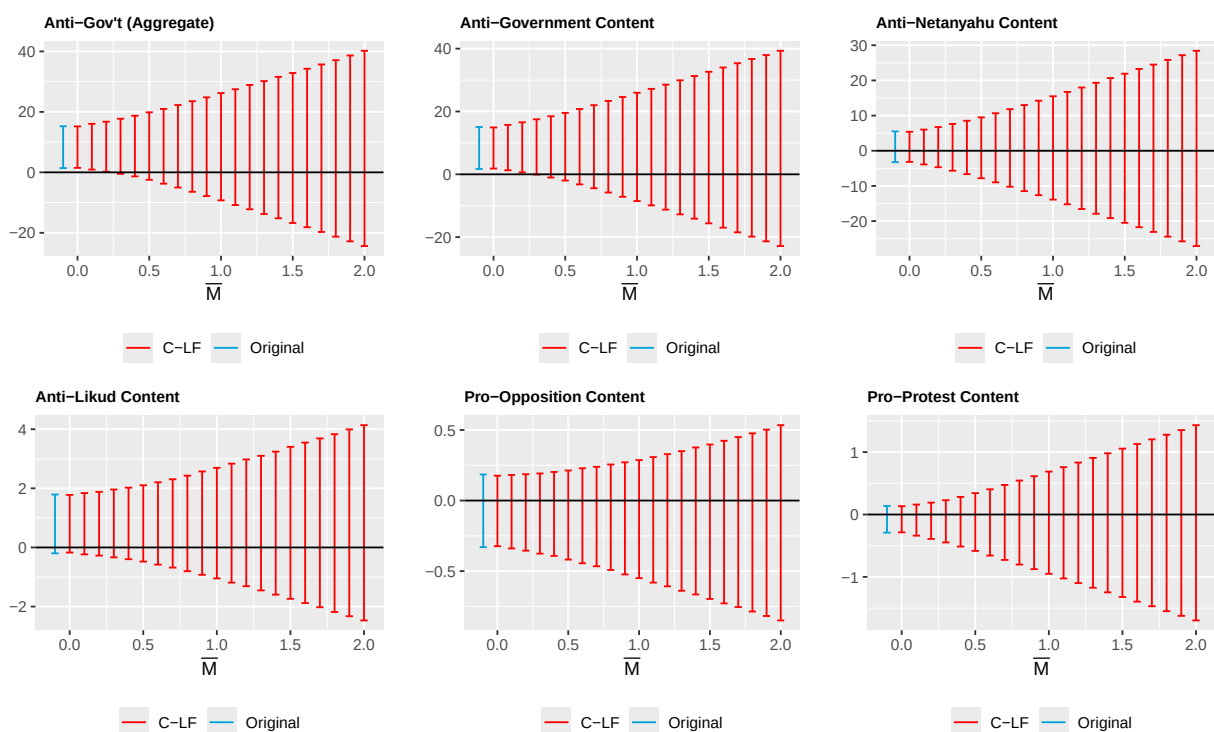


Figure A6: **HonestDiD sensitivity analysis for disaggregated content measures.** Each panel reports the Rambachan and Roth (2023) relative-magnitude sensitivity analysis for the $t = 0$ estimate of a specific content category, using five-day aggregated data.

Table A6: TWFE Event-Study Estimates: Disaggregated Content (5-Day Aggregation)

Dependent Variables:	Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	Anti-Gov't (Gov't Only)	Anti- Netanyahu	Anti- Likud	Pro- Opposition	Pro- Protest
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Variables</i>						
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -4	7.706 (5.368)	6.763 (5.229)	5.566* (2.736)	0.5030 (0.4782)	0.0141 (0.0845)	0.0680 (0.1585)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -3	1.606 (4.744)	1.553 (4.841)	-2.974 (2.053)	-0.1411 (0.3880)	0.0972 (0.0765)	-0.2970 (0.2146)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = -2	7.145 (4.243)	6.996 (4.232)	-1.238 (2.477)	0.0694 (0.4788)	-0.0600 (0.0888)	0.1320 (0.1284)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 0	8.333* (3.529)	8.366* (3.404)	1.128 (2.229)	0.7966 (0.5077)	-0.0727 (0.1313)	-0.0764 (0.1091)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 1	1.435 (4.373)	2.694 (4.227)	-1.223 (2.457)	0.4294 (0.5148)	0.0196 (0.0449)	-0.0423 (0.1436)
treatment_num2 $\times$ event_time = 2	4.259 (3.864)	4.656 (3.585)	-0.1133 (2.213)	0.5934 (0.4853)	0.0468 (0.0327)	0.0080 (0.1153)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
podcast_id	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
period	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
shows	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>						
Observations	290	294	294	294	294	294
R ²	0.86699	0.84690	0.80546	0.47338	0.24934	0.36875
Adjusted R ²	0.81953	0.79517	0.73972	0.29543	-0.00431	0.15546
Within R ²	0.03125	0.02732	0.03521	0.02405	0.01460	0.02924

Clustered (podcast_id) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.001, **: 0.01, *: 0.05*

Clustered (podcast_id) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A7: Callaway-Sant'Anna Dynamic Effects: Disaggregated Content (5-Day Aggregation)

spec	week	estimate	se	conf.low	conf.high
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	-3	0.368	9.953	-19.139	19.876
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	-2	7.539	7.410	-6.984	22.062
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	-1	-9.912	4.398	-18.531	-1.292
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	0	9.111	4.620	0.056	18.166
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	1	3.959	5.941	-7.686	15.604
Anti-Gov't (Aggregate)	2	5.068	3.821	-2.421	12.557
Anti-Government Content	-3	0.765	9.344	-17.549	19.079
Anti-Government Content	-2	7.178	7.535	-7.592	21.947
Anti-Government Content	-1	-9.953	4.345	-18.468	-1.437
Anti-Government Content	0	8.982	4.089	0.968	16.996
Anti-Government Content	1	4.088	5.363	-6.423	14.600
Anti-Government Content	2	5.202	3.510	-1.678	12.083
Anti-Netanyahu Content	-3	-7.065	4.301	-15.495	1.365
Anti-Netanyahu Content	-2	3.830	3.582	-3.191	10.851
Anti-Netanyahu Content	-1	0.152	2.885	-5.502	5.807
Anti-Netanyahu Content	0	1.387	2.464	-3.443	6.217
Anti-Netanyahu Content	1	-0.520	3.005	-6.409	5.370
Anti-Netanyahu Content	2	0.476	2.239	-3.913	4.864
Anti-Likud Content	-3	-0.501	0.546	-1.572	0.569
Anti-Likud Content	-2	0.297	0.471	-0.627	1.221
Anti-Likud Content	-1	-0.144	0.518	-1.159	0.871
Anti-Likud Content	0	0.780	0.570	-0.337	1.897
Anti-Likud Content	1	0.393	0.557	-0.698	1.484
Anti-Likud Content	2	0.517	0.509	-0.480	1.515
Pro-Opposition Content	-3	0.052	0.098	-0.141	0.245
Pro-Opposition Content	-2	-0.130	0.093	-0.313	0.053
Pro-Opposition Content	-1	0.043	0.108	-0.168	0.254
Pro-Opposition Content	0	-0.034	0.149	-0.327	0.259
Pro-Opposition Content	1	0.028	0.042	-0.056	0.111
Pro-Opposition Content	2	0.040	0.041	-0.040	0.120
Pro-Protest Content	-3	-0.391	0.242	-0.866	0.084
Pro-Protest Content	-2	0.488	0.253	-0.008	0.985
Pro-Protest Content	-1	-0.167	0.120	-0.403	0.069
Pro-Protest Content	0	-0.057	0.102	-0.256	0.143
Pro-Protest Content	1	-0.037	0.140	-0.311	0.238
Pro-Protest Content	2	0.053	0.112	-0.167	0.273

D.6 Thematic Composition of Anti-Government Content

The disaggregated content analysis in the preceding section shows that the backlash effect identified in our main analysis is concentrated in anti-government content broadly, rather than in criticism of specific political figures such as Netanyahu or specific parties such as Likud. To further characterize the substantive themes that comprise anti-government discourse on Israeli radio, we use

BERTopic, an unsupervised topic modeling approach that clusters semantically similar sentences using transformer-based embeddings. Specifically, we embed all sentences classified as containing anti-government content using a Hebrew-language sentence transformer model (AlephBERT), reduce the embedding dimensions via UMAP, and identify dense clusters via HDBSCAN. We then extract the most representative terms for each cluster to characterize its thematic content.

Applied to the 5,988 sentences classified as containing anti-government content, BERTopic identifies 12 thematic clusters, summarized in Table A8. The largest topics concern legal and judicial reform, the war in Lebanon and Gaza, and the Netanyahu corruption trial. Other topics capture discussion of the national budget, Minister Ben Gvir and police affairs, ceasefire and hostage negotiations, International Criminal Court proceedings, and criticism of Netanyahu’s long tenure in office. Note that some sentences classified as anti-government also reference specific political figures; for example, a discussion of the Netanyahu trial may be coded as anti-government because it criticizes the government’s handling of legal proceedings, even as it also references the Prime Minister specifically and may also be coded as anti-Netanyahu. Table A8 compares the thematic composition of anti-government content before and after the attack, separately for targeted and non-targeted shows. The largest shifts in topic prevalence are broadly parallel across targeted and non-targeted shows. War-related anti-government content declined sharply in both groups (–15.1 and –23.2 percentage points, respectively), consistent with the November 27, 2024 ceasefire with Hezbollah. Content related to the Netanyahu trial and legal reform increased in both groups, tracking the intensification of trial proceedings in the same period. These trends likely reflect shifts in the news cycle rather than differential changes in the thematic focus of government criticism. Notably, the fact that targeted and non-targeted shows track the same thematic shifts provides additional support for the parallel trends assumption underlying the difference-in-differences design in our main analysis.

If the attack had induced self-censorship on specific politically sensitive topics, we would expect targeted shows to disproportionately shift *away* from themes most directly critical of the governing coalition—such as the Netanyahu trial or criticism of Minister Ben Gvir. Instead, targeted

shows shift toward these topics at similar rates than non-targeted shows. Combined with the disaggregated event-study results, which show a significant increase in anti-government content but no significant change in entity-specific measures, these patterns suggest that the backlash effect operates broadly across anti-government themes rather than through the amplification or suppression of any particular type of government criticism.

Table A8: Thematic Composition of Anti-Government Content: Pre vs. Post Attack

Topic	Description	Targeted Shows			Non-Targeted Shows		
		Pre (%)	Post (%)	Δ (pp)	Pre (%)	Post (%)	Δ (pp)
0	Legal/Judicial Reform	20.2	25.3	+5.1	19.7	28.3	+8.6
1	War (Hezbollah/Lebanon/Gaza)	31.9	16.9	-15.1	34.9	11.6	-23.2
2	Netanyahu Trial	7.5	17.6	+10.1	7.4	22.4	+15.0
3	Budget/Economy	5.2	6.5	+1.3	13.7	12.7	-1.0
4	Newspaper Commentary	5.9	4.4	-1.4	7.0	5.7	-1.3
5	Ben Gvir/Police	4.2	7.3	+3.0	1.1	3.9	+2.9
6	Police Commissioner	4.1	5.9	+1.9	3.2	3.2	+0.1
7	Ceasefire/Hostage Negotiations	6.8	1.3	-5.5	5.3	2.2	-3.1
8	ICC/International Law	5.5	1.5	-4.0	5.6	2.5	-3.1
9	Government Ministries	2.6	4.2	+1.6	2.5	2.7	+0.2
10	Hostage Advocacy	4.7	2.9	-1.8	1.8	1.4	-0.3
11	Netanyahu (Long Tenure)	0.2	4.8	+4.6	0.7	4.5	+3.8
<i>N (assigned sentences)</i>		<i>614</i>	<i>522</i>		<i>284</i>	<i>558</i>	

Notes: Topics estimated via BERTopic using Hebrew sentence embeddings (AlephBERT). Each sentence was first classified as containing anti-government content using GPT-4. BERTopic then clusters these sentences into thematic groups based on semantic similarity. Topic descriptions are based on the highest-weighted terms in each cluster. Percentages reflect the share of topically assigned anti-government sentences in each group-period cell. “ Δ ” is the percentage-point change from pre- to post-attack. Of the 5,988 anti-government sentences, 1,978 (33%) were assigned to one of the 12 topics; the remainder were classified as thematically diffuse.

Figure A7 visualizes the pre-to-post shift in topic prevalence separately for targeted and non-targeted shows, highlighting the parallel nature of these compositional changes.

D.7 Spillover and Indirect Chilling Effects

A key concern raised in the literature on attacks on the press is the possibility of indirect chilling effects: even journalists who are not directly targeted may alter their coverage if they observe colleagues being attacked (Krämer, 2018). To test for such spillover effects, we examine whether

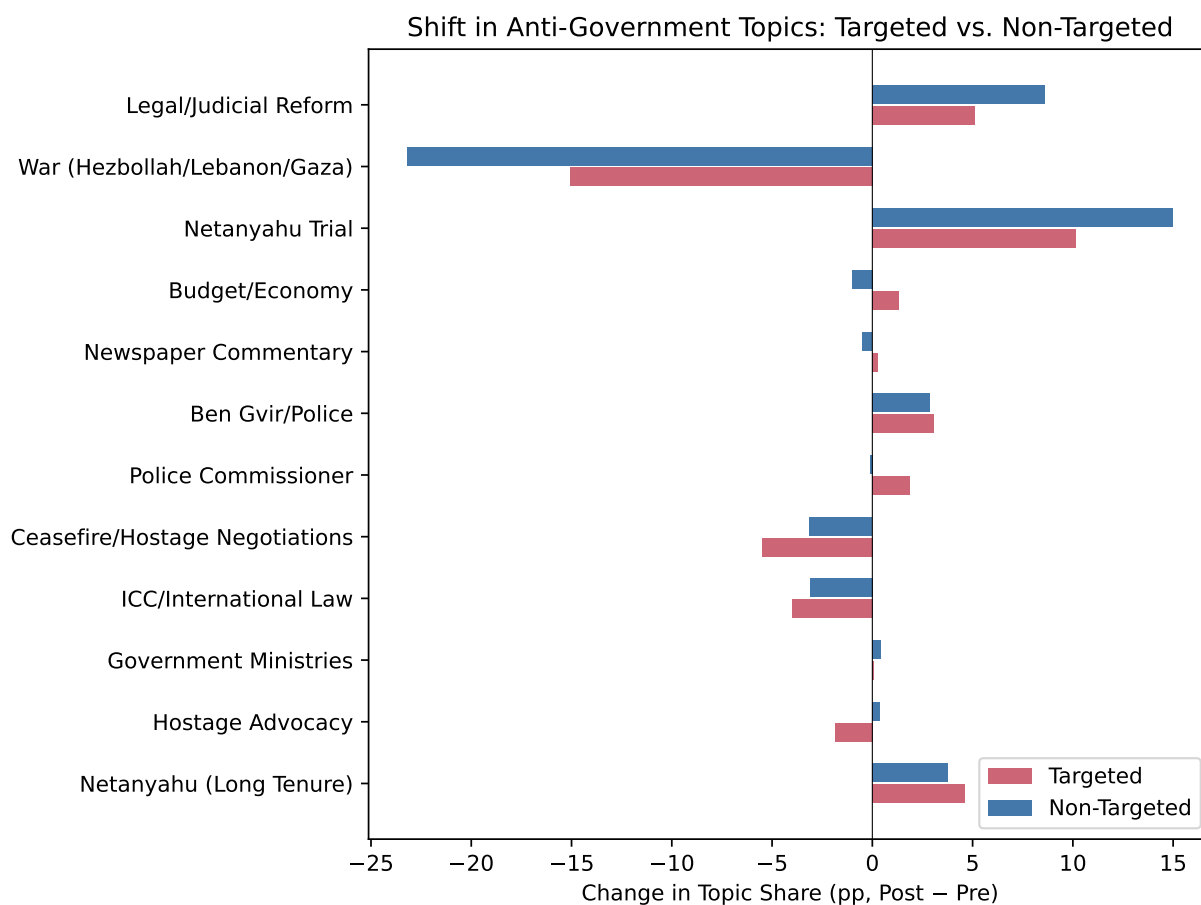


Figure A7: Change in Anti-Government Topic Shares: Targeted vs. Non-Targeted Shows Each bar shows the percentage-point change in a topic's share of anti-government content from before to after the attack. Topics estimated via BERTopic with Hebrew sentence embeddings (AlephBERT).

non-targeted hosts—those in our comparison group—change their production of anti-government content following the December 1 attack.

We conduct this analysis in two steps. First, we examine the descriptive trajectory of anti-government content among non-targeted hosts around the time of the attack. Figure A8 plots the mean level of anti-government content among non-targeted hosts in five-day periods before and after the attack. The figure reveals no discernible shift in content production coinciding with the attack, with anti-government content remaining stable across the pre- and post-treatment periods.

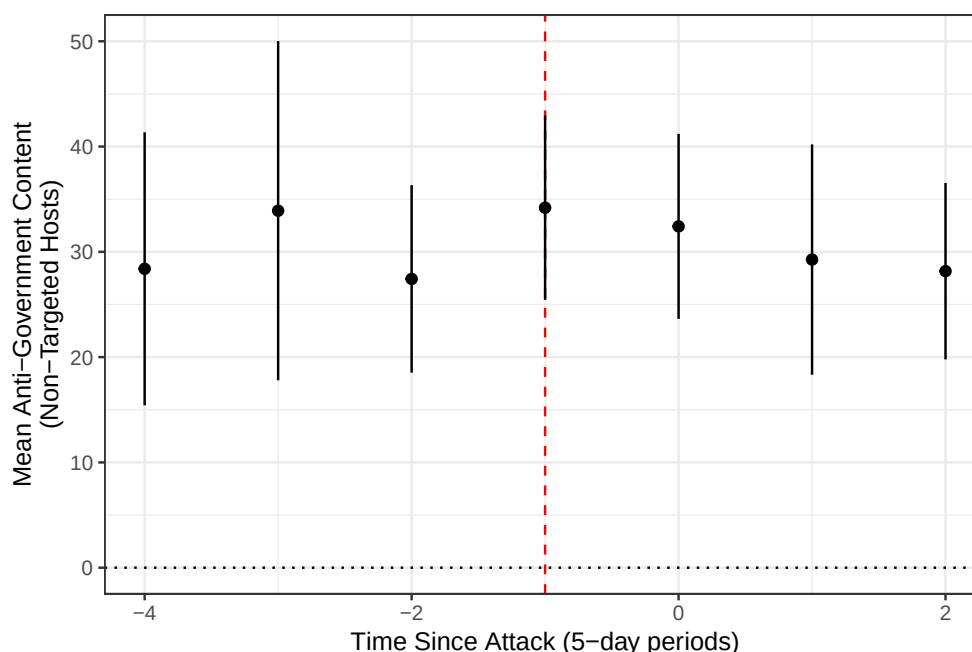


Figure A8: **Anti-government content among non-targeted hosts over time.** This figure plots the mean level of anti-government content (with 95% confidence intervals) among non-targeted radio hosts in five-day periods around the December 1 attack. The dashed red line indicates the last pre-treatment period.

Second, we estimate a series of regressions to formally test for changes in content among non-targeted hosts. Table A9 reports results from four specifications. Column 1 tests whether the pooled sample of non-targeted hosts (including Kan hosts excluded from the treatment group due to low Likud scores, as well as Galatz and 103FM hosts) exhibits a pre/post change in anti-government content. The post coefficient is small and statistically insignificant ($\hat{\beta} = -2.61$, $p = 0.256$). Column 2 estimates a difference-in-differences specification comparing non-targeted Kan hosts

(those within the attacked network but excluded from treatment due to pro-government orientation) to external comparison hosts at Galatz and 103FM. The interaction term is small and insignificant ($\hat{\beta} = -1.40$, $p = 0.548$), indicating no differential change in content among non-targeted Kan hosts relative to external controls. Columns 3 and 4 report station-specific pre/post tests for Galatz and 103FM separately, neither of which shows a significant change.

Table A9: Spillover Analysis: Anti-Government Content Among Non-Targeted Hosts

Dependent Variable: Model:	Anti-Government Content			
	All Non-Targeted (1)	DiD: Kan Non-Targeted vs. External Controls (2)	Galatz (GLZ) (3)	103FM (4)
<i>Variables</i>				
Constant	33.88*** (6.021)	34.32*** (6.128)	22.24*** (2.414)	39.60*** (8.603)
Post	-2.607 (2.200)	-2.767 (2.258)	1.943 (2.077)	-1.598 (2.747)
Kan		-23.65*** (6.128)		
Kan $\times$ Post		-1.399 (2.258)		
<i>Fit statistics</i>				
Observations	348	348	134	209
R ²	0.002	0.013	0.005	0.001
Adjusted R ²	-0.001	0.004	-0.003	-0.004

Clustered (show-level) standard errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.001, **: 0.01, *: 0.05*

Together, these results provide no evidence of indirect chilling effects on non-targeted journalists. The attack appears to have affected only the directly targeted hosts, without generating broader spillovers to other journalists—whether at the same network or at competing stations. This is consistent with the attack being perceived as targeted at specific individuals rather than as a general threat to press independence.

D.8 References to Attacks on the Press

A natural question is whether targeted journalists respond to the attack by explicitly discussing political threats to press freedom on air. To investigate this, we construct a measure of press-attack references using the same two-stage classification pipeline used in our other analyses. First, we apply a dictionary of Hebrew terms related to journalism, press freedom, media independence, and political pressure on the media to flag candidate sentences from the full corpus of radio transcripts. This dictionary includes terms such as “press freedom” (חופש העיתונות), “media independence” (עצמאות התקשורת), “silencing” (השתקה), “shaming” (שיימינג), and “Melukdim” (מלוכדים ניז), among others. This step flags 650 sentences across the full sample.

Because dictionary-based flagging inevitably captures incidental mentions of press-related terms (e.g., a journalist’s name mentioned in unrelated reporting), we use GPT-4 to classify each flagged sentence as either a substantive reference to attacks on the press or an incidental mention. The prompt instructs the model to identify sentences that discuss politicians attacking criticizing, or delegitimizing journalists; threats to press freedom or media independence; journalists being targeted, ranked, or pressured by political actors; or meta-commentary about the relationship between politicians and the press. For sentences classified as substantively relevant, the mode also codes the tone as critical of the attack, supportive of the attack, or neutral/descriptive.

Of the 650 flagged sentences, 146 (22.5%) are classified as containing substantive references to attacks on the press. Table A10 summarizes these references by treatment status and period.

Table A10: Press-Attack References by Treatment Status and Period

		Total Flagged	Substantive	% Substantive
Targeted	Pre-Attack	162	33	20.4
Targeted	Post-Attack	214	45	21.0
Non-Targeted	Pre-Attack	86	15	17.4
Non-Targeted	Post-Attack	188	53	28.2
<i>Total</i>		650	146	22.5

Sentences flagged via a dictionary of press-freedom terms and classified by GPT-4 as containing a substantive reference to attacks on the press (“Substantive”) or an incidental mention of press-related terms.

A notable descriptive pattern emerges from Table A10: among non-targeted shows, the share of press-related sentences classified as substantive references to attacks on the press nearly doubles from the pre- to post-attack period (17.4% to 28.2%), suggesting that the Melukdim list generated broader media discussion of political threats to press freedom. Among targeted shows, however, this share remains essentially unchanged (20.4% to 21.0%). While the formal event-study analysis below does not identify a statistically significant differential effect, this descriptive pattern is suggestive: even as non-targeted colleagues increasingly discussed political attacks on the press, targeted journalists did not similarly amplify this topic. This is consistent with the interpretation that targeted journalists responded through their substantive government coverage—where we observe a backlash effect—rather than through explicit on-air discussion of the attack itself.

To formally test whether targeted journalists differentially change their discussion of press-related attacks, we aggregate the count of substantive press-attack references to the show-period level and estimate the same event-study specifications used in our main analysis. Figure A9 reports both TWFE and Callaway-Sant’Anna estimates, with the TWFE specification including fixed effects for show, period, and number of shows per period, and standard errors clustered at the show level. None of the event-time coefficients are statistically significant under either estimator, indicating that targeted journalists do not differentially increase or decrease their on-air discussion of political attacks on the press following the Melukdim list’s publication.

Combined with the main finding of a backlash effect in anti-government content, these results suggest that targeted journalists respond by increasing their criticism of the government broadly rather than by explicitly discussing the attack on the press itself.

To complement the broadcast-level analysis, we also examined whether targeted journalists discussed the attack on their personal social media accounts (Twitter/X and Facebook) during the month following the attack (December 1, 2024–January 1, 2025). Of the 26 journalists included on the Melukdim list, only one directly referenced the attack on social media, and three others posted generally about political attacks on the press. The remaining 22 journalists made no public social media statements about the attack during this period. This pattern reinforces our broadcast-level

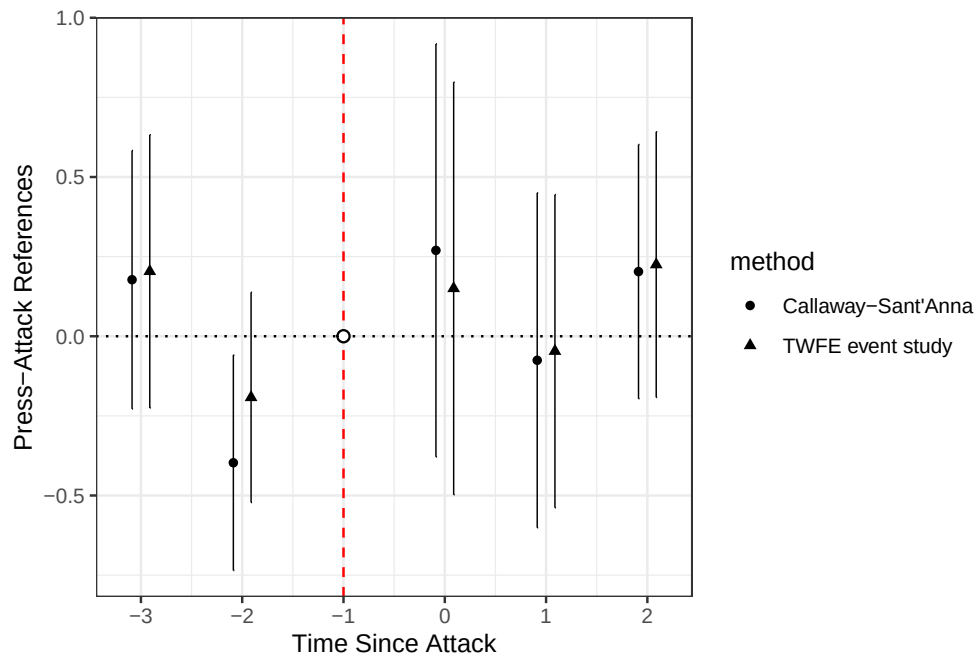


Figure A9: Event Study: Press-Attack References Among Targeted vs. Non-Targeted Shows
TWFE and Callaway-Sant'Anna event-study estimates of the effect of being targeted on the number of substantive press-attack references per show-period (5-day aggregation). TWFE specification includes fixed effects for show, period, and number of shows, with standard errors clustered at the show level. 95% confidence intervals shown.

findings suggesting that targeted journalists channeled their response through their professional editorial choices. They increased substantive government criticism on air rather than through personal public commentary about the attack itself. This is consistent with the boundary-maintenance mechanism, in which journalists defend their professional role through the practice of journalism rather than through personal advocacy.

E Survey Studies

Studies 2a, 2b, and 3 in the main text were fielded using an online survey distributed by iPanel between July 22, 2025 and August 5, 2025. After screening on attention, a total of 3,268 respondents were assigned to the treatment or control conditions related to each study. To avoid order effects in selection and evaluation tasks we further randomized the order of studies 2a-b. Following iPanel guidance, we employed quota sampling, considering respondents age, religiosity, locality, and gender, to ensure that our sample mirrors the general Jewish population in terms of key covariates.

E.1 Ethical Considerations

All participants provided informed and voluntary consent at the start of the Qualtrics survey via a dedicated consent page in Hebrew that described the study purpose (media consumption and current events), expected duration (10 minutes), minimal risks, data security consistent with IRB standards, the voluntary nature of participation, the right to skip questions or discontinue without penalty, and contact information for the authors and IRB. Participants were compensated in line with iPanel’s standard payment policy, with an additional optional lottery incentive (equivalent to 100 NIS in points) contingent on answering three general knowledge questions. Given local norms for online panel research and iPanel guidance, we view this compensation structure as fair in both local and broader comparative contexts and unlikely to exert undue influence. Studies 2a, 2b, and 3 were fielded through iPanel between July 22, 2025 and August 5, 2025, using quota sampling on age, religiosity, locality, and gender to ensure coverage of key sociodemographic variation and to approximate the general Jewish population. Because this research focuses on the general adult

Jewish population recruited through a reputable panel and involves minimal-risk survey and experimental tasks, the participant pool did not contain vulnerable or marginalized groups. Nonetheless, we designed materials to avoid stigmatizing language, allowed nonresponse to any item, and maintained strong confidentiality protections. Finally, we do not believe the research to differentially harm particular groups. The primary anticipated benefit is contribution to scholarly understanding of media consumption in democracies, while risks are limited to minimal informational and privacy risks mitigated through secure data storage and anonymized reporting.

E.2 Survey Flow

- **Informed Consent and Introduction.**
- **Demographics and Attention Checks.** Respondents reported basic demographic information, including:
 - Ethnicity
 - Education level
 - Age group
 - Gender
 - Geographic location
 - Religious affiliation
 - Political ideology (7-point left–right scale)
 - News consumption sources
 - Government support
 - We embedded in this block two attention checks. Failure to pass checks resulted in exclusion from the sample.
- **Experiment 1: Journalist Selection.** Participants were told they would answer factual questions about current events and could choose up to three journalists whose articles to read be-

forehand. Within this task we randomize the topical domain of the exercise to focus on **Law** (judicial independence) or **Health and Technology** (Teva Pharmaceuticals). Moreover, one of four journalist profiles biography was randomized to include a mention of how they have been a subject of government led-political attacks in the past. While journalist names were all fictitious, we employed original new sources (often shortened) from main stream Israeli media outlets.

- The primary outcome in this study is whether a respondent selects to read about a journalist who has been subject to attacks on the press.
- **Experiment 2: Article Evaluation.** All participants read a short news article written by a journalist described as “Yariv Levi.” While Levi was a fictitious journalist, we employed original, shortened new sources from main stream Israeli media outlets for the purpose of this experiment. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of two topics: AI and the labor market, or Military conscription law for ultra-Orthodox men. After reading the article, reported outcomes of interest, including:
 - *Knowledge Retention*: three knowledge questions (combined into an overall knowledge retention index).
 - *Article Evaluation metrics*: eliciting respondents evaluation of the article’s informativeness, professionalism, novelty, and shareability (combined into a 4-item [0-100] evaluation scale).
 - *Perceived Bias*: measuring perceptions of article favorability toward government vs. opposition (single-item measures ranging from 0-100)
- **Experiment 3: Press Attack Treatment.** In the final experiment, participants were randomly assigned to read one of two short vignettes. **Treatment**: a news article depicting the Likud-affiliated campaign attacking Kan radio hosts (https://www.calcalist.co.il/local_news/article/hjbmdcymjl#google_vignette). **Control**: a news article about

NASA's plans to return to the moon (<https://www.calcalist.co.il/internet/articles/0,7340,L-3850937,00.html>). After reading this vignette, respondents completed several outcome batteries measured on 100-point slider scales:

- *Trust in Institutions*: trust in the government, opposition, Kan, and Channel 14
- *Perceived Democratic Backsliding*: eliciting respondents' perceptions regarding existing threats to judicial independence, press freedom, and democracy (combined into 3-item index)
- *Social Distance*: eliciting willingness to accept outparty supporters as close friends, family members, work-supervisors, teachers, or government officials (combined into five-items scale)
- *Recall*: We also asked all respondents whether they recall a recent event in which a Likud-affiliated media outlet targeted Kan radio hosts, ranking them by their level of government support.

E.3 Descriptive Statistics and Diagnostics

In Table A11, we report descriptive statistics for our full sample. In Figure A10 we further report balance covariates (top panel), as well as balance across treatment conditions (bottom panel). We show that our three primary treatments do not correlate with pre-treatment covariates or treatments from other studies fielded on the same survey.

In Figure A11 we further visualize patterns of attrition in our survey. Given the length of our survey which included three different studies, we are faced with noticeable patterns of attrition. Importantly, however, as we show in Figure A12, these patterns unlikely pose a threat to attrition. None of our treatment consistently correlate with non-response to post-treatment outcomes, reducing concerns regarding differential attrition in response to treatment. We do, however, find that attrition correlates with gender for all outcomes, and political preferences for a subset of outcomes. Thus, we encourage readers to interpret our estimates as sample average treatment effects.

Table A11: Survey Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N
Ideology	2.96	1.45	1.00	7.00	3268
Age	3.22	1.58	1.00	6.00	3268
Religiosity	1.68	0.82	1.00	4.00	3268
Female	0.53	0.50	0.00	1.00	3268
Male	0.47	0.50	0.00	1.00	3268
Experiment 1: Selection	0.38	0.48	0.00	1.00	2914
Experiment 2: Number of Correct Answers	2.25	0.88	0.00	3.00	2869
Experiment 2: Article Evaluation	54.42	22.06	0.00	100.00	2817
Experiment 2: Pro-Gov Salience	25.54	25.19	0.00	100.00	2653
Experiment 2: Pro-Opp Salience	35.31	29.90	0.00	100.00	2662
Experiment 3: Backsliding Perceptions	54.30	35.13	0.00	100.00	2492
Experiment 3: Social Distance	53.64	27.98	0.00	100.00	2489
Experiment 3: Trust Gov	37.58	33.08	0.00	100.00	2492
Experiment 3: Trust Opp	33.03	27.02	0.00	100.00	2493
Experiment 3: Trust Channel 11	53.70	31.15	0.00	100.00	2498
Experiment 3: Trust Channel 14	34.67	35.44	0.00	100.00	2491

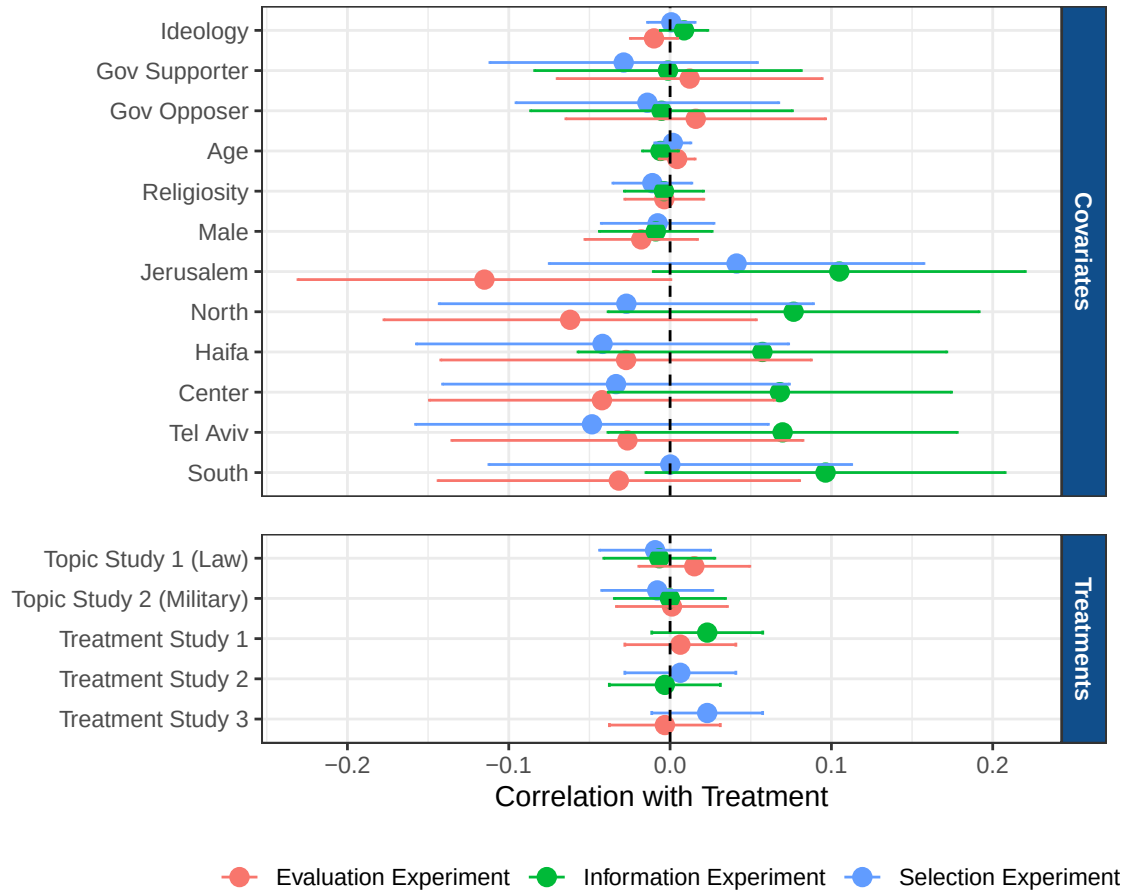


Figure A10: **Balance on Covariates and Additional Treatments.** This Figure reports balance for all three experiments. Point estimates and corresponding 95% CI are extracted from three separated regressions in which a treatment indicator is regressed over covariates and additional treatments. Table format results reported in Table A14.

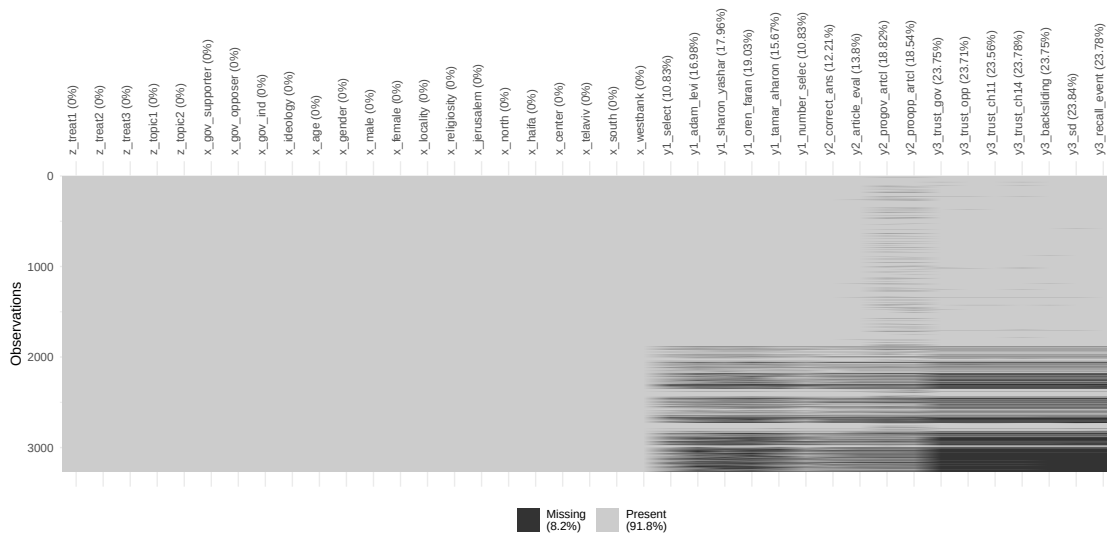


Figure A11: **Patterns of Attrition.** This Figure reports the overall pattern of attrition in our survey, and the stage at which each respondent attrites.

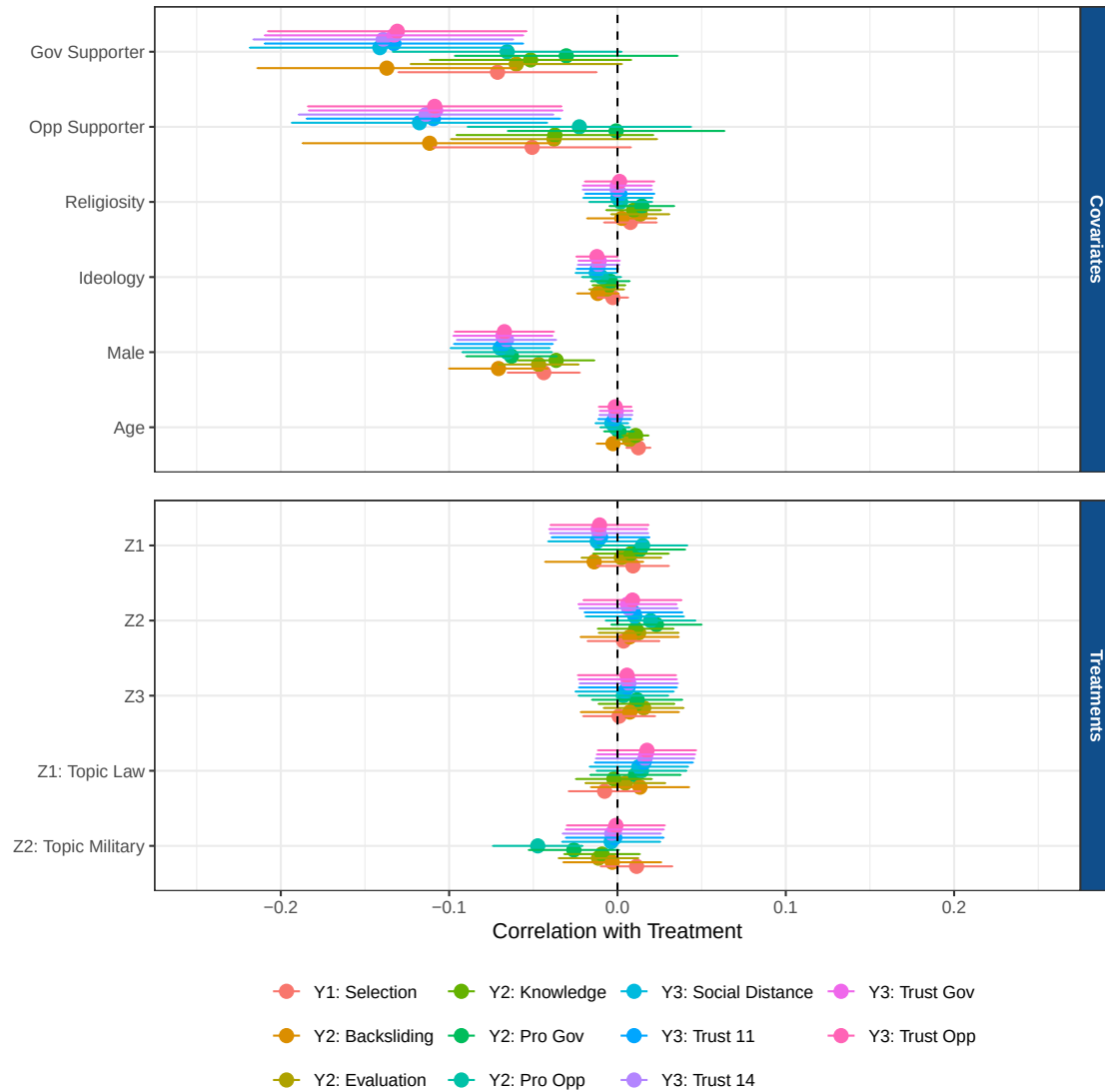


Figure A12: **Correlates of Attrition.** This Figure reports estimates from OLS regressions in which we regress a measure of non-response to each primary outcome, over all treatments and key covariates. We report point estimates alongside 95% confidence intervals showing no meaningful pattern of differential attrition by treatment, but some differential attrition by select pre-treatment covariates.

E.4 Additional analyses

In this section, we report additional analyses which we pre-registered in our pre-analysis plan.

E.4.1 Selection Experiment

In Figure A13 we consider whether the effects that attacks on the press have on consumers' selection behavior vary by topic of coverage. Note that we randomized the topic about which respondents were asked to read, in order to consider the extent to which attacks shape selection behavior when consumers focus on political or a-political content. All estimates reported in Figure A13 are directionally similar. While the magnitude of effects among opposition supporters reading about political topics is almost double in magnitude when benchmarked against opposition supporters reading about non-political topics, these differences are not statistically significant. We thus do not find strong evidence to suggest that selection behavior varies across experimental topics.

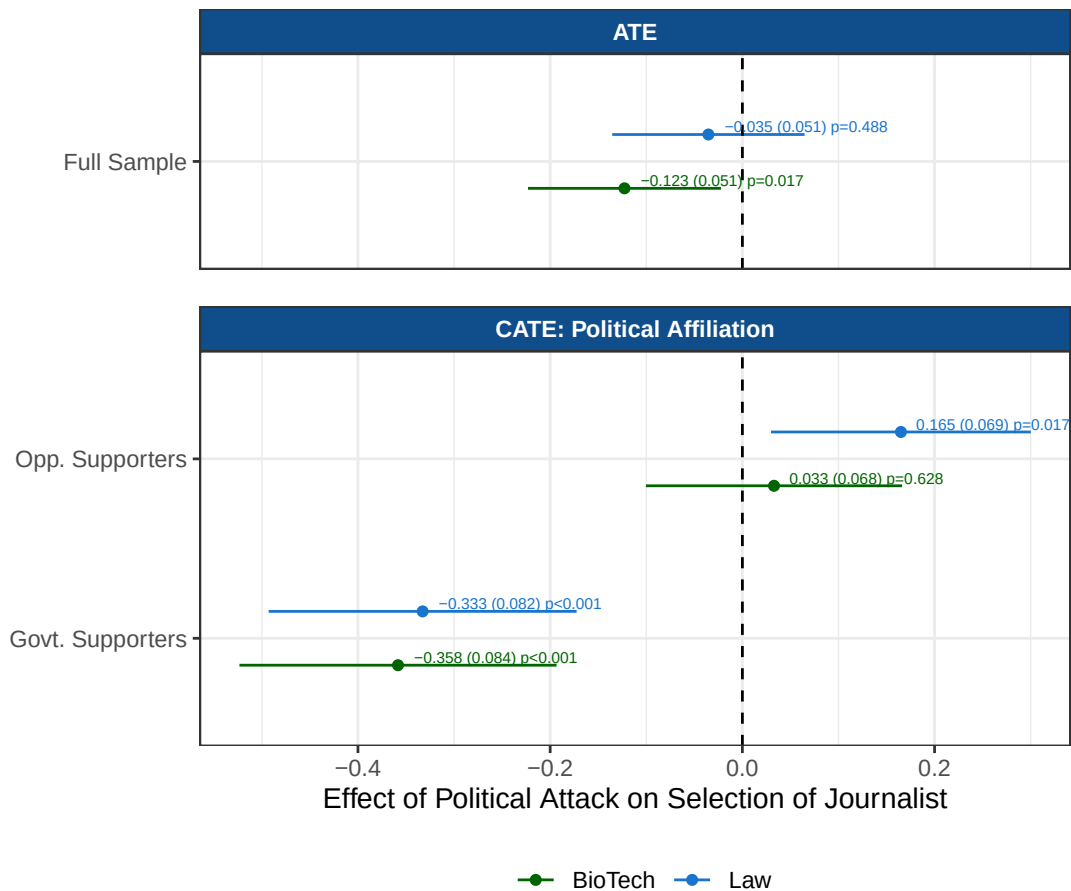


Figure A13: Effects of Attack on Media Selection by Topic.

E.4.2 Evaluation Experiment

In Figure A14 we consider variation in how attacks on the press influence evaluation of journalistic content, driven by our topical treatment. These analyses generate several interesting insights. First, among opposition supporters, the negative (positive) effects on knowledge retention (article evaluation) are driven by respondents assigned to a political (non-political) content. Second, effects on perceptions of articles' political slant are mostly homogeneous across topics. When considering effects among government supporters, we find that for all outcomes, other than knowledge retention, government supporters are more sensitive to treatment under the political topic treatment.

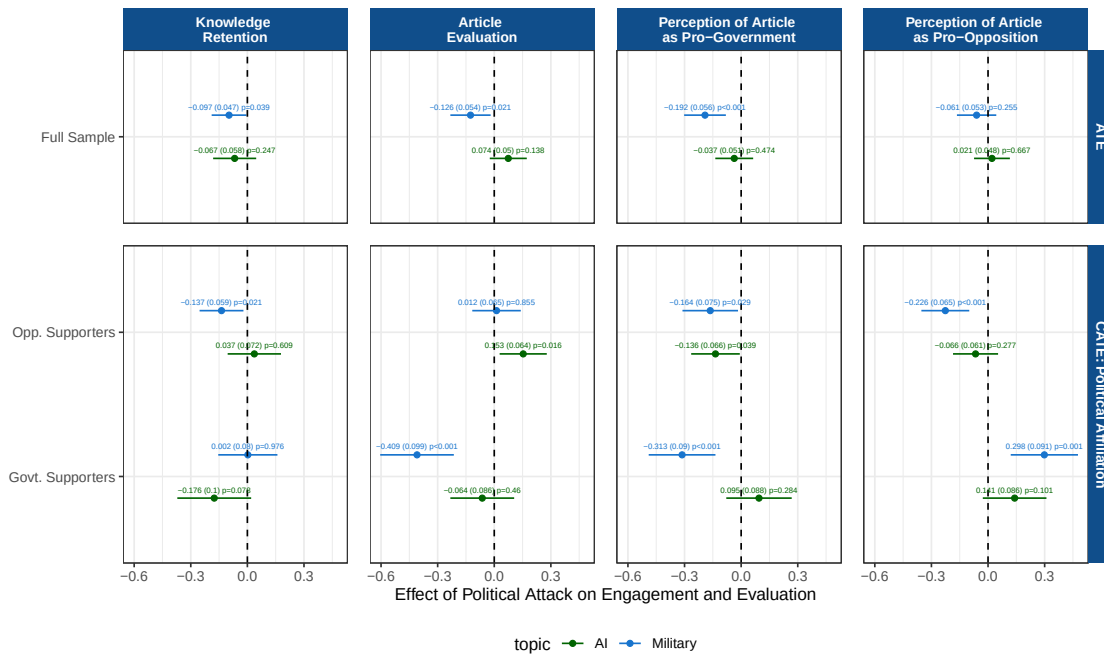


Figure A14: Effects of Attack on Media Evaluation by Topic.

To explore the underlying mechanism driving effects on knowledge retention, in Figure A15 we consider the effects of the government attack treatment on the amount of time respondents' spend reading journalistic content. We find that government attacks reduce respondents' time spent on articles, and that this effect is primarily driven by opposition supporters.

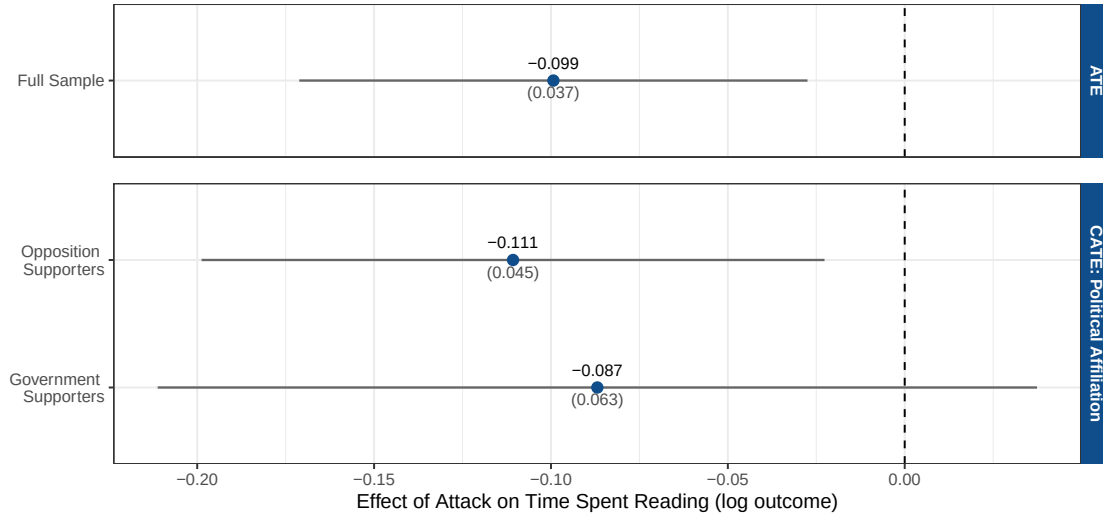


Figure A15: Effects of Attack on Time Spent on Article.

E.4.3 Information Experiment

In Figure A16 we report additional results from our information experiment, examining how learning about the Likud attack on Kan radio hosts affect respondents trust in the Kan network, as well as channel 14, a competing pro-government media channel. Overall, we do not find strong evidence that treatment shifted trust in media.

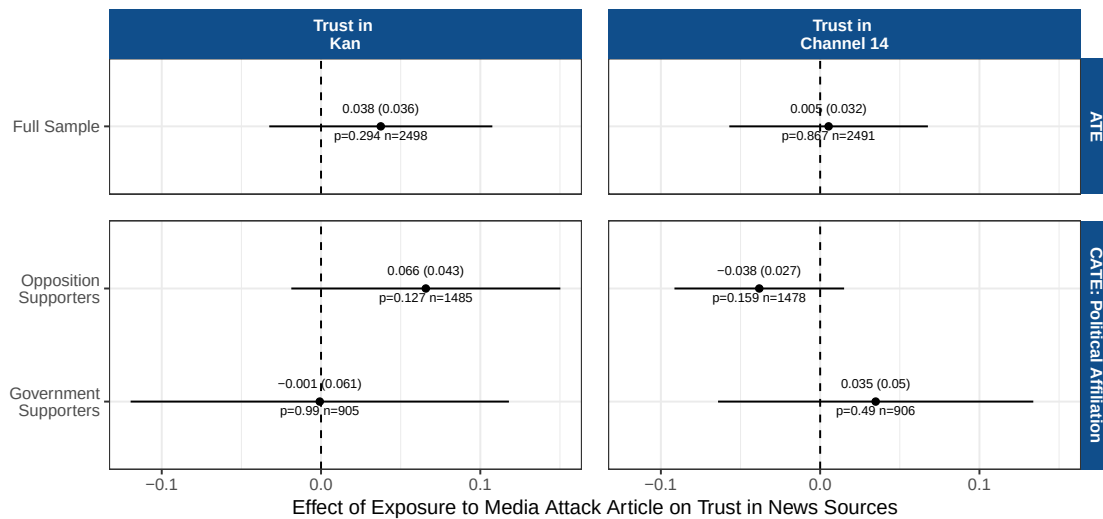


Figure A16: Effects of Attack on Trust in News Sources.

Finally, in Figure A17 we examine whether control group respondents who did not receive

exposure to the article depicting attacks on Kan radio hosts recall the event. We show that only 7.3% of respondents recall the event eight months post-treatment, and that men and opposition supporters were more likely to recall these attacks.

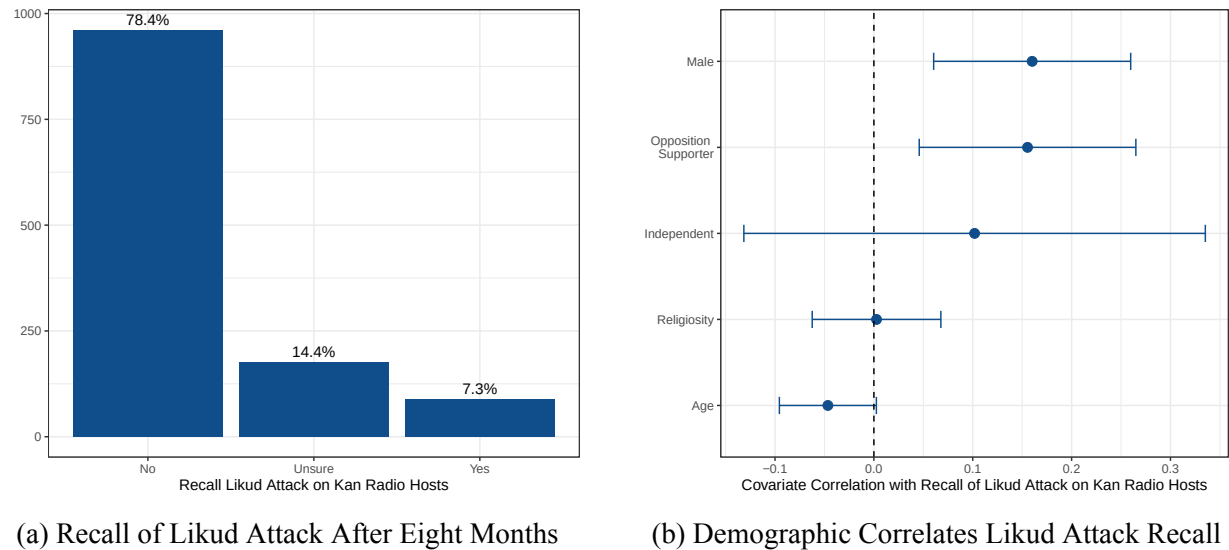


Figure A17: **Recall Patterns of Likud Attack Against Kan11 Journalists After Eight Months.** This figure reports descriptive survey data from all respondents who were not exposed to information about the Likud attack on radio hosts in December 2024.

E.5 Extension Studies

Through a final pre-registered survey, we extend Studies 2a and 2b, and introduce a second set of treatments: opposition led attacks on journalists. Whereas the original experiments manipulated whether a journalist had been attacked by *government* officials, the extension uses a three-arm design: (i) a *control* condition with no attack, (ii) a *government attack* in which coalition (Likud) members are described as attacking the journalist’s work as politically biased, and (iii) an *opposition attack* in which members of the center-left opposition (the “Change Bloc”) are described as doing so. This design separates the effect of *being attacked* from the effect of *who* attacks.

The study was fielded on the Midgam online panel between July 29 and August 4, 2026, focusing on government and opposition supporters. Of the 3,573 respondents who entered the survey, 3,377 passed the consent and attention screens and were randomized into the experiments, and 3,037 completed the full study. The selection and evaluation tasks were otherwise identical to

Table A12: Descriptive statistics: numeric covariates (Study 4, randomized sample).

	Mean	SD	Min	Median	Max
Ideology	2.96	1.56	1.00	3.00	7.00
Age	3.45	1.55	1.00	3.00	6.00

Table A13: Descriptive statistics: categorical covariates (Study 4, randomized sample).

		N	Percent
Gender	Male	1637	48.47
	Female/Other	1740	51.53
Religiosity	Secular	1710	50.64
	Traditional	616	18.24
	Religious	475	14.07
	Ultra-Orthodox	576	17.06
Locality	Jerusalem	431	12.76
	North	247	7.31
	Haifa	499	14.78
	Center	977	28.93
	Tel Aviv	711	21.05
	South	312	9.24
	West Bank	200	5.92
Partisanship	Government supporter	1520	45.01
	Opposition supporter	1832	54.25
	Independent	25	0.74

Studies 2a and 2b—in their outcomes, journalist profiles, and randomized topics (law vs. biotechnology for selection; AI vs. military conscription for evaluation)—the only change being the added opposition-attack arm. Because our congruence and subgroup analyses require partisan information, we block-randomized treatment within blocs of government and opposition supporters (the small number of independents who entered our survey were randomized into a bloc). Tables [A12–A13](#) report descriptive statistics for the randomized sample.

Figures [A18–A20](#) report standard design diagnostics. Treatment assignment is uncorrelated with pre-treatment covariates in both experiments (Figure [A18](#)), consistent with successful randomization. No attack arm predicts survey non-completion (Figure [A19](#)); as in our original study, attrition correlates with some demographics (notably gender and age) but not with treatment, so we

again interpret our estimates as sample average treatment effects. Figure A20 reports the partisan composition of the randomized sample.

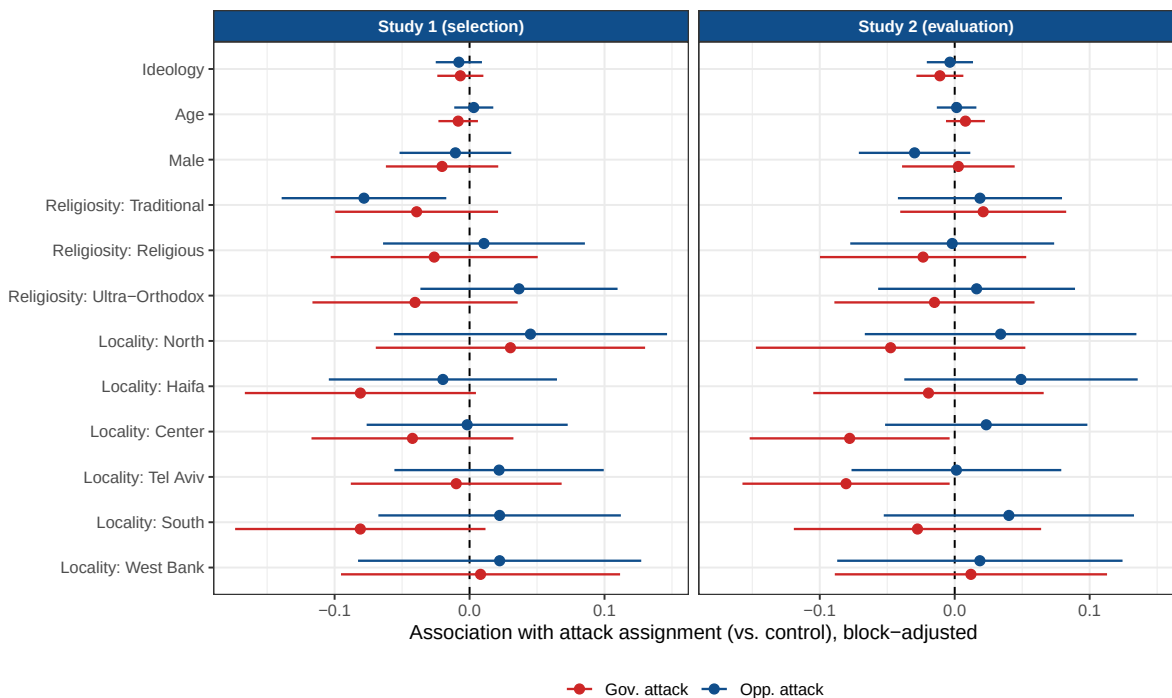


Figure A18: **Covariate balance across treatment arms (Study 4).** For each experiment (selection and evaluation) and each attack arm, points are coefficients from a OLS regression with block fixed effects where arm assignment—government attack vs. control and opposition attack vs. control—is regress over all pre-treatment covariates, with 95% confidence intervals (HC2 robust standard errors). Estimates cluster around zero, consistent with successful randomization. Table format results reported in Table A17.

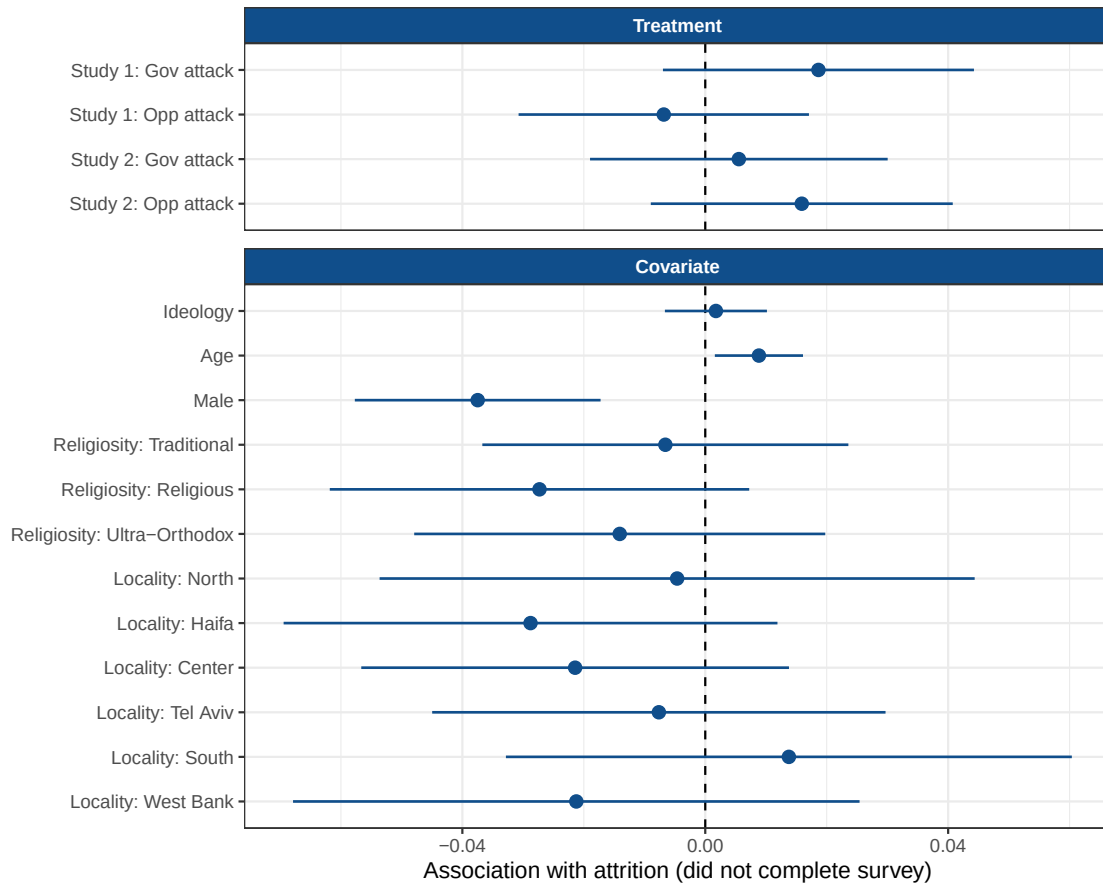


Figure A19: **Predictors of survey attrition (Study 4).** Coefficients from a OLS regression with Block fixed effects where a non-completion indicator (1 = did not finish the survey) is regressed over both treatments (government/opposition attack relative to control), and all pre-treatment covariates, with 95% confidence intervals (HC2 standard errors). The top panel reports the treatment arms and the bottom panel the covariates. No attack arm significantly predicts attrition, indicating no differential attrition across conditions. Table format results reported in Table A18.

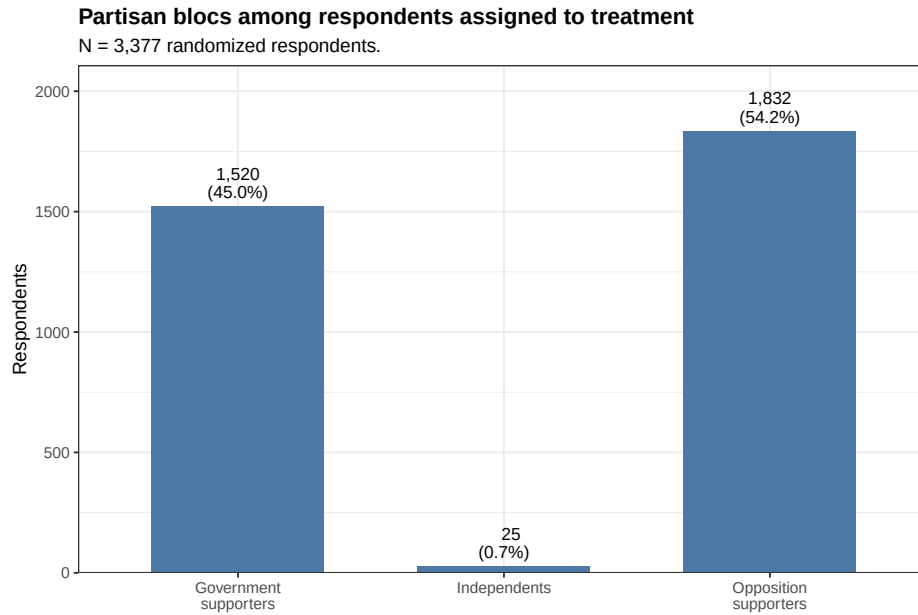


Figure A20: **Partisan composition of the randomized sample (Study 4).** Number and share of respondents classified as government supporters, opposition supporters, or independents, among all respondents assigned to treatment.

The selection results are reported in the main text (Figure 6; table-format results in Table A16). Figure A21 extends the evaluation experiment (Study 2b) to the three-arm design. Consistent with the selection findings, attacks shift how respondents evaluate journalistic content: both government and opposition attacks modestly raise perceived article quality in average, but these results are driven by partisan responses to outparty attacks. Moreover, attacks shift perceptions of the article’s political slant in directions consistent with the attacker’s identity—government attacks reduce perceived pro-government slant, whereas opposition attacks increase perceived pro-government slant and reduce perceived pro-opposition slant. As in the selection experiment, these effects are polarized across partisan subgroups, and we find no consistent effects on knowledge retention.

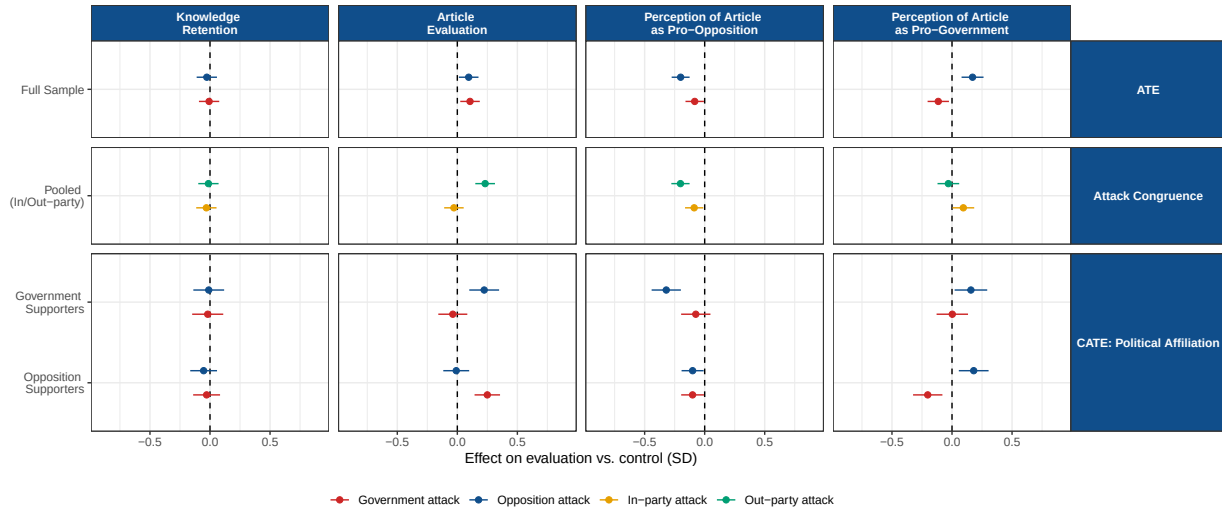


Figure A21: **Effects of political attacks on article evaluation (Study 4).** This figure reports Covariate-adjusted treatment effects employing our primary specification on the four evaluation outcomes (knowledge retention, article evaluation, and perceived pro-opposition and pro-government slant) estimated for the full sample (ATE), pooled by attack congruence (in-party vs. out-party), and by respondent partisanship (CATE). We report standardized point estimates (by control-group SD units) with 95% confidence intervals; colors denote the attacker identity. Table-format results (full Lin regressions with treatment×covariate interactions, one column per estimand) are reported per outcome in Tables [A19](#) (knowledge retention), [A20](#) (article evaluation), [A21](#) (pro-government slant), and [A22](#) (pro-opposition slant).

F Table Format Results

Table A14: Balance Tests for Experiments

	Selection Study	Evaluation Study	Information Study
z_topic1Law	−0.009 (0.018)	0.015 (0.018)	−0.007 (0.018)
z_topic2Military	−0.008 (0.018)	0.001 (0.018)	0.000 (0.018)
z_treat2	0.006 (0.018)		−0.003 (0.018)
z_treat3	0.023 (0.018)	−0.003 (0.018)	
x_ideology	0.001 (0.008)	−0.010 (0.007)	0.009 (0.007)
x_age	0.002 (0.006)	0.004 (0.006)	−0.006 (0.006)
x_religiosity	−0.011 (0.012)	−0.004 (0.012)	−0.004 (0.013)
x_gov_supporter	−0.029 (0.042)	0.012 (0.042)	−0.001 (0.042)
x_gov_opposer	−0.014 (0.042)	0.016 (0.041)	−0.005 (0.041)
x_male	−0.008 (0.018)	−0.018 (0.018)	−0.009 (0.018)
x_jerusalem	0.041 (0.059)	−0.115+ (0.059)	0.105+ (0.059)
x_north	−0.027 (0.059)	−0.062 (0.059)	0.077 (0.059)
x_haifa	−0.042 (0.059)	−0.027 (0.059)	0.057 (0.058)
x_center	−0.034 (0.055)	−0.042 (0.055)	0.068 (0.054)
x_telaviv	−0.048 (0.056)	−0.026 (0.056)	0.070 (0.055)
x_south	0.000 (0.057)	−0.032 (0.057)	0.096+ (0.057)
z_treat1		0.006 (0.018)	0.023 (0.018)
Num.Obs.	3268	3268	3268
R2	0.004	0.004	0.003
RMSE	0.50	0.50	0.50

Each regression estimates the correlation between a study's primary treatment and demographic covariates. Models also include other study treatments assigned at the start of the survey.

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table A15: Effects of Government Attacks on Media Selection

	All respondents	Government supporters	Government opposers
z_treat1	−0.076*	−0.337***	0.099*
z_topic1Law_c	−0.036	−0.013	−0.039
x_ideology_c	0.047*	0.076	0.051+
x_age_c	−0.036*	−0.076**	−0.011
x_religiosity_c	0.039	−0.012	0.032
x_gender_c	−0.231***	−0.153+	−0.288***
(as.factor(x_locality)2)_c	−0.405***	−0.263	−0.545**
(as.factor(x_locality)3)_c	−0.306*	0.023	−0.579***
(as.factor(x_locality)4)_c	−0.376***	−0.255	−0.509***
(as.factor(x_locality)5)_c	−0.335**	−0.224	−0.462***
(as.factor(x_locality)6)_c	−0.339**	−0.135	−0.510**
(as.factor(x_locality)7)_c	−0.186	−0.166	−0.363
z_treat1 × z_topic1Law_c	0.093	0.028	0.142
z_treat1 × x_ideology_c	0.097***	0.082	0.049
z_treat1 × x_age_c	0.003	0.041	−0.021
z_treat1 × x_religiosity_c	−0.109*	0.041	−0.150+
z_treat1 × x_gender_c	0.097	−0.001	0.150
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)2)_c	0.292+	0.176	0.405+
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)3)_c	0.064	−0.229	0.252
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)4)_c	0.292*	0.150	0.370*
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)5)_c	0.234+	0.013	0.355+
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)6)_c	0.220	0.269	0.210
z_treat1 × (as.factor(x_locality)7)_c	−0.018	0.124	−0.079
Num.Obs.	2914	1058	1715
R2	0.049	0.074	0.047
RMSE	0.97	0.93	0.98

Each regression estimates the effects of the government attack treatment on a binary indicator taking a value of 1 if a respondent selected to read an article written by a targeted journalist.

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table A16: Extension study, selection experiment: Lin regressions with treatment $\times$ covariate interactions.

	Full: Gov	Full: Opp	In-party	Out-party	GovSup: Gov	GovSup: Opp	OppSup: Gov	OppSup: Opp
Attack (vs. control)	−0.150*** (0.042)	−0.143*** (0.041)	−0.347*** (0.041)	0.057 (0.043)	−0.478*** (0.062)	−0.028 (0.064)	0.115 (0.059)	−0.243*** (0.054)
Ideology	0.008 (0.025)	0.008 (0.025)	0.006 (0.025)	0.006 (0.025)	−0.053 (0.046)	−0.053 (0.046)	0.037 (0.031)	0.037 (0.031)
Age	−0.043* (0.021)	−0.043* (0.021)	−0.042 (0.021)	−0.042 (0.021)	0.014 (0.032)	0.014 (0.032)	−0.096*** (0.029)	−0.096*** (0.029)
Male	0.024 (0.061)	0.024 (0.061)	0.025 (0.061)	0.025 (0.061)	0.016 (0.092)	0.016 (0.092)	0.063 (0.082)	0.063 (0.082)
Religiosity: Traditional	0.136 (0.089)	0.136 (0.089)	0.129 (0.089)	0.129 (0.089)	0.180 (0.136)	0.180 (0.136)	0.143 (0.126)	0.143 (0.126)
Religiosity: Religious	0.154 (0.111)	0.154 (0.111)	0.146 (0.112)	0.146 (0.112)	0.252 (0.144)	0.252 (0.144)	0.029 (0.213)	0.029 (0.213)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.184 (0.114)	0.184 (0.114)	0.179 (0.114)	0.179 (0.114)	0.352* (0.154)	0.352* (0.154)	−0.030 (0.203)	−0.030 (0.203)
Locality: North	−0.293 (0.151)	−0.293 (0.151)	−0.306* (0.151)	−0.306* (0.151)	−0.252 (0.208)	−0.252 (0.208)	−0.324 (0.245)	−0.324 (0.245)
Locality: Haifa	−0.108 (0.125)	−0.108 (0.125)	−0.121 (0.125)	−0.121 (0.125)	−0.232 (0.180)	−0.232 (0.180)	−0.056 (0.208)	−0.056 (0.208)
Locality: Center	−0.260* (0.111)	−0.260* (0.111)	−0.275* (0.111)	−0.275* (0.111)	−0.292* (0.142)	−0.292* (0.142)	−0.278 (0.198)	−0.278 (0.198)
Locality: Tel Aviv	−0.098 (0.117)	−0.098 (0.117)	−0.107 (0.117)	−0.107 (0.117)	−0.016 (0.157)	−0.016 (0.157)	−0.150 (0.203)	−0.150 (0.203)
Locality: South	−0.205 (0.135)	−0.205 (0.135)	−0.217 (0.135)	−0.217 (0.135)	−0.291 (0.164)	−0.291 (0.164)	−0.136 (0.238)	−0.136 (0.238)
Locality: West Bank	−0.239 (0.159)	−0.239 (0.159)	−0.250 (0.159)	−0.250 (0.159)	−0.310 (0.182)	−0.310 (0.182)	−0.179 (0.361)	−0.179 (0.361)
Topic (Law)	0.011 (0.060)	0.011 (0.060)	0.012 (0.061)	0.012 (0.061)	0.072 (0.091)	0.072 (0.091)	−0.045 (0.081)	−0.045 (0.081)
Block (opp.)	−0.123 (0.082)	−0.123 (0.082)	−0.123 (0.083)	−0.123 (0.083)				
Attack $\times$ Ideology	0.032 (0.035)	−0.031 (0.035)	−0.011 (0.034)	0.024 (0.037)	0.028 (0.060)	−0.060 (0.067)	0.032 (0.044)	−0.028 (0.042)
Attack $\times$ Age	−0.001 (0.030)	0.009 (0.029)	0.007 (0.029)	0.000 (0.031)	−0.047 (0.043)	−0.052 (0.045)	0.042 (0.042)	0.060 (0.040)
Attack $\times$ Male	0.020 (0.085)	0.192* (0.084)	0.133 (0.083)	0.106 (0.087)	0.092 (0.124)	0.215 (0.130)	−0.042 (0.119)	0.137 (0.112)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Traditional	−0.105 (0.125)	−0.117 (0.125)	0.004 (0.122)	−0.203 (0.130)	0.042 (0.188)	−0.201 (0.200)	−0.162 (0.178)	−0.111 (0.169)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Religious	−0.262 (0.155)	0.013 (0.154)	−0.086 (0.151)	−0.125 (0.159)	−0.183 (0.194)	−0.123 (0.200)	−0.350 (0.325)	−0.014 (0.284)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	−0.374* (0.155)	0.062 (0.153)	−0.069 (0.154)	−0.191 (0.158)	−0.334 (0.204)	−0.174 (0.208)	−0.476 (0.281)	0.472 (0.273)
Attack $\times$ Locality: North	0.261 (0.205)	0.353 (0.209)	0.250 (0.203)	0.380 (0.210)	0.187 (0.283)	0.480 (0.294)	0.375 (0.328)	0.318 (0.318)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Haifa	0.216 (0.179)	−0.046 (0.171)	0.125 (0.172)	0.080 (0.180)	0.254 (0.259)	−0.243 (0.253)	0.258 (0.288)	0.071 (0.269)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Center	0.267 (0.153)	0.275 (0.153)	0.303* (0.151)	0.294 (0.157)	0.315 (0.196)	0.315 (0.202)	0.343 (0.270)	0.314 (0.256)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Tel Aviv	0.185 (0.160)	0.055 (0.160)	0.178 (0.159)	0.100 (0.163)	0.095 (0.212)	−0.119 (0.217)	0.296 (0.276)	0.221 (0.263)
Attack $\times$ Locality: South	0.184 (0.190)	0.178 (0.186)	0.053 (0.181)	0.322 (0.194)	0.051 (0.226)	0.315 (0.237)	0.417 (0.344)	0.051 (0.308)
Attack $\times$ Locality: West Bank	0.366 (0.216)	0.271 (0.217)	0.190 (0.209)	0.498* (0.223)	0.337 (0.247)	0.468 (0.259)	0.638 (0.473)	−0.072 (0.429)
Attack $\times$ Topic (Law)	−0.068 (0.085)	0.081 (0.083)	0.015 (0.082)	−0.005 (0.087)	−0.141 (0.123)	−0.030 (0.129)	0.012 (0.118)	0.144 (0.109)
Attack $\times$ Block (opp.)	0.354** (0.117)	−0.148 (0.114)	0.186 (0.112)	0.010 (0.122)				
N	2103	2159	2113	2120	951	979	1141	1162
R^2	0.047	0.067	0.061	0.028	0.087	0.056	0.038	0.054

Each column is a pairwise Lin (2013) regression of the standardized outcome on a single attack arm relative to control (HC2 robust standard errors), reproducing the matching coefficient-plot estimate. Full: full sample; In-/Out-party: pooled attack-congruence contrasts; GovSup/OppSup: government / opposition supporters. Covariates are mean-centered; rows below the treatment effect are covariate main effects and treatment *times* covariate interactions. Full-sample and congruence columns include a block fixed effect; subgroup columns omit it (constant within subgroup).

Table A17: Extension study: covariate balance across treatment arms (selection and evaluation experiments), block-adjusted (HC2 SEs).

	Sel.: Gov	Sel.: Opp	Eval.: Gov	Eval.: Opp
Ideology	−0.007 (0.009)	−0.008 (0.009)	−0.011 (0.009)	−0.004 (0.009)
Age	−0.008 (0.007)	0.003 (0.007)	0.008 (0.007)	0.001 (0.007)
Male	−0.020 (0.021)	−0.010 (0.021)	0.003 (0.021)	−0.030 (0.021)
Religiosity: Traditional	−0.039 (0.031)	−0.078* (0.031)	0.021 (0.031)	0.019 (0.031)
Religiosity: Religious	−0.026 (0.039)	0.011 (0.038)	−0.023 (0.039)	−0.002 (0.039)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	−0.040 (0.039)	0.037 (0.037)	−0.015 (0.038)	0.016 (0.037)
Locality: North	0.030 (0.051)	0.045 (0.052)	−0.047 (0.051)	0.034 (0.051)
Locality: Haifa	−0.081 (0.044)	−0.020 (0.043)	−0.019 (0.044)	0.049 (0.044)
Locality: Center	−0.042 (0.038)	−0.002 (0.038)	−0.078* (0.038)	0.023 (0.038)
Locality: Tel Aviv	−0.010 (0.040)	0.022 (0.040)	−0.081* (0.039)	0.001 (0.040)
Locality: South	−0.081 (0.047)	0.022 (0.046)	−0.028 (0.047)	0.040 (0.047)
Locality: West Bank	0.008 (0.053)	0.022 (0.054)	0.012 (0.051)	0.019 (0.054)
Block (opposition)	0.010 (0.029)	0.029 (0.028)	0.055 (0.029)	0.048 (0.029)
N	2248	2278	2248	2278
R^2	0.006	0.007	0.007	0.004

Each column is a linear-probability regression of assignment to that attack arm (vs. control) on all pre-treatment covariates and the block fixed effect. Sel. = selection experiment; Eval. = evaluation experiment.

Table A18: Extension study: predictors of survey attrition, block-adjusted (HC2 SEs).

	Did not complete
Selection: Gov attack	0.019 (0.013)
Selection: Opp attack	−0.007 (0.012)
Evaluation: Gov attack	0.006 (0.012)
Evaluation: Opp attack	0.016 (0.013)
Ideology	0.002 (0.004)
Age	0.009* (0.004)
Male	−0.037*** (0.010)
Religiosity: Traditional	−0.007 (0.015)
Religiosity: Religious	−0.027 (0.018)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	−0.014 (0.017)
Locality: North	−0.005 (0.025)
Locality: Haifa	−0.029 (0.021)
Locality: Center	−0.021 (0.018)
Locality: Tel Aviv	−0.008 (0.019)
Locality: South	0.014 (0.024)
Locality: West Bank	−0.021 (0.024)
Block (opposition)	−0.005 (0.014)
N	3377
R^2	0.011

Linear-probability regression of a non-completion indicator (1 = did not finish the survey) on both treatments (attack arms relative to control), all pre-treatment covariates, and the block fixed effect.

Table A19: Extension study, evaluation experiment: effects on knowledge retention (Lin regressions with treatment $\times$ covariate interactions).

	Full: Gov	Full: Opp	In-party	Out-party	GovSup: Gov	GovSup: Opp	OppSup: Gov	OppSup: Opp
Attack (vs. control)	−0.008 (0.043)	−0.027 (0.043)	−0.030 (0.043)	−0.013 (0.043)	−0.019 (0.066)	−0.010 (0.065)	−0.028 (0.057)	−0.053 (0.057)
Ideology	0.026 (0.025)	0.026 (0.025)	0.028 (0.025)	0.028 (0.025)	−0.006 (0.047)	−0.006 (0.047)	0.047 (0.031)	0.047 (0.031)
Age	0.058** (0.021)	0.058** (0.021)	0.055** (0.021)	0.055** (0.021)	0.060 (0.032)	0.060 (0.032)	0.047 (0.029)	0.047 (0.029)
Male	0.012 (0.060)	0.012 (0.060)	0.014 (0.060)	0.014 (0.060)	−0.020 (0.091)	−0.020 (0.091)	0.055 (0.081)	0.055 (0.081)
Religiosity: Traditional	−0.113 (0.099)	−0.113 (0.099)	−0.128 (0.099)	−0.128 (0.099)	−0.184 (0.146)	−0.184 (0.146)	−0.058 (0.143)	−0.058 (0.143)
Religiosity: Religious	0.133 (0.111)	0.133 (0.111)	0.102 (0.111)	0.102 (0.111)	0.125 (0.136)	0.125 (0.136)	0.124 (0.291)	0.124 (0.291)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.255* (0.104)	0.255* (0.104)	0.222* (0.104)	0.222* (0.104)	0.294* (0.139)	0.294* (0.139)	−0.005 (0.187)	−0.005 (0.187)
Locality: North	0.259 (0.142)	0.259 (0.142)	0.256 (0.142)	0.256 (0.142)	0.306 (0.181)	0.306 (0.181)	0.106 (0.228)	0.106 (0.228)
Locality: Haifa	0.139 (0.122)	0.139 (0.122)	0.144 (0.122)	0.144 (0.122)	0.249 (0.170)	0.249 (0.170)	0.002 (0.189)	0.002 (0.189)
Locality: Center	0.155 (0.109)	0.155 (0.109)	0.161 (0.109)	0.161 (0.109)	0.248 (0.141)	0.248 (0.141)	0.026 (0.180)	0.026 (0.180)
Locality: Tel Aviv	0.185 (0.115)	0.185 (0.115)	0.201 (0.115)	0.201 (0.115)	0.266 (0.155)	0.266 (0.155)	0.094 (0.187)	0.094 (0.187)
Locality: South	−0.023 (0.144)	−0.023 (0.144)	−0.030 (0.144)	−0.030 (0.144)	−0.049 (0.180)	−0.049 (0.180)	−0.025 (0.241)	−0.025 (0.241)
Locality: West Bank	0.303* (0.147)	0.303* (0.147)	0.302* (0.147)	0.302* (0.147)	0.233 (0.177)	0.233 (0.177)	0.735** (0.223)	0.735** (0.223)
Topic (Military)	0.039 (0.060)	0.039 (0.060)	0.034 (0.060)	0.034 (0.060)	0.159 (0.091)	0.159 (0.091)	−0.072 (0.080)	−0.072 (0.080)
Block (opp.)	0.083 (0.090)	0.083 (0.090)	0.049 (0.090)	0.049 (0.090)				
Attack $\times$ Ideology	−0.021 (0.036)	−0.028 (0.036)	−0.007 (0.037)	−0.048 (0.035)	0.007 (0.073)	−0.085 (0.067)	−0.047 (0.043)	−0.011 (0.044)
Attack $\times$ Age	0.007 (0.031)	−0.076* (0.032)	−0.051 (0.033)	−0.013 (0.031)	0.015 (0.048)	−0.032 (0.046)	0.010 (0.042)	−0.104* (0.044)
Attack $\times$ Male	−0.063 (0.086)	0.026 (0.086)	−0.077 (0.086)	0.021 (0.086)	−0.002 (0.132)	0.188 (0.133)	−0.120 (0.116)	−0.113 (0.115)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Traditional	0.024 (0.139)	−0.102 (0.139)	0.102 (0.139)	−0.138 (0.139)	0.292 (0.217)	−0.143 (0.209)	−0.155 (0.196)	−0.008 (0.194)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Religious	−0.123 (0.160)	−0.144 (0.160)	−0.079 (0.162)	−0.118 (0.159)	−0.039 (0.214)	−0.264 (0.199)	0.048 (0.354)	0.173 (0.363)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.026 (0.153)	−0.163 (0.148)	−0.065 (0.154)	−0.010 (0.149)	0.117 (0.219)	−0.138 (0.199)	0.218 (0.259)	−0.103 (0.254)
Attack $\times$ Locality: North	−0.580** (0.212)	−0.196 (0.205)	−0.461* (0.215)	−0.323 (0.206)	−0.608 (0.318)	−0.227 (0.271)	−0.380 (0.324)	−0.069 (0.324)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Haifa	−0.348* (0.168)	−0.157 (0.176)	−0.381* (0.170)	−0.140 (0.174)	−0.470* (0.237)	−0.141 (0.243)	−0.154 (0.270)	−0.033 (0.276)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Center	−0.266 (0.150)	−0.058 (0.159)	−0.235 (0.151)	−0.124 (0.159)	−0.340 (0.194)	−0.173 (0.208)	−0.119 (0.259)	0.089 (0.262)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Tel Aviv	−0.390* (0.163)	−0.091 (0.167)	−0.312 (0.164)	−0.192 (0.165)	−0.553* (0.233)	−0.231 (0.228)	−0.227 (0.263)	0.039 (0.269)
Attack $\times$ Locality: South	−0.228 (0.193)	0.066 (0.205)	−0.099 (0.197)	−0.066 (0.201)	−0.296 (0.245)	−0.041 (0.258)	−0.131 (0.326)	0.266 (0.333)
Attack $\times$ Locality: West Bank	−0.301 (0.194)	−0.254 (0.219)	−0.262 (0.195)	−0.302 (0.217)	−0.225 (0.233)	−0.239 (0.273)	−0.778* (0.342)	−0.569 (0.338)
Attack $\times$ Topic (Military)	−0.047 (0.086)	0.105 (0.087)	0.033 (0.086)	0.030 (0.086)	−0.110 (0.131)	0.059 (0.132)	0.014 (0.115)	0.155 (0.115)
Attack $\times$ Block (opp.)	0.047 (0.126)	−0.021 (0.124)	0.039 (0.127)	0.061 (0.123)				
N	2113	2116	2114	2088	982	971	1117	1132
R^2	0.028	0.023	0.021	0.026	0.045	0.050	0.025	0.026

Each column is a pairwise Lin (2013) regression of the standardized outcome on a single attack arm relative to control (HC2 robust standard errors), reproducing the matching coefficient-plot estimate. Full: full sample; In-/Out-party: pooled attack-congruence contrasts; GovSup/OppSup: government / opposition supporters. Covariates are mean-centered; rows below the treatment effect are covariate main effects and treatment *times* covariate interactions. Full-sample and congruence columns include a block fixed effect; subgroup columns omit it (constant within subgroup).

Table A20: Extension study, evaluation experiment: effects on article evaluation (Lin regressions with treatment $\times$ covariate interactions).

	Full: Gov	Full: Opp	In-party	Out-party	GovSup: Gov	GovSup: Opp	OppSup: Gov	OppSup: Opp
Attack (vs. control)	0.106* (0.041)	0.095* (0.042)	-0.028 (0.041)	0.232*** (0.042)	-0.038 (0.062)	0.224*** (0.063)	0.250*** (0.054)	-0.009 (0.055)
Ideology	-0.044 (0.026)	-0.044 (0.026)	-0.044 (0.026)	-0.044 (0.026)	-0.068 (0.045)	-0.068 (0.045)	-0.026 (0.031)	-0.026 (0.031)
Age	0.040 (0.021)	0.040 (0.021)	0.040 (0.021)	0.040 (0.021)	0.059 (0.030)	0.059 (0.030)	0.012 (0.027)	0.012 (0.027)
Male	-0.035 (0.058)	-0.035 (0.058)	-0.030 (0.058)	-0.030 (0.058)	-0.121 (0.086)	-0.121 (0.086)	0.059 (0.078)	0.059 (0.078)
Religiosity: Traditional	-0.215* (0.087)	-0.215* (0.087)	-0.225* (0.089)	-0.225* (0.089)	-0.203 (0.137)	-0.203 (0.137)	-0.141 (0.121)	-0.141 (0.121)
Religiosity: Religious	-0.358** (0.110)	-0.358** (0.110)	-0.369*** (0.111)	-0.369*** (0.111)	-0.289* (0.139)	-0.289* (0.139)	-0.494* (0.237)	-0.494* (0.237)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	-0.543*** (0.105)	-0.543*** (0.105)	-0.553*** (0.106)	-0.553*** (0.106)	-0.418** (0.142)	-0.418** (0.142)	-0.856*** (0.186)	-0.856*** (0.186)
Locality: North	-0.139 (0.149)	-0.139 (0.149)	-0.140 (0.149)	-0.140 (0.149)	-0.089 (0.208)	-0.089 (0.208)	-0.168 (0.227)	-0.168 (0.227)
Locality: Haifa	-0.138 (0.124)	-0.138 (0.124)	-0.139 (0.124)	-0.139 (0.124)	-0.070 (0.202)	-0.070 (0.202)	-0.235 (0.183)	-0.235 (0.183)
Locality: Center	-0.014 (0.104)	-0.014 (0.104)	-0.016 (0.104)	-0.016 (0.104)	-0.021 (0.133)	-0.021 (0.133)	-0.092 (0.174)	-0.092 (0.174)
Locality: Tel Aviv	-0.042 (0.105)	-0.042 (0.105)	-0.036 (0.105)	-0.036 (0.105)	-0.020 (0.136)	-0.020 (0.136)	-0.074 (0.176)	-0.074 (0.176)
Locality: South	-0.175 (0.142)	-0.175 (0.142)	-0.177 (0.142)	-0.177 (0.142)	-0.153 (0.168)	-0.153 (0.168)	-0.210 (0.265)	-0.210 (0.265)
Locality: West Bank	-0.021 (0.148)	-0.021 (0.148)	-0.022 (0.148)	-0.022 (0.148)	-0.073 (0.161)	-0.073 (0.161)	0.088 (0.326)	0.088 (0.326)
Topic (Military)	-0.382*** (0.058)	-0.382*** (0.058)	-0.384*** (0.059)	-0.384*** (0.059)	-0.731*** (0.087)	-0.731*** (0.087)	-0.047 (0.077)	-0.047 (0.077)
Block (opp.)	0.162 (0.085)	0.162 (0.085)	0.153 (0.086)	0.153 (0.086)				
Attack $\times$ Ideology	0.103** (0.037)	0.070* (0.036)	0.085* (0.037)	0.096** (0.036)	0.111 (0.067)	0.086 (0.064)	0.090* (0.045)	0.060 (0.044)
Attack $\times$ Age	-0.016 (0.029)	-0.033 (0.031)	-0.083** (0.030)	0.033 (0.030)	-0.112* (0.044)	-0.015 (0.047)	0.077* (0.037)	-0.037 (0.041)
Attack $\times$ Male	-0.047 (0.084)	0.114 (0.083)	0.008 (0.083)	0.030 (0.084)	0.069 (0.125)	0.287* (0.127)	-0.156 (0.110)	-0.048 (0.110)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Traditional	0.300* (0.124)	0.038 (0.122)	0.276* (0.123)	0.102 (0.125)	0.424* (0.197)	-0.202 (0.194)	0.257 (0.168)	0.113 (0.162)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Religious	0.458** (0.152)	0.035 (0.152)	0.443** (0.156)	0.055 (0.150)	0.557** (0.196)	-0.159 (0.191)	0.371 (0.298)	0.357 (0.327)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.409** (0.152)	0.288 (0.152)	0.404** (0.156)	0.352* (0.151)	0.461* (0.209)	0.112 (0.204)	0.513* (0.257)	0.574* (0.271)
Attack $\times$ Locality: North	0.157 (0.218)	0.062 (0.213)	0.096 (0.220)	0.159 (0.212)	0.182 (0.355)	0.154 (0.299)	0.163 (0.310)	-0.094 (0.329)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Haifa	0.097 (0.177)	-0.065 (0.179)	0.200 (0.178)	-0.078 (0.178)	0.329 (0.264)	-0.321 (0.266)	0.078 (0.257)	0.099 (0.283)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Center	0.007 (0.152)	-0.106 (0.157)	-0.009 (0.152)	-0.019 (0.156)	0.120 (0.190)	-0.022 (0.204)	0.074 (0.241)	-0.097 (0.266)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Tel Aviv	-0.051 (0.153)	-0.179 (0.161)	-0.003 (0.156)	-0.158 (0.159)	0.062 (0.196)	-0.281 (0.213)	-0.063 (0.246)	-0.126 (0.274)
Attack $\times$ Locality: South	0.198 (0.193)	0.177 (0.196)	0.204 (0.197)	0.233 (0.192)	0.064 (0.238)	0.073 (0.239)	0.477 (0.327)	0.296 (0.352)
Attack $\times$ Locality: West Bank	0.098 (0.210)	-0.069 (0.211)	0.001 (0.212)	0.099 (0.210)	0.116 (0.240)	-0.021 (0.235)	0.219 (0.416)	-0.252 (0.449)
Attack $\times$ Topic (Military)	-0.039 (0.083)	-0.100 (0.083)	-0.206* (0.083)	0.082 (0.084)	-0.193 (0.123)	0.051 (0.127)	0.043 (0.109)	-0.281* (0.110)
Attack $\times$ Block (opp.)	0.348** (0.118)	-0.236* (0.114)	0.133 (0.117)	-0.020 (0.116)				
N	2086	2093	2086	2068	967	962	1106	1119
R^2	0.136	0.097	0.121	0.118	0.197	0.174	0.082	0.054

Each column is a pairwise Lin (2013) regression of the standardized outcome on a single attack arm relative to control (HC2 robust standard errors), reproducing the matching coefficient-plot estimate. Full: full sample; In-/Out-party: pooled attack-congruence contrasts; GovSup/OppSup: government / opposition supporters. Covariates are mean-centered; rows below the treatment effect are covariate main effects and treatment *times* covariate interactions. Full-sample and congruence columns include a block fixed effect; subgroup columns omit it (constant within subgroup).

Table A21: Extension study, evaluation experiment: effects on perceived pro-government slant (Lin regressions with treatment $\times$ covariate interactions).

	Full: Gov	Full: Opp	In-party	Out-party	GovSup: Gov	GovSup: Opp	OppSup: Gov	OppSup: Opp
Attack (vs. control)	-0.114* (0.045)	0.171*** (0.047)	0.094* (0.046)	-0.030 (0.046)	0.002 (0.067)	0.158* (0.069)	-0.202** (0.062)	0.181** (0.063)
Ideology	-0.000 (0.028)	-0.000 (0.028)	-0.001 (0.028)	-0.001 (0.028)	0.027 (0.044)	0.027 (0.044)	-0.014 (0.036)	-0.014 (0.036)
Age	0.034 (0.022)	0.034 (0.022)	0.035 (0.022)	0.035 (0.022)	-0.019 (0.029)	-0.019 (0.029)	0.092** (0.032)	0.092** (0.032)
Male	-0.027 (0.064)	-0.027 (0.064)	-0.034 (0.064)	-0.034 (0.064)	-0.206* (0.089)	-0.206* (0.089)	0.121 (0.093)	0.121 (0.093)
Religiosity: Traditional	0.066 (0.093)	0.066 (0.093)	0.075 (0.094)	0.075 (0.094)	0.117 (0.135)	0.117 (0.135)	0.001 (0.136)	0.001 (0.136)
Religiosity: Religious	-0.145 (0.114)	-0.145 (0.114)	-0.123 (0.114)	-0.123 (0.114)	-0.169 (0.130)	-0.169 (0.130)	0.199 (0.394)	0.199 (0.394)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	-0.182 (0.113)	-0.182 (0.113)	-0.160 (0.113)	-0.160 (0.113)	-0.226 (0.139)	-0.226 (0.139)	-0.077 (0.222)	-0.077 (0.222)
Locality: North	0.156 (0.155)	0.156 (0.155)	0.158 (0.155)	0.158 (0.155)	0.160 (0.202)	0.160 (0.202)	0.105 (0.269)	0.105 (0.269)
Locality: Haifa	-0.130 (0.120)	-0.130 (0.120)	-0.132 (0.120)	-0.132 (0.120)	-0.253 (0.144)	-0.253 (0.144)	-0.154 (0.214)	-0.154 (0.214)
Locality: Center	0.118 (0.111)	0.118 (0.111)	0.112 (0.111)	0.112 (0.111)	0.140 (0.134)	0.140 (0.134)	0.017 (0.209)	0.017 (0.209)
Locality: Tel Aviv	0.051 (0.113)	0.051 (0.113)	0.041 (0.113)	0.041 (0.113)	0.175 (0.147)	0.175 (0.147)	-0.120 (0.204)	-0.120 (0.204)
Locality: South	0.106 (0.155)	0.106 (0.155)	0.111 (0.155)	0.111 (0.155)	0.250 (0.184)	0.250 (0.184)	-0.179 (0.291)	-0.179 (0.291)
Locality: West Bank	0.154 (0.164)	0.154 (0.164)	0.154 (0.164)	0.154 (0.164)	0.157 (0.167)	0.157 (0.167)	0.115 (0.487)	0.115 (0.487)
Topic (Military)	0.257*** (0.063)	0.257*** (0.063)	0.258*** (0.064)	0.258*** (0.064)	0.049 (0.089)	0.049 (0.089)	0.430*** (0.090)	0.430*** (0.090)
Block (opp.)	0.042 (0.097)	0.042 (0.097)	0.067 (0.098)	0.067 (0.098)				
Attack $\times$ Ideology	-0.040 (0.039)	-0.037 (0.039)	-0.045 (0.040)	-0.024 (0.039)	-0.040 (0.073)	0.008 (0.067)	-0.021 (0.049)	-0.052 (0.049)
Attack $\times$ Age	-0.049 (0.032)	-0.012 (0.033)	-0.027 (0.033)	-0.032 (0.032)	-0.048 (0.047)	-0.007 (0.047)	-0.068 (0.044)	-0.024 (0.046)
Attack $\times$ Male	0.037 (0.092)	-0.057 (0.093)	0.003 (0.093)	-0.005 (0.092)	0.062 (0.138)	-0.033 (0.141)	-0.031 (0.128)	-0.089 (0.127)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Traditional	-0.013 (0.133)	-0.105 (0.140)	-0.147 (0.138)	0.005 (0.136)	-0.195 (0.209)	-0.097 (0.214)	0.120 (0.186)	-0.129 (0.192)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Religious	0.049 (0.159)	-0.092 (0.165)	-0.092 (0.163)	0.022 (0.164)	0.026 (0.204)	0.063 (0.207)	-0.331 (0.424)	-0.673 (0.423)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.001 (0.170)	-0.019 (0.173)	-0.077 (0.178)	0.011 (0.169)	-0.134 (0.223)	-0.059 (0.218)	0.081 (0.321)	0.094 (0.345)
Attack $\times$ Locality: North	-0.055 (0.231)	0.125 (0.241)	0.227 (0.245)	-0.096 (0.234)	-0.092 (0.332)	-0.155 (0.314)	0.077 (0.385)	0.432 (0.402)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Haifa	0.236 (0.180)	0.252 (0.193)	0.221 (0.183)	0.276 (0.192)	0.348 (0.237)	0.489 (0.258)	0.331 (0.322)	0.265 (0.328)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Center	-0.093 (0.161)	-0.028 (0.179)	-0.063 (0.165)	-0.036 (0.177)	-0.300 (0.197)	-0.142 (0.226)	0.196 (0.311)	0.180 (0.315)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Tel Aviv	0.068 (0.166)	0.045 (0.186)	0.095 (0.174)	0.017 (0.180)	0.120 (0.225)	-0.028 (0.247)	0.224 (0.304)	0.225 (0.319)
Attack $\times$ Locality: South	-0.007 (0.215)	-0.130 (0.224)	-0.010 (0.216)	-0.123 (0.223)	-0.082 (0.268)	-0.315 (0.277)	0.298 (0.395)	0.195 (0.385)
Attack $\times$ Locality: West Bank	-0.055 (0.234)	-0.035 (0.242)	-0.061 (0.236)	-0.034 (0.240)	-0.075 (0.264)	-0.100 (0.277)	0.162 (0.576)	0.038 (0.587)
Attack $\times$ Topic (Military)	-0.005 (0.091)	0.258** (0.093)	0.249** (0.092)	-0.003 (0.092)	0.128 (0.133)	0.139 (0.138)	-0.122 (0.125)	0.327** (0.126)
Attack $\times$ Block (opp.)	-0.088 (0.131)	0.042 (0.134)	0.201 (0.135)	-0.327* (0.131)				
N	1899	1922	1906	1891	872	876	1015	1034
R^2	0.036	0.066	0.071	0.039	0.051	0.051	0.069	0.134

Each column is a pairwise Lin (2013) regression of the standardized outcome on a single attack arm relative to control (HC2 robust standard errors), reproducing the matching coefficient-plot estimate. Full: full sample; In-/Out-party: pooled attack-congruence contrasts; GovSup/OppSup: government / opposition supporters. Covariates are mean-centered; rows below the treatment effect are covariate main effects and treatment *times* covariate interactions. Full-sample and congruence columns include a block fixed effect; subgroup columns omit it (constant within subgroup).

Table A22: Extension study, evaluation experiment: effects on perceived pro-opposition slant (Lin regressions with treatment $\times$ covariate interactions).

	Full: Gov	Full: Opp	In-party	Out-party	GovSup: Gov	GovSup: Opp	OppSup: Gov	OppSup: Opp
Attack (vs. control)	-0.083* (0.039)	-0.200*** (0.038)	-0.087* (0.039)	-0.202*** (0.039)	-0.074 (0.062)	-0.320*** (0.062)	-0.101* (0.048)	-0.101* (0.047)
Ideology	-0.014 (0.024)	-0.014 (0.024)	-0.015 (0.024)	-0.015 (0.024)	0.030 (0.045)	0.030 (0.045)	-0.043 (0.028)	-0.043 (0.028)
Age	0.016 (0.019)	0.016 (0.019)	0.015 (0.019)	0.015 (0.019)	0.011 (0.028)	0.011 (0.028)	0.029 (0.024)	0.029 (0.024)
Male	0.101 (0.054)	0.101 (0.054)	0.101 (0.055)	0.101 (0.055)	0.208* (0.084)	0.208* (0.084)	0.002 (0.069)	0.002 (0.069)
Religiosity: Traditional	0.150 (0.079)	0.150 (0.079)	0.145 (0.080)	0.145 (0.080)	0.146 (0.129)	0.146 (0.129)	0.081 (0.105)	0.081 (0.105)
Religiosity: Religious	-0.069 (0.103)	-0.069 (0.103)	-0.073 (0.103)	-0.073 (0.103)	-0.033 (0.129)	-0.033 (0.129)	-0.447** (0.160)	-0.447** (0.160)
Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	0.236* (0.103)	0.236* (0.103)	0.234* (0.103)	0.234* (0.103)	0.185 (0.135)	0.185 (0.135)	0.374 (0.195)	0.374 (0.195)
Locality: North	-0.162 (0.134)	-0.162 (0.134)	-0.161 (0.134)	-0.161 (0.134)	-0.003 (0.193)	-0.003 (0.193)	-0.394* (0.198)	-0.394* (0.198)
Locality: Haifa	-0.154 (0.118)	-0.154 (0.118)	-0.157 (0.118)	-0.157 (0.118)	-0.087 (0.185)	-0.087 (0.185)	-0.247 (0.184)	-0.247 (0.184)
Locality: Center	-0.206* (0.104)	-0.206* (0.104)	-0.199 (0.104)	-0.199 (0.104)	-0.178 (0.131)	-0.178 (0.131)	-0.260 (0.177)	-0.260 (0.177)
Locality: Tel Aviv	-0.260* (0.105)	-0.260* (0.105)	-0.268* (0.105)	-0.268* (0.105)	-0.308* (0.138)	-0.308* (0.138)	-0.318 (0.177)	-0.318 (0.177)
Locality: South	-0.274* (0.134)	-0.274* (0.134)	-0.274* (0.134)	-0.274* (0.134)	-0.212 (0.161)	-0.212 (0.161)	-0.490* (0.225)	-0.490* (0.225)
Locality: West Bank	-0.018 (0.146)	-0.018 (0.146)	-0.018 (0.146)	-0.018 (0.146)	-0.048 (0.161)	-0.048 (0.161)	0.092 (0.326)	0.092 (0.326)
Topic (Military)	0.940*** (0.054)	0.940*** (0.054)	0.949*** (0.054)	0.949*** (0.054)	1.151*** (0.085)	1.151*** (0.085)	0.727*** (0.068)	0.727*** (0.068)
Block (opp.)	-0.335*** (0.079)	-0.335*** (0.079)	-0.336*** (0.079)	-0.336*** (0.079)				
Attack $\times$ Ideology	-0.056 (0.033)	-0.033 (0.032)	-0.038 (0.032)	-0.054 (0.033)	-0.067 (0.068)	-0.035 (0.065)	-0.044 (0.039)	-0.018 (0.037)
Attack $\times$ Age	-0.029 (0.027)	-0.032 (0.027)	-0.003 (0.027)	-0.057* (0.027)	-0.008 (0.043)	-0.060 (0.042)	-0.059 (0.034)	-0.014 (0.034)
Attack $\times$ Male	-0.050 (0.079)	-0.132 (0.076)	-0.069 (0.077)	-0.101 (0.078)	-0.123 (0.126)	-0.287* (0.124)	0.018 (0.099)	-0.014 (0.095)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Traditional	-0.165 (0.115)	-0.117 (0.111)	-0.133 (0.115)	-0.152 (0.111)	-0.207 (0.198)	-0.211 (0.181)	-0.076 (0.144)	0.018 (0.145)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Religious	-0.035 (0.145)	0.172 (0.143)	0.001 (0.145)	0.139 (0.145)	-0.126 (0.198)	0.088 (0.184)	0.435 (0.243)	0.523* (0.235)
Attack $\times$ Religiosity: Ultra-Orthodox	-0.032 (0.153)	-0.210 (0.149)	-0.050 (0.155)	-0.202 (0.150)	-0.026 (0.209)	-0.245 (0.195)	-0.147 (0.287)	-0.375 (0.283)
Attack $\times$ Locality: North	0.351 (0.201)	0.185 (0.196)	0.355 (0.201)	0.178 (0.197)	0.237 (0.296)	-0.127 (0.278)	0.550 (0.293)	0.569 (0.296)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Haifa	0.134 (0.166)	0.235 (0.170)	0.190 (0.170)	0.168 (0.168)	0.037 (0.264)	0.184 (0.254)	0.254 (0.257)	0.293 (0.269)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Center	0.277 (0.151)	0.279 (0.156)	0.304* (0.152)	0.213 (0.157)	0.288 (0.200)	0.221 (0.211)	0.296 (0.250)	0.335 (0.257)
Attack $\times$ Locality: Tel Aviv	0.308* (0.155)	0.336* (0.160)	0.238 (0.156)	0.395* (0.160)	0.208 (0.214)	0.480* (0.217)	0.457 (0.254)	0.326 (0.264)
Attack $\times$ Locality: South	0.427* (0.184)	0.288 (0.193)	0.324 (0.185)	0.373 (0.194)	0.367 (0.231)	0.289 (0.253)	0.631* (0.305)	0.404 (0.304)
Attack $\times$ Locality: West Bank	0.157 (0.203)	0.091 (0.211)	0.150 (0.206)	0.092 (0.210)	0.143 (0.233)	0.093 (0.251)	0.092 (0.414)	0.070 (0.422)
Attack $\times$ Topic (Military)	-0.109 (0.078)	-0.363*** (0.076)	-0.186* (0.077)	-0.316*** (0.077)	-0.075 (0.126)	-0.503*** (0.123)	-0.109 (0.097)	-0.209* (0.095)
Attack $\times$ Block (opp.)	0.026 (0.111)	0.229* (0.106)	-0.025 (0.112)	0.290** (0.108)				
N	1911	1929	1922	1893	898	893	1000	1024
R^2	0.283	0.237	0.274	0.249	0.297	0.258	0.213	0.192

Each column is a pairwise Lin (2013) regression of the standardized outcome on a single attack arm relative to control (HC2 robust standard errors), reproducing the matching coefficient-plot estimate. Full: full sample; In-/Out-party: pooled attack-congruence contrasts; GovSup/OppSup: government / opposition supporters. Covariates are mean-centered; rows below the treatment effect are covariate main effects and treatment *times* covariate interactions. Full-sample and congruence columns include a block fixed effect; subgroup columns omit it (constant within subgroup).

Table A23: Effects of Attacks on Article Evaluation

	Knlg Retention	Knlg Retention	Knlg Retention	Article Eval	Article Eval	Article Eval	Perceive Progrov	Perceive Progrov	Perceive Progrov	Perceive Proopp	Perceive Proopp	Perceive Proopp
z_treat2	-0.086*	-0.091	-0.053	-0.021	-0.229***	0.079+	-0.110**	-0.102	-0.148**	-0.029	0.206**	-0.152***
	(0.037)	(0.064)	(0.046)	(0.037)	(0.066)	(0.046)	(0.038)	(0.063)	(0.050)	(0.036)	(0.063)	(0.045)
z_topic2Military_c	0.351***	0.344***	0.332***	-0.096+	-0.294**	0.030	0.355***	0.286**	0.411***	0.739***	0.959***	0.603***
	(0.051)	(0.090)	(0.064)	(0.052)	(0.094)	(0.063)	(0.053)	(0.088)	(0.070)	(0.049)	(0.087)	(0.062)
x_ideology_c	0.020	-0.016	-0.012	0.029	-0.037	0.030	-0.020	0.043	-0.035	-0.067***	-0.067	-0.025
	(0.020)	(0.046)	(0.026)	(0.020)	(0.047)	(0.025)	(0.021)	(0.047)	(0.028)	(0.019)	(0.045)	(0.025)
x_age_c	0.044**	0.028	0.050*	0.019	-0.012	0.023	0.005	-0.035	0.035	-0.018	0.012	-0.036+
	(0.017)	(0.029)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.031)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.029)	(0.024)	(0.016)	(0.029)	(0.020)
x_gender_c	-0.085	-0.181*	-0.036	0.035	0.165+	-0.068	0.147**	0.192*	0.131+	0.060	0.051	0.092
	(0.052)	(0.089)	(0.065)	(0.052)	(0.095)	(0.064)	(0.053)	(0.090)	(0.071)	(0.050)	(0.086)	(0.062)
x_locality_c	0.001	0.026	-0.024	-0.011	-0.015	-0.010	0.013	-0.019	0.028	0.030+	0.001	0.047*
	(0.017)	(0.027)	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.027)	(0.020)	(0.016)	(0.025)	(0.023)	(0.015)	(0.026)	(0.019)
x_religiosity_c	-0.032	0.071	-0.118*	-0.159***	-0.199***	-0.067	-0.041	-0.083	0.000	0.089**	0.068	0.043
	(0.034)	(0.050)	(0.055)	(0.036)	(0.055)	(0.056)	(0.034)	(0.050)	(0.055)	(0.034)	(0.049)	(0.054)
z_treat2 × z_topic2Military_c	-0.032	0.158	-0.181+	-0.193**	-0.357**	-0.132	-0.152*	-0.392**	-0.026	-0.080	0.166	-0.175*
	(0.075)	(0.128)	(0.093)	(0.074)	(0.131)	(0.092)	(0.076)	(0.126)	(0.099)	(0.072)	(0.126)	(0.089)
z_treat2 × x_ideology_c	0.044	-0.010	0.086*	0.080**	0.052	0.028	-0.018	0.036	-0.058	-0.076**	0.059	-0.073*
	(0.029)	(0.068)	(0.037)	(0.029)	(0.071)	(0.037)	(0.030)	(0.071)	(0.041)	(0.028)	(0.067)	(0.036)
z_treat2 × x_age_c	0.020	0.000	0.025	0.033	-0.041	0.074*	-0.008	-0.011	-0.013	0.007	0.033	0.004
	(0.025)	(0.043)	(0.030)	(0.025)	(0.044)	(0.029)	(0.025)	(0.041)	(0.033)	(0.024)	(0.043)	(0.029)
z_treat2 × x_gender_c	0.032	0.164	-0.036	-0.042	-0.332*	0.103	0.037	-0.173	0.136	-0.024	0.013	-0.023
	(0.075)	(0.127)	(0.094)	(0.076)	(0.132)	(0.093)	(0.078)	(0.129)	(0.101)	(0.074)	(0.128)	(0.091)
z_treat2 × x_locality_c	-0.016	-0.041	0.019	0.018	0.013	0.019	-0.009	0.035	-0.037	-0.021	0.035	-0.026
	(0.024)	(0.038)	(0.032)	(0.024)	(0.040)	(0.030)	(0.024)	(0.036)	(0.033)	(0.023)	(0.038)	(0.029)
z_treat2 × x_religiosity_c	0.058	-0.070	0.211**	-0.010	0.070	-0.066	0.040	0.022	-0.004	0.095+	0.081	0.015
	(0.051)	(0.073)	(0.081)	(0.052)	(0.076)	(0.082)	(0.051)	(0.075)	(0.082)	(0.050)	(0.072)	(0.083)
Num.Obs.	2869	1032	1696	2817	1015	1665	2653	961	1559	2662	976	1557
R2	0.044	0.053	0.041	0.058	0.085	0.031	0.033	0.032	0.061	0.171	0.230	0.111
RMSE	0.99	1.02	0.94	0.98	1.03	0.92	0.98	0.97	0.98	0.93	0.97	0.87
Subgroup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup

Each regression estimates the effects of the government attack treatment on a different measure of respondents' evaluation of an article.

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table A24: Effects of Exposure to Media Attack Article on Political Attitudes and Preferences

	Perceived Backsliding	Perceived Backsliding	Perceived Backsliding	Outparty Soc Dis	Outparty Soc Dis	Outparty Soc Dis	Trust Gov	Trust Gov	Trust Gov	Trust Opp	Trust Opp	Trust Opp
z_treat3	0.046 (0.032)	0.010 (0.045)	0.096** (0.034)	-0.103** (0.040)	-0.042 (0.066)	-0.144** (0.049)	-0.019 (0.034)	0.047 (0.049)	-0.088** (0.032)	0.057 (0.039)	0.024 (0.063)	0.096+ (0.050)
x_ideology_c	0.291*** (0.019)	0.031 (0.036)	0.173*** (0.020)	0.020 (0.024)	0.174** (0.060)	-0.108*** (0.030)	-0.276*** (0.019)	-0.044 (0.036)	-0.105*** (0.017)	0.141*** (0.022)	0.015 (0.046)	0.092** (0.029)
x_age_c	0.032* (0.015)	-0.070*** (0.021)	0.099*** (0.016)	-0.022 (0.019)	-0.021 (0.032)	-0.028 (0.023)	0.002 (0.016)	0.085*** (0.021)	-0.051*** (0.015)	0.045* (0.018)	-0.082** (0.018)	0.117*** (0.022)
x_gender_c	0.082+ (0.048)	0.146* (0.065)	0.003 (0.051)	-0.022 (0.058)	-0.165+ (0.099)	0.050 (0.071)	-0.012 (0.050)	-0.069 (0.066)	0.075 (0.048)	0.057 (0.055)	0.210* (0.099)	-0.048 (0.070)
x_locality_c	0.017 (0.015)	0.029 (0.019)	0.001 (0.017)	-0.015 (0.019)	-0.008 (0.030)	-0.028 (0.024)	0.019 (0.016)	0.018 (0.018)	0.023 (0.015)	0.022 (0.017)	0.010 (0.025)	0.038+ (0.022)
x_religiosity_c	-0.325*** (0.032)	-0.075* (0.038)	-0.226*** (0.050)	-0.026 (0.040)	-0.073 (0.061)	0.172** (0.061)	0.273*** (0.034)	-0.028 (0.040)	0.117** (0.043)	-0.159*** (0.035)	-0.061 (0.050)	-0.164** (0.056)
z_treat3 × x_ideology_c	0.021 (0.025)	0.089+ (0.051)	-0.013 (0.028)	-0.013 (0.032)	-0.012 (0.078)	0.034 (0.042)	-0.033 (0.027)	-0.076 (0.055)	0.020 (0.023)	0.028 (0.031)	0.009 (0.067)	0.043 (0.043)
z_treat3 × x_age_c	-0.008 (0.021)	0.038 (0.030)	-0.026 (0.022)	0.014 (0.026)	0.046 (0.043)	0.010 (0.032)	0.017 (0.023)	-0.017 (0.032)	0.005 (0.020)	-0.007 (0.025)	-0.001 (0.039)	-0.001 (0.033)
z_treat3 × x_gender_c	0.064 (0.066)	0.156+ (0.091)	0.032 (0.071)	-0.074 (0.081)	0.059 (0.134)	-0.154 (0.100)	0.041 (0.070)	0.065 (0.098)	-0.034 (0.064)	-0.052 (0.079)	-0.068 (0.128)	-0.065 (0.102)
z_treat3 × x_locality_c	-0.006 (0.020)	0.008 (0.026)	-0.010 (0.023)	0.023 (0.026)	0.052 (0.040)	0.011 (0.034)	-0.035 (0.023)	-0.056* (0.028)	-0.018 (0.021)	0.015 (0.024)	0.040 (0.037)	-0.011 (0.032)
z_treat3 × x_religiosity_c	-0.054 (0.045)	-0.082 (0.053)	-0.017 (0.071)	0.038 (0.056)	-0.059 (0.081)	0.109 (0.087)	0.036 (0.049)	0.035 (0.059)	0.024 (0.061)	-0.056 (0.051)	-0.110 (0.070)	-0.012 (0.083)
Num.Obs.	2492	904	1481	2489	902	1481	2492	906	1478	2493	902	1483
R2	0.383	0.082	0.216	0.005	0.048	0.061	0.307	0.046	0.102	0.112	0.042	0.095
RMSE	0.80	0.67	0.66	0.98	0.98	0.93	0.85	0.73	0.60	0.97	0.94	0.95
Subgroup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup	Pooled	Gov Sup	Opp Sup

Each regression estimates the effects of the government attack treatment on a different attitudinal outcome.

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

G Pre-Analysis Plan

Consequences of Media Attacks: Evidence from Israel (#231711)

Author(s)

This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has 2 authors.

Pre-registered on: 2025/06/03 - 11:20 AM (PT)

1) Have any data been collected for this study already?

No, no data have been collected for this study yet.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?

STUDY 1: How does exposure to government attacks on journalists affect selection to consume media produced by those journalists?

STUDY 2: How does exposure to government attacks on journalists affect retention of factual information, as well as perceptions of quality and bias of media produced by those journalists?

STUDY 3: How does exposure to government attacks on journalists affect trust in media, trust in government institutions, partisan animosity, and perceptions of democratic backsliding?

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.

STUDY 1: The dependent variable is a binary indicator recording whether or not respondents select to read an article by a fictitious journalist named Oren Faran.

STUDY 2: The first dependent variable measures factual information retention. This is measured with three multiple choice questions (on a 0-3 scale) designed to capture objective information from each article. This will be measured as an index.

The second dependent variable is perceptions of media quality. This is measured as an index constructed from the following multiple choice question: To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements? (on a 0-100 scale) a. This article provides objective information and facts; b. The article I read adheres to the highest standard of journalism; c. I learned new information from the article I just read; d. I would share this article with my friends and family.

The third dependent variable captures perceptions of media bias. This is measured with the following multiple choice question: To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements? (on a 0-100 scale) a. The article I read is politically biased in favor of the government; b. The article I read is politically biased in favor of the opposition.

STUDY 3: The first dependent variable measures trust in media and political coalitions with the following multiple choice question: On a scale of 0-100 how much you personally trust each of the following: a. The government; b. The opposition; c. Channel 14; d. Kan 11.

The second dependent variable measures perceptions of democratic backsliding as an index with the following multiple choice question: How much do you agree or disagree with the following statements? (on a 0-100 scale). a. The independence of the Israeli civil service is currently under threat; b. Freedom of the press is currently under threat in Israel; c. Israeli democracy is currently under threat.

The third dependent variable measures partisan animosity as an index with the following multiple choice question: Would you be comfortable with someone who strongly supports [Likud / Opposition] in the following roles? (0 = Not at all comfortable, 100 = Completely comfortable): a. As a close friend; b. As your child's teacher; c. As your boss or manager; d. As a romantic partner of your child; e. As a government official making decisions that affect your life

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?

STUDY 1: There are two main conditions. Respondents assigned to treatment will read that Oren Faran has been attacked by the government, and respondents assigned to control will not have information about whether or not Oren Faran has been attacked by the government. We further randomize the topic of the articles that respondents read to focus on a polarizing or non-polarizing topic.

STUDY 2: There are two main conditions. Respondents assigned to treatment will be informed that the author of the article to which they will be exposed has been attacked by the Israeli government. Respondents in the control group will not receive this information. We further randomize the topic of the article that respondents read to focus on a polarizing or non-polarizing topic.

STUDY 3: There are two conditions. Respondents assigned to treatment will read a real article about government attacks on journalists. Respondents assigned to control will read an article about recent expeditions to the moon.

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.

We will measure average treatment effects using OLS regression. Our main specifications will adjust for pre-treatment covariates (ideology, age, gender, locality, religiosity, and experiment topic when relevant) using the Lin (2013) estimator. We will report robust standard errors. Note that for all indices we will report the aggregated index as well as the individual items.

For studies 1 and 2 we focus on six primary analyses: 1) the full sample, 2) full sample with polarizing topic, 3) full sample with non-polarizing topic, 4) government supporters only, 5) opposition supporters only, and 6) independents only.

For study 3, we focus on four primary analyses: 1) the full sample, 2) government supporters only, 3) opposition supporters only, and 4) independents only.

For all three studies, in secondary analyses, we will also examine treatment effects by party and experimental topic.

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.

NA

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.

2500 respondents

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)

Nothing else to pre-register.

H Pre-Analysis Plan: Extension Study

Media Attacks (Extension) (#302893)

Author(s)

This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has 2 authors.

Pre-registered on:

2026/07/21 05:04 (PT)

1) Have any data been collected for this study already?

No, no data have been collected for this study yet.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?

STUDY 1: How does exposure to government/opposition attacks on journalists affect selection to consume media produced by those journalists?

STUDY 2: How does exposure to government/opposition attacks on journalists affect retention of factual information, as well as perceptions of quality and bias of media produced by those journalists?

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.

STUDY 1: The outcome is a binary indicator recording whether or not respondents select to read an article by a fictitious journalist named Oren Faran.

STUDY 2: The first outcome measures factual information retention. This is measured with three multiple-choice questions (on a 0-3 scale) designed to capture objective information from each article. This will be measured as an index.

The second outcome is perceptions of media quality. This is measured as an index constructed from the following multiple-choice question: To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements? (on a 0-100 scale) a. This article provides objective information and facts; b. The article I read adheres to the highest standard of journalism; c. I learned new information from the article I just read; d. I would share this article with my friends and family.

The third outcome captures perceptions of media bias. This is measured with the following multiple-choice question: To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements? (on a 0-100 scale) a. The article I read is politically biased in favor of the government; b. The article I read is politically biased in favor of the opposition.

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?

STUDY 1: There are three main conditions. Respondents assigned to treatment will read that Oren Faran has been attacked by either the government or the opposition, and respondents assigned to control will not have information about whether or not Oren Faran has been attacked by political figures. We further randomize the topic of the articles that respondents read to focus on a polarizing or non-polarizing topic.

STUDY 2: There are three main conditions. Respondents assigned to treatment will be informed that the author of the article to which they will be exposed has been attacked by the Israeli government or opposition. Respondents in the control group will not receive this information. We further randomize the topic of the article that respondents read to focus on a polarizing or non-polarizing topic.

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.

We will estimate average treatment effects using OLS. Our main specifications will adjust for pre-treatment covariates (ideology, age, gender, locality, religiosity, and experiment topic) using the Lin (2013) estimator. We will report robust standard errors. Note that for all indices we will report the aggregated index as well as the individual items.

We focus on the following estimates: 1) effects of government attacks on the full sample, 2) effects of opposition attacks on the full sample, 3) effects of in-party attacks against outparties, 4) effects of outparties' attacks against the in-parties, 5) effects of government and opposition attacks among government supporters, and 6) effects of government and opposition attacks among opposition supporters

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.

NA

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.

3000 respondents

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)

NA